

UNIVERSITY OF ST. MICHAEL'S COLLEGE

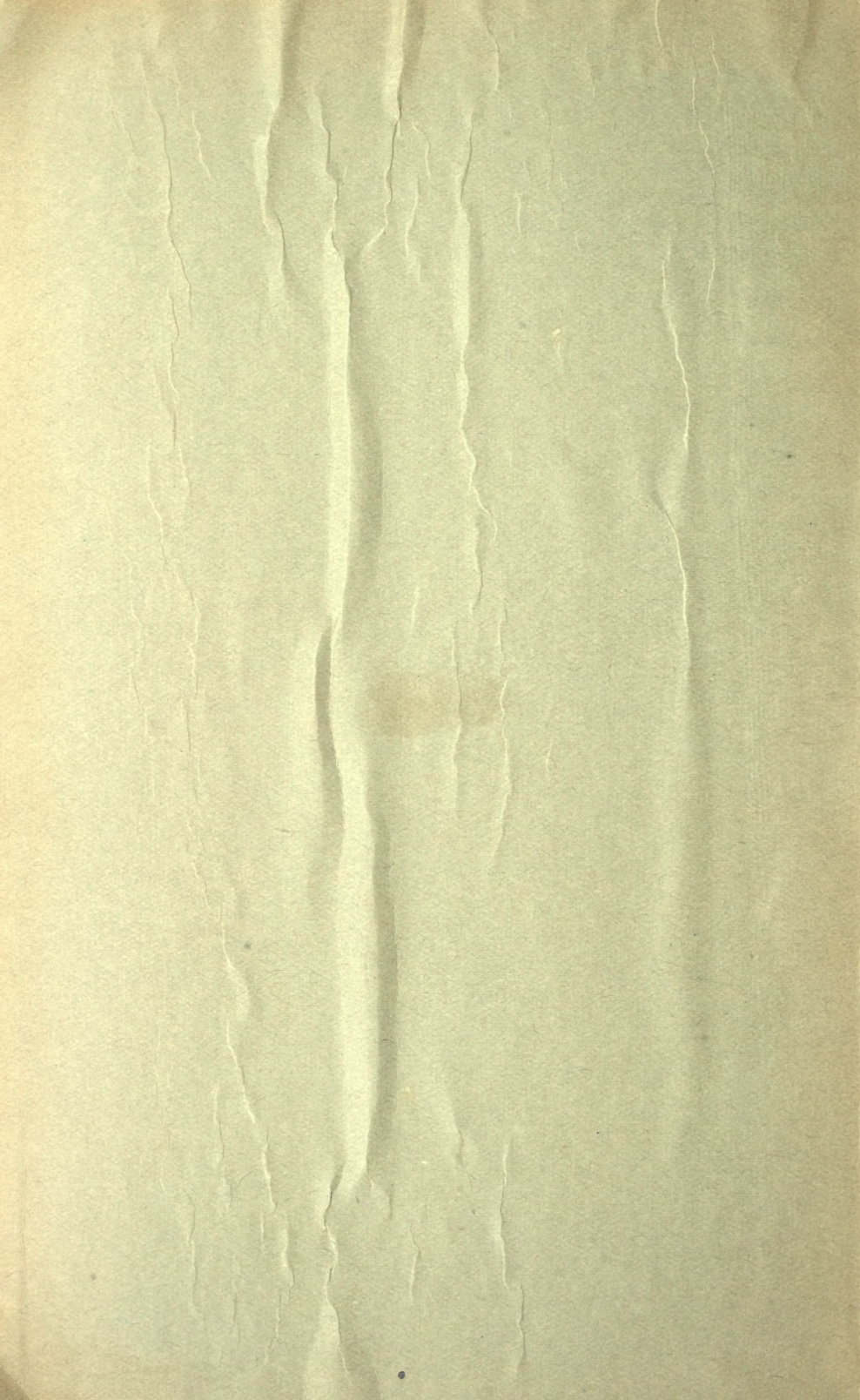


3 1761 06113885 5

THE EASTER SONG OF SEDULIUS



SIGERSON



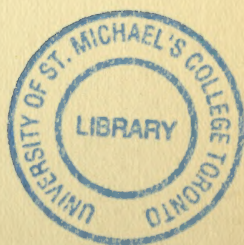


To G. L. M.

from B. N. M.

Z15

THE EASTER SONG



THE EASTER SONG
BEING
THE FIRST EPIC OF
CHRISTENDOM

BY
SEDULIUS *"flourished" 423 AD - 480 AD*

THE FIRST SCHOLAR-SAINT OF ERINN

WITH INTRODUCTION, VERSE-TRANSLATION AND APPENDICES
INCLUDING A SCHEDULE OF MILTON'S "DEBTS"

BY
GEORGE SIGERSON

M.D., M.CH., HON. LITT.D., HON. F.R.C.P.I.
PROFESSOR N.U.I.; PRESIDENT OF HISTORY SOCIETY, U.C.D.;
PRESIDENT OF NATIONAL LITERARY SOCIETY, IRELAND;
MEMBER NATIONAL ACADEMY, IRELAND; MEMBER OF LA
SOCIÉTÉ D'ANTHROPOLOGIE, OF LA SOCIÉTÉ CLINIQUE, AND
OF LA SOCIÉTÉ DE PSYCHOLOGIE PHYSIOLOGIQUE DE PARIS

DUBLIN
THE TALBOT PRESS LIMITED
LONDON
T. FISHER UNWIN LIMITED

1922

Printed in Ireland at The Talbot Press, Dublin.

PREFACE

THE Easter Song of Sedulius takes rank as the First Epic of Christendom, and may be regarded as the Morning Hymn of the Christian World. Juvenius, who preceded him, produced but a metrical and amplified version of the text of the New Testament. Sedulius conceived the Great Epic. Beginning with the expulsion of the First of Man from Paradise, and the intrusion of Death because of disobedience, he describes the consequences of the Fall—the darkness of the World illumined by one only hope—and the coming, the sufferings and the sublime triumph of the Redeemer of Mankind.

Few works have been held in so high honour, or have commanded a great audience through so many generations.

Its earliest Editor was a Roman Consul ; an Emperor, Theodosius, declared himself grateful for its dedication ; the First Council of the Church welcomed it with distinguished praise. From its appearance in the middle of the fifth century it became the Christian classic. Before the invention of printing the Scriptoria distributed

innumerable copies, many exquisitely illuminated on vellum. After that epoch, the presses of almost every country of Europe were busy printing it for the Scholars and Colleges of Christendom. Since then over seventy-five editions could be reckoned in 1886, being at the rate of one edition in every five and a half years. There have been many more.

In this work appears the first attempt to present any part of the poem in a modern language.

Chilperic, King of the Franks, paid it the homage of an imitation, in accentual verse. Petrarch, and other true poets acknowledged their peer and crowned him with the noble laurel. Not the least, though not the greatest of his glories is that Milton, adopting his exordium, his style, and many striking passages, so obscured Sedulius with the splendour of alien robes that the great original is forgotten and the creator ignored.

The nationality of Sedulius has been questioned. But by evidence indisputable, it is here shown that he bordered each Book of his Five Books, with a couplet wrought with Irish art, so complex and so fine that his Latin poem may be likened to a toga decorated with a band of interlaced embroidery and not with the *latus clavus* or plain purple stripe of the Roman Senator.

A secret of centuries has been revealed, and Ireland is shown to have produced an Epic Poem—the First of Christendom.

CONTENTS

PREFACE	PAGE V
INTRODUCTION—	
PART I. SEDULIUS: LEARNING IN IRELAND AND ROMANISED GAUL	3
„ II. DRUIDS: SCHOOL AND COLLEGE LIFE IN GAUL	10
„ III. CELTIC SURVIVAL IN ROMANISED GAUL	26
„ IV. CELTIC REVIVAL IN GAUL, ITS EMPEROR CROWNED WITH CELTIC RITES	34
„ V. GOLDEN AGE OF CHRISTIAN LITERATURE IN GREECE, ROME, AND GAUL	51
„ VI. IRELAND INTERVENES: SEDULIUS WRITES HIS DEDICATION: ITS WISDOM AND KIND WIT	59
„ VII. THE EASTER SONG: ITS PUBLICATION: ITS EDITIONS AND MARVELLOUS POPULARITY	67
„ VIII. THE CHRISTIAN EPIC, A CLASSIC: EDITED BY A ROMAN CONSUL, HONOURED BY EMPEROR THEODOSIUS, PRAISED BY THE FIRST GENERAL COUNCIL: VISION OF ANGELS SINGING A HYMN OF SEDULIUS	72

THE EASTER SONG—

	PAGE
TO THE READER	79
BOOK I.	81
BOOK II.	96
BOOK III.	111
BOOK IV.	120
BOOK V.	128

APPENDIX I.—THE FIRST AND THE LAST EPIC OF
CHRISTENDOM

147

SECTION I.—

PART I. PARADISE LOST: MILTON'S DEBT TO
SEDULIUS

147

PART II. PARADISE REGAINED: MILTON'S DEBT
TO SEDULIUS

168

SECTION II.—

PART I. MILTON'S DEBT TO BLOSSIUS AEMILIUS
DRACONTIUS

175

PART II. MILTON'S DEBT TO CLAUDIUS MARIUS
VICTOR

177

PART III. MILTON'S DEBT TO ALCIMUS ECDICIUS
AVITUS: BISHOP AND SAINT

186

SECTION III.—

PART I.—MILTON'S DEBT TO VIRGIL

206

APPENDIX II.—IRISH METRICAL CHARACTERISTICS
IN SEDULIAN VERSE

210

APPENDIX III.—CELTIC INFLUENCE ON THE EVOLU-
TION OF RIMED HYMNS

229

APPENDIX IV.—ON CERTAIN SPECIAL SENSES AND
DOMINANT QUALITIES OF NATIONS: TIME-METRIC
AND RIME-METRIC

253

INTRODUCTION

PART I

SEDULIUS: LEARNING IN IRELAND AND ROMANISED GAUL

OISIN, the last bard of Paganism, had been dead for a century, when another poet was born to Erin—the destined author of the first epic of Christendom. The fame of the former has spread over the world, that of the latter has not yet reached his native isle. Who in Ireland reads the works of Sedulius? Few know his name. Yet of all the lights that fell upon her troubled seas, for fifteen hundred years none gave a clearer radiance or shone from a loftier sky.

There are not many details relating to his life, and perhaps so best. He was a man of letters, and we are left to discover in his work that transfusion of the truer and higher self which is so often blurred and distorted in the world-mist. He was by birth one of the "barbarians,"¹ as the Greeks and Romans termed those who resented their yoke, but whom I should name the Free Nations. The oldest Vatican documents, according to Arevalus, tell us briefly that he was a Gentile, a poet, who taught philosophy in Italy; he became a Christian and, by advice

¹ Modern usage confounds "barbarian" with "savage," but wrongly, as it primarily meant foreigner, and the repetition of the syllable—bar-bar—seems (as a French scholar suggested) an attempt to represent the "babble" of a foreign language to classic ears. It must have denoted also splendour of decoration, with gold and ivory, as Ennius makes Andromache use it in her praise of the palace of Priam.

of one Macedonius, he established a school at Athens where he explained the art of poetry, teaching the heroic and other metres. There he wrote his great poem which was given to the world in the year 430.

Let us remember that he went from a cultured people, the artistic beauty of whose antique ornaments in gold, silver, and bronze, corresponds with that of the noble remnants of their ancient literature and laws. He went, a poet from an isle of poets.

Some called him a gentile. Gentile in the ecclesiastical dialect meant one outside the classic world. It would have indicated a native of Ireland, and this should explain why so little is known about him on the Continent. A Roman, Greek, Gaul, Spaniard, Syrian, or African of such eminence would have been registered or recognised.

Poets of less distinction are fully identified. Dicuil, the famous Irish scientific author of the eighth century, calls him "Noster Sedulius," "our own Sedulius."

Trithemius, in the fifteenth century, writes of him more fully :

"Sedulius, a priest," he says, "a Scot by nation, a disciple of Hildebert,¹ Archbishop of the Scots, from youth was a man well disciplined in divine Scriptures, most erudite in secular letters, excelling in poetry and in prose; he left Scotia through love of learning and came to Gaul; then he travelled through Italy and Asia; finally, having departed from the confines of Greece, he shone in the city of Rome distinguished for his admirable instruction."

The writer of this was a German, Johann Tritheim, and therefore he could not be impeached of partiality in

¹ Colgan gives Ailbe as the correct Gaelic name, Germanised by Tritheim, as Hildebert. Irish Christians must have been many and fervent, before Palladius, as they had several Bishops, and as their schools could send forth such missionaries as St. Mansuetus, 1st Bishop of Toul, a century before St. Patrick's arrival.

assigning Sedulius to the Irish Celts. As Benedictine Abbot of Spanheim he took a deep interest in letters ; composing many works himself, he set his monks to copy so busily that he got together over two thousand volumes for a library. Amongst the manuscripts which have perished he probably found old authority for the general belief that Sedulius was an Irishman.

For Scotia, of course, was Erinn, and the term Scot designates a member of the Milesian or Scotic colony which governed the island. Mistakes about its historical meaning are mistakes of modern times. Before the birth of Sedulius Scots had passed from Erinn to Alba, settled there and brought part of it under the sceptre of Cormac—the first Christian Irish king. Alba became “Scotia minor.” There were Picts and Scots in both countries so that, though sea-divided, the peoples were united in blood.

Erinn had singular advantages in those early centuries. Untouched by the invading Romans, who passed like a sand-storm withering all native efforts elsewhere, it was stimulated by accounts of their daring and by rumours of their approach. It had developed an independent culture and become formidable in war.

The last refuge of Druids fleeing from vanquished Gaul and Britain, it was the Forlorn Hope of the Free Nations. There could be no greater testimony to its power, nor any more striking recognition of its prominence than the fact that, as Tacitus says,¹ Agricola had designed its conquest so that Liberty might be extinguished. Surely he saw that the Light of Liberty in Ireland flashed

¹ The version which Tacitus gives of the noble speech of Galgacus shows that, differing from so many modern writers, the Roman understood and did justice to nations, fighting for freedom against his own conquering country. The name of the chief is Gaelic, and it is significant that Derry got its first name, Doire Calgach, from such a person, and that many spoils of Roman coins were found near Derry,—known later as Doire-Columcille, and latterly as Londonderry.

on the darkness of subjugated nations, and disturbed their servile slumbers with dangerous dreams. It is not less significant that he never made the attempt. On the other hand the Scots of Erin joined in common cause with the native peoples of Britain against the Romans. It would be easy to deride the accounts given in the Irish Annals of their warlike expeditions abroad if one were ignorant that Claudian confirms them in classic hexameters.¹ Culture, too, and all acquaintance with Latin literature, could be denied them, if, with other things, one could suppress the fact that St. Jerome, in the fourth century, had to complain of the criticism of an Irish reviewer of his Commentaries.

Latin was of course the official language of Roman Britain; there must have been Celts in Britain, in Scotland, and in Erin, who understood it—interpreters innumerable. There were certainly Latin-speaking prisoner-captives carried over to the Western Isle before those “many thousands” (*tot millia*), whose capture is recorded by the Roman citizen, St. Patrick, when describing his own. They comprised men of different ranks, some skilled in classic learning, not a few Christians. For there were Christians in Erin, not only before the arrival of St. Patrick but even before the coming of his predecessor, St. Palladius, who, in the year 430, was sent by Pope Celestine to “the Scots believing in Christ.” In those days, in the west, wherever Christianity was, there also was Latinity, and it is impossible to believe that, whilst St. Jerome’s work reached Erin, none of the elder classics entered there, though taught in the schools of Britain and of Gaul.

Our traditional habit of looking at ancient Europe

¹ They are more than confirmed by the numerous discoveries in Ireland of buried hoards of ancient Roman coins, captured in foreign forays.

from a Roman standpoint and through a Roman atmosphere has made us unfair to the Free Nations—our forefathers. They could not have conquered the conquerors had they not been apt and intelligent enough to learn from them. Opportunities for acquiring the Latin language and something of its literature were not absent from the Irish Scots, in the youthful days of Sedulius. It is quite probable that he made use of them. There were opportunities also for faring to foreign parts. Numbers of the Attacoti—revolted subjects of the Scots—had taken service under the Eagles and were stationed in Gaul. The Scotie warriors not only invaded Britain but also made incursions into Gaul, so that there were strong currents of intercourse between these countries.¹ Sedulius may have gone to Gaul in the train of Dathi, Erinn's last pagan king and outland conqueror.

One must not lay over much stress upon his name as evidence of his western race, for it is found amongst the Romans, yet here Sedulius may be the latinised form of Siadal. Other and later Irish scholars have adopted or adapted it. With more certainty we can appeal to the intrinsic evidence supplied by his works. There, alike in his prose and in his verse, is shown a fondness for, and a familiarity with the sea which well became an islander. With this goes a delight in woods and streams—all that fine love of natural beauty, which so distinguished the ancient Irish poets. Most of all, I would cite in evidence the remarkable complex peculiarities of verse-structure (detailed fully in Appendix II.) which, being identical with those of early Gaelic verse, would of themselves demonstrate its Irish origin.

The exploits of their countrymen in Britain, when Stilicho blenched before them and the Roman Eagles

¹ In the later part of the sixth century Saxon vessels were at the mouth of the Loire and Britons raided Rennes.

wavered, must have fired many a young noble to whose ears these deeds came glorified by the fervid imagination of the bards. They also would fare forth and seek fame or fortune beyond the narrow seas.

Sedulius, however, was the type and forerunner of another class, numerous and daring enough in after days, whose ambition was higher and more ethereal. Their weapons were those of the intellect. Wherever knowledge had lighted her camp-fire, thither they hastened with passionate zeal until they had warmed their souls at its flame. They were, indeed, always eager to give as well as to receive, as many a work of subtle intelligence can testify.¹ Their camp fires shone like stars in the firmament of Learning, and their island for three centuries was the "University of Europe." All comers from all nations were welcomed, as never elsewhere, to lodging, living, and learning—and all gratuitously, according to the Venerable Beda, a Saxon. Mosheim declares that Ireland held the civilisation of Europe for three centuries.

Imagine the sensations of this young Gentile, when, in the splendid array of an Irish chief, he left behind him his native isle, with its glamour of mist and minstrelsy, and came first upon the square Roman camp—the strong-walled cities—guarded by the stern Power against which his far kindred had so often flung themselves, and not always in vain, but whose literature had always conquered.

In Gaul, there was now a closer union than of old between the Roman and the Celt; for, like avalanche following avalanche, over the Eastern frontier began to come horde after horde of German "barbarians"—the avenging Free Peoples falling upon their degenerate conquerors. Though the ruin of some towns made

¹ Eric of Auxerre writes (eighth century) of "Almost all Ireland, despising the perils of the sea, passes over to our shores, with her crowds of philosophers."

desolate the heart of Jerome,¹ there were still schools where Sedulius could forget all transient outer strife and life, and continue whatever studies he had entered on at home, become a naturalised citizen of the Classic World and heir to the immortal intellects of Greece and Rome. There was no withstanding the influence of their majesty—Virgil the beloved called him over the Alps, and imperial Homer to Athens and the windy plain of Troy. All this new-found region was peopled by hero-phantoms with mirage-fleets upon the seas, and armies fighting in the air. In this new atmosphere everything was strange and every strange thing was possible—for the mind had cast off old moorings and was freed of familiar limits—gods and goddesses, fauns and nymphs might flourish here as well as the myrtle, the orange grove, and the vine, for the poets had told of them all. Since their words were true of the earth's strange produce, why not also of the sky's progeny?

These, however, passed into cloud-shadows when the pure dawn of Christianity came upon his mind with serene radiance, showing ideals of infinite beauty.

¹ It is too much ignored that the "barbarian hordes" had also their laws, organisations, culture, in different degrees. The Franks are stated to have used Greek and Scythian letters. The costume of some chiefs was picturesque and splendid, according to Sidonius Apollonius, whose statement that Serenatus had been "extolling the barbarians and depreciating the Romans," shows that they could make themselves popular sometimes. Again, Fortunatus spent some time in German territory later, and found them singing their "leuden" to the murmuring of the "Arpa." There are many eulogistic poems by Fortunatus to the new rulers of France, and pleasant pictures of flowers sent, and the gardens of Ultrogotho's queen with its fragrance of "paradisial roses." To Queen Radegund, who, he says, despised the pomp of purple and gold, he offers these in the acceptable form of purple pansies and golden crocuses.

PART II

DRUIDS : SCHOOL AND COLLEGE LIFE IN GAUL

LOOKING into the clouded past, one is inclined to consider it difficult, if not impossible, for a native of Ireland to journey through Gaul to Rome, and still more to imagine him as Head of a School, teaching there and in Athens. Yet Pytheas sailed north from Marseilles, and our sea-ports were recognised by Tacitus as more accessible than those of Britain. Pelagius certainly travelled from this country (or from Wales) to confer with St. Augustine and to live, labour, and teach a school in Rome. St. Jerome found it possible to keep up a correspondence with noble ladies in remote Armorica and his writings went farther still, for he discovered that an Irish critic had not only read but censured a passage of his Commentaries. This roused his wrath and he declared his censor to be made stolid by Irish stirabout—a fortunate wrath, for without it we had missed an unimpeachable witness to the Latin scholarship of an Irish author of the fourth century. Travellers and written scrolls thus passed with certainty, if slowly, along the great highways of the Empire, and when Roman roads ceased, as in Britain, there were sea-boats which led to the state-controlled roads of Ireland.

Our vessels were familiar with British coasts in peace and in war, and did not fear to fare to the harbours of Gaul. There, when Sedulius arrived, he found Roman civilisation and language overlying the native culture and

customs, like a vast sheet of glittering ice above the unfrozen founts of living water.

For though Julius Caesar had been able to win Gauls, to make some of them Senators, and to form the Legion of the Lark, not all the rigour of the penal laws of his successors could soon extinguish their language, customs, and faith. The contrary has been stated, but I shall adduce evidence to prove that, even in the fifth century, a College of Druids existed, and that so late as the sixth Avitus, a Gaul, was crowned in Celtic fashion by a patriotic people ripe for a Celtic revival. Indeed, the Penal Laws must have failed of activity, or become obsolete, so early as the fourth century. For we find that a man who was publicly recognised as a Druid, and for whom the name held not reproach but honour, could and did become a professor in the great School of Bordeaux.

These facts being ascertained, it was reasonable to expect that some outcropping of native culture and custom should be discernible even through the covering of an alien language. To trace the existence of this hidden mine was a work of extreme interest.

The result has been that, in several instances, the Celtic ore is shown to gleam through the Latin mould, and that, in some remarkable examples the mould itself is Celtic, though the language is Latin. In other words we find the metrical laws which govern an exceptional and ancient form of Irish verse-structure exactly reproduced in a Latin poem by a Gallic Celt.

Sedulius in such a country should have been more or less at home, or at least felt himself among friends. Scholarship made the path easy for him, for in those days it carried far and high. No nation supplies a parallel except the Great Republic of North America, and even this is not so generous in its recognition of intellectual

merit. Difficult as it may seem for an insular Celt like Sedulius to achieve a high position in Rome and in Athens, the difficulty disappears when we consider the career of a Gallic scholar born of poor parents, in a provincial town. A sketch of his life will throw light on the coming career of the Irish outlander.

When Sedulius came to Gaul, Ausonius had but recently died, in 394, closing with the fourth century his life of poetry and of power. If the Irishman came by long-sea, as his fond familiarity with nautical images does suggest, then probably he sailed into the spacious harbour of Burdigala, where Ausonius was born, where he was educated, where he lectured for thirty years, and whither he returned, covered with honours, to die at home.

Now his maternal grandfather, Argicius Arborius, was an Aeduan by race. These Celts, according to Livy, founded Milan. We know that one of them, Divitiacus,¹ a distinguished Druid was Caesar's friend and was in correspondence with Cicero whom he instructed in the religious philosophy of his nation and (as I have ventured to demonstrate)² in the structure of their verse.

Argicius Arborius appears to have been such another. He was an Aeduan noble, opulent and with high connections. But when Victorinus gained the Empire, both he and his father were proscribed and had to fly to the south. That he was an adept in Druid knowledge is clear, for the poet states (in his *Parentalia*) that Argicius was skilled in celestial numbers and in the Stars, the Warders of Man's Destiny. But this science had to be kept secret at that time. He had cast the child's horoscope, a favourable one. "Not unknown to him," says Ausonius, "was my life's career; he had traced it out on tablets which were

¹ Divitiacus is the latinised form of Dubhtac—pronounced Duvtac.

² *Bards of the Gael and Gall*, Introduction. London. Fisher Unwin.

kept hidden, until a mother's curious hands discovered them."

How this recalls the coming of the venerable Druid to St. Columba's cradle in Ireland, and his prediction of the infant's great future !

After his flight Argicius managed to earn a livelihood by teaching mathematics and to amass a little wealth by the secret practice of astrology and divination. There were many Druids like him, throughout the country, who in times when persecution was keen, lived by their learning, whilst they practised the mysteries of their belief among a faithful people, for whom the grosser polytheism of Rome had no mystic charm.

Now, Arborius, one of the sons of this Druid, became an eminent scholar, a rhetor, a professor at the famous Schools of Bordeaux and Toulouse, and subsequently the appointed preceptor of a Caesar—the son of the Emperor Constantine at Constantinople ! His sister, a daughter of the Druid, became a distinguished physician : her name was Emilia Hilaria, but some used to make it masculine and call her Hilarius because of the manliness of her mind, whilst others, because of her genial manner, would call her Hilaritas, by way of a gentle pleasantry.

Dr. Emilia Hilaria was the poet's aunt, for her sister, Emilia Eonia, attracted also by the profession, had married Julius Ausonius, a physician of exceptional ability and high repute—a learned philosopher who spoke Greek even better than Latin, a genuine philanthropist who preferred the service of the suffering poor, to the prestige of the Prefecture conferred on him by the State.

Ausonius, his son, was proud of him and began life poor. But family affection and love of learning are characteristics of the Celt, and Arborius, his uncle, took charge of the young lad's education. Quick, clever,

industrious, pleasant, with a latent spark of genius and the ambition to make it flash, he passed through school with honour, became a teacher of grammar, then a rhetor and next a professor.

For thirty years he held the chair, with increasing credit. Then the Emperor Valentinian I., aware of his great reputation, invited him to the Court at Treves, the northern capital of the Empire, to direct the education of his nephew Gratian, the young Augustus. Thus Arborius and Ausonius, Gauls both, were both preceptors of imperial pupils.

Treveri (now Treves) is described by Ausonius, in his poem on the Moselle, as reposing in the bosom of peace, because it feeds, clothes, and arms the forces of the Empire. Its broad walls stretch over a sloping hill. The wide and tranquil Moselle flows past, bearing hither from afar the commerce of all countries. Treves fostered art, for elsewhere the poet describes a remarkable picture on the palace wall of Cupid crucified by the Heroines.¹ As it was the imperial capital not only of Gaul, but of Britain, many natives of the Northern Isles must have visited the celebrated city.

In his expedition against the Alemanni in 368 Valentinian took with him, not only Gratian, but his poet-preceptor in order that his exploits might not lack the sacred bard to sing them. And Ausonius sang how the Danube raises his happy head to salute the two Augusti and rushes with the news to the Euxine Sea to announce that the Rhine is no longer the limit of Gaul—thence if sea-law permit the river will rush back with tidings of the victory of Valens over the Goths !

¹ Ausonius writing to Gregorius asks : "Have you ever seen the painted cloud on the wall ? You saw it and remember it." This picture was coloured in the Eolus Hall at Treves. Ausonius greatly admired it and sent his friend some charming verses on the subject.

Valentinian died in 375. Then Gratian, in the plenitude of power, displayed a gratitude and an affection for his professor which are rather exceptional in historical records. The fact that his favours extended to the poet's aged father and other relatives speaks for the affectionate heart of Ausonius. In rapid succession, the higher honours of the State were showered upon him and his kindred. His father, then nearly ninety, was made Prefect of Illyria—the functions were, of course, discharged by deputy. His brother-in-law became Pro-consul of Africa, Ausonius himself and his son Hesperius were granted the Prefecture of the Gauls, and finally in 379 the poet was created First Consul.

When Gratian was slain by Maximus the Emperor Theodosius bestowed his favours on the poet, but Ausonius had had enough of court greatness, and retired to his beloved Burdigala, "Nidumque Senectae," the "Nest of my Age," he said, and there spent the remainder of his years in lettered leisure and in directing the education of his grandson.¹

In his *Idyll*, written to encourage his "honey-grandson" (*mellite nepos*), he opens the school-doors to us and allows us to listen to the murmurs and the moans of the boys—for the Gallic Schools were severe in discipline. Ausonius, in a mock-heroic, half-humorous, and yet earnest manner, bids his dear boy take courage and not mind the morning terrors of the master's face, nor other troubles—they had all undergone the same sufferings and happily survived. It was not to be all work. The Muses had their playtimes as well as their worktimes—these alternated and the Greeks gave school its name (*skole*) because this meant leisure. This was an etymological comfort! "No teacher should affright you,"

¹ It is curious to note that Ausonius preceded Victor Hugo in *L'Art d'être Grand-Père*.

Ausonius went on, " he may appear cross and quarrelsome but you will get accustomed to his looks. Chiron was half a horse, but he did not frighten young Achilles, nor did pine-wielding Atlas terrify the son of Amphitryon—they got to like them ! " This was truly a mythological comfort !

Having cheered the little lad by the memories of these monstrous masters, the poet proceeds with the serene philosophy of a senior who has forgotten the smart, " Neither should you fear though the school re-echo with strokes, and the master look truculent." " Fear argues a degenerate spirit ; be true to thyself (*tibi consta*), intrepid, neither the clamour, the sounding slaps, nor morning terrors shall agitate thee." " What though the sceptre of the ferula be brandished, the heap of rods be big, and the tawse have many supple straps—never mind their pomp of place nor that scene of vain terrors."

" Following such advice, in bye-gone days, your parents," he continues, " have made my old age peaceful and happy, and do you, first of my grand-children and first to bear my name, give me joy by hap or hope (*vel re vel spe*). " Then reminding the boy of the careers of his ancestors, so that he also should aspire to the arduous crown of learning, Ausonius continues : " Read thoroughly whatever is worth remembering ; these I advise—unroll the works of the ' Creator of the *Iliad* and those of pleasant Menander.' " Then comes an interesting passage on how poetry should be read : " Produce it," he says, " with rise and fall of the voice, noting the numbers, with proper accentuation. Give the meaning when reading. By distinguishing, the thought is emphasised, and a pause gives strength even to things inept."

As a suggestion has been made that the ancients read their poems in a sort of chant, I quote the words of Ausonius which describe their real method and which, be

it noted, is still the classic and best manner of French recitation :

tu flexu et acumine vocis
in numeros numeros doctis accentibus effer
affectusque impone legens :¹ distinctio sensum
auget, et ignavis dant intervalla vigorem.

"When shall I hear thee read," he exclaims with feeling. "When shall thy voice recall to life all the old forgotten songs, all the stories binding age to age, the Comedian's Sock, the tragic draperies of Kings with all the melodies of lyre and Song? Listening to thee, my child, I shall hear the poems that Horace moulded, and once more the lofty lines of Virgil,—Thee, also, Terence! of such choice latinity, with well-bound buskin tripping on the Stage,—thy crime, O Catiline, the tumult of Lepidus, the sequent history of the Twelve Years and the strange Civil War of banished Sertorius."

Then Ausonius indicates the course of higher education. It was not, he reminds the boy, an inexperienced grandsire who spoke. He had had pupils from their childhood onward. When the age of puberty brought a beard, he guided them in morals, in the fine arts, and in vigorous eloquence—though their neck disliked the yoke and their mouth the bridle-bit. Arduous moderation, gentle censure of indocile youth, were his methods—he had many trials but great success. Until, at last, he was called to the education of a Prince, and with various honours could command in a golden palace. Nay, if Fate and Fortune would pardon the jest, he presided the Empire, since his pupil—Master of the people, the sceptre, and the throne—submitted to his rule—and, he said, even Augustus thought our honours greater than his own :

maioresque putat nostros Augustus honores.

¹ Cf. "si vis me flere, flendum est et ipsi tibi."

Ausonius is his own biographer, and gives a vivid picture of his surroundings. In *Ephemeris* he sketches a day's occupation. The clear morning shines in, the swallows twitter in their nests ; then, " up, boy ! bring water to wash, garments to dress, and open the Chapel for prayer. Next the robes for the town, for the promenade and visits to friends, by that, it will be near noon and time to warn and counsel the cook. The dinner must not be kept waiting : off, boy ! now, and remind the five friends I mentioned," six (including the host) the proper number : six is company, more a mob ! (Sex enim convivium . . . si super, convivium est).

Then he tells of his dreams, some accountable as those of the forum, of lawsuits, of the stage, some incongruous and terrifying, as of one caught in a crowd of cavalry, fighting with wild beasts or in the ensanguined arena—some strange and impossible—yet stranger still in that they so often recur throughout the centuries, as of walking on the sea after shipwreck and of sudden flights in the air.

Virgil, he says, has spoken of those Illusions which come through the Ivory Gate, and the true Visions which come through the Gate of Horn : as to himself, he prefers the illusory when they are agreeable, for better a phantom pleasure than fear a fate.¹

Ausonius introduces us to the society of his relatives (*Parentalia*) with affectionate descriptions, but more interesting, from our standpoint, is his account of his grammar-teachers and of his professors of the higher grades. If he does not spare eulogy, he does not omit censure.

His Reminiscences of Professors (at Bordeaux)²

¹ Why dreams should, in ages so different, be so similar is a curious problem, and this evidence of continuity has been hitherto overlooked. Attempts should be made to collect and compare the dreams of the different races of mankind.

² *Commemoratio Professorum Burdigalensium.*

naturally begin by the most famous. This was Minervius, the orator, celebrated by his lectures at Rome and at Constantinople. In the School he led the fictitious debates (? law cases) like a Quintilian of the rhetor's toga. His eloquence was a torrent rolling in its course not mud but gold. Even more than Demosthenes he had that quality of action which Demosthenes thrice declared to be the first quality of an orator. He had a marvellous memory.¹ Anything he read or heard once, he could correctly repeat. In the case of a disputed game Ausonius heard him "ascribe every one of the casts and the number of marks on each of the dice thrown."

Alcimus also stood prominent—the only man whom that modern age of theirs could oppose to the great men of the past. Victor in the Forum, Pride of the Muses, Master of Greek and Latin letters, his services were the succour of the poor, in Law Court or in Lecture Hall.

There is a tear for dead Luciolus, the rhetor, once his School-comrade, next his master, and finally his colleague.

We now come to a professor of the greatest eminence. He had predeceased the others, but his noble eloquence survived him. He was Patera. Ausonius had seen him when a boy. This master of mighty rhetors (*doctor potentum rhetorum*) was a scion of the stock of Druids; whose race was consecrate to the Temple of Belenus.² None at that time had such knowledge, such fluency, and such variety in his discourses. Endowed with memory, elegance, lucidity, culture, and a musical voice, he was reticent of witticisms, never bitter, abstemious in food

¹ It is remarkable that Ausonius lays great stress on memory—which was particularly and exceedingly cultivated by the Celts.

² "Tu Baiocassis, stirpe Druidarum satus." Baiocassis is now Bayeux.

and drink, yet joyous, modest, and handsome in his age ; which was that of the eagle or the steed.

This surely is a bright and cheering portrait of a potential Druid, by one who knew them well, and a contrast to the gloomy paintings by foes, who knew them not at all.

Patera, St. Jerome says, taught rhetoric at Rome "gloriosissime."

Delphidius, another professor, was Patera's son. Eloquent, learned, quick of wit and word, he was genial by temperament and a charming companion. He delighted in poetry and excelled in oratory. But his character was independent, and unworldly ; he did not look after Court patronage, desiring to deserve rather than to receive honours, meriting more than he won. He stood forth against tyranny when it was rampant ; but, engrossed as a rhetor, he was not persistent in teaching. He conducted the great indictment against Numerius, Governor of the Narbonese, who was accused of speculation. He was a patriot, not a courtier.

Phoebicius was the aged father of Patera. He had been the guardian of the Temple of Belenus in remote Armorica, but he was brought to Bordeaux, and obtained the Chair of Grammar—this was through the influence of Patera, his famous son, and if it show that the father was not distinguished in Latin letters (though he may have been a scholar in Celtic), it also proves the great affection of Patera,—for not all eminent men would care to have their father near them in such a position—Ausonius says :

nec reticebo senem
nomine Phoebicium,
qui Beleni aedituus
nil opis inde tulit ;
sed tamen, ut placitum,
stirpe satus Druidum

gentis Armoricae,
Burdigala cathedram
nati opera obtinuit.

It appears from this that to be of Druid stock was now a point in one's favour when seeking advancement, and that Phoebicius was himself a Druid in active function. True it brought him little worldly wealth in remote Armorica—at least in the eyes of the wealthy Ausonius. Perhaps the Druid did not so much value it. Belenus, according to M. Beugnot, was the chief divinity of some parts of Gaul and occupied in Celtic Mythology the place reserved to the sun or Apollo in Roman rites.¹ The Celtic doctrine of sun-worship could thus have been continued by the Druids, under cover of Apollo's name.

Frankness is a characteristic of Ausonius. In his *Parentalia* he grieved for Herculanus, his sister's son, so lively, convivial, musical, handsome, and swift of foot,—his mother's pride. He adds that he assisted here as grammarian in his uncle's class, and should have succeeded him, but did not keep to the right road of Pythagoras. Other names of little note follow, but the poet desired to mention all citizens who taught there or elsewhere and any foreigners who taught in Bordeaux. They were clearly of one Brotherhood, all natives of the Nation of Knowledge.

Concordius had been a banished man; Securus was the son of a freedman, dissatisfied, of little learning or repute: he taught grammar elsewhere. Thalassus he barely remembered. Citarius was a Sicilian, a Greek grammarist and good poet, who married well. Marcellus had been driven forth by a cruel mother, but fortune gave him repute—a large class, wealth, and a distinguished wife. He lost all but his name (*Cuncta perisse simul, Non tamen*

¹ *Histoire de la destruction du paganisme*, t. ii. p. 152.

et nomen), says Ausonius,—which reminds one of the words of François I.—“ tout est perdu, fors l'honneur.”

To Crispus and Urbicus, Latin and Greek grammarians, a bitter-sweet elegy. Crispus first taught the alphabet, the mere elements, afterwards : “ It used to be thought that the warmth of wine raised you at times, to a rivalry with Virgil and Horace.” His comrade was a Greek and should have his ἐλλεῦ.¹ He spoke in prose and verse with equal force, and recalled the heroes of Homer and the voice of Nestor, sweeter than honey. They were both born free : pity they could not give proof of it. Three other Greek teachers he names, two of whom gave him to know the meaning and pronunciation of Greek, but he did not cultivate the language. “ Light lie the turf above you ” (vos levis cespes tegat). He commemorates also five Latin grammaticists or philologists. Leontius he specially mentions as a jolly, good-natured, pleasure-loving comrade, with just learning enough to be named a grammaticist. Jucundus, his brother, was said to have usurped the chair, but though unequal to the position, he had been good, simple, and his friend.

Ausonius refers in his *Epigrams* to grammarians. Playing on the name of one, Felix (happy), he declared that Felix could not be a grammarian—never was a grammarian happy :

Felix grammaticus non est, sed nec fuit unquam :
nec quisquam est felix nomine grammaticus.

If ever such a grammarian existed, he existed contrary to grammar.

Another epigram is inscribed to Auxilius. “ How could he teach rightly who faultily speaks his own name.” He called himself Auxilius, whereas Auxilium is the right

¹ There is a curious similarity between the Greek ἐλλεῦ and the Irish word *ailliliu*, which has much the same meaning.

word for assistance. "Give the proper case or you will be a Solecism!" In the third epigram we hear the fate of a grammaticist, who made an unhappy marriage. It has the merit of informing us that the grammarians taught more than grammar: they taught Virgil.¹

Grammarians had (for Glabrio had) the right to defend clients in the Forum: he had won his chair when Ausonius became rhetor. Nepolianus was both a grammarian and a rhetor, a man of the highest distinction. Old with a soul of youth, genial, gay, witty, pure, honey without bitterness, Ausonius said he was a sharer in his play and in his work, the healing of his heart!²

Nostri medela, Nepoliane, pectoris !

Silent often, when he spoke Ulysses would have listened. Honourable, modest, frugal, eloquent, no rhetor surpassed him in style. A Cleanthes the Stoic for dialectic, having Scaurus and Probus by heart, he excelled Cineas the Epirote in memory. He was, says the poet, the "Driver of my mind" (*Agitator mentis meae*), and had attained the honour of the Presidency.

Arburius, the uncle who took charge of his education, had been lamented in *Parentalia*—he is eulogised here among the professors, but his chair was in Tolosa (Toulouse). Now is mentioned the curious fact that, at this time there were in Tolosa, as in a kind of honourable exile, two young brothers of the Emperor Constantine. From Tolosa the fame of Arburius went forth to the East and he was appointed Preceptor of the young Caesar,

¹ Arma virumque docens, atque arma virumque peritus
non duxi uxorem, sed magis arma domum.

Which may be rendered :

Arms and the Man I taught, who founded Rome—
Arms and strife, not wife, I found at home.

² This expression is also in Gaelic, *e.g.* "For my heart no healing without thee" in "Eiblin a ruin."

Constantine's son. There he lived in honour and opulence, and there he died, but the Emperor nobly restored his body to the tomb of his ancestors in Bordeaux.

Exuperius was a rhetor, personable and dignified, who taught at Tolosa and next at Narbo. There the young sons of Dalmatius¹ ("fatal names of Kings") paid a vast price for his lessons in rhetoric. When at last they obtained the name of Caesars, they gave him the Presidency of a tribunal in Spain. His copious eloquence pleased the ear, but when read showed little solidity. Sedatus was another native of Bordeaux who was rhetor at Tolosa. Staphylius, a rhetor of Auch, a stranger, had been like a father and an uncle, an Ausonius and an Arborius to him. A learned grammaticist, a clever rhetor, deep in the history of Livy and Herodotus, he knew the contents of the six hundred volumes of Varro.

Victorius, a sub-doctor or *proscholus* (under-master or Substitute), was perhaps the principal scholar of the School, though not so placed by Ausonius. He was absorbed, says the latter, in moth-eaten manuscripts in questions of Pontifical right, remote history, Castor on doubtful Kings, Rhodope's publications from her husband's works, the laws of Draco and of Solon, of Saleucus to the Locrians, of Minos after Jove, of Themis before Jove. He preferred all this to our Cicero and Virgil!

This, in Victorius, evidently revealed the independence of his character and the originality of his mind. He went out beyond the beaten path and was engaged in research work. He ended his days in Rome to which he had formerly come from Sicily. A scholar, not a rhetor, he lived without patronage and died without official honours.

¹ Dalmatius was one of the brothers of the Emperor, kept in Gaul out of the way of intrigues. His sons were killed by revolted soldiers after the Emperor's death.

In these Reminiscences we have a picture of the teachers of the lower and higher school or college classes, and it cannot be gainsaid that the effect is a pleasant one. The Academical world, with its few weaknesses and fewer faults, was intellectual and agreeable, friendly and helpful, social, hospitable, admiring talent, and welcoming strangers. There appears to have been wonderful activity and movement throughout the Empire in those days. Some who won fame in Rome and Constantinople, Greek and Sicilian students, came to teach at Bordeaux, natives of Bordeaux were called to the Imperial Courts at Constantinople and at Treves,—some gained glory in Rome and lesser men a livelihood in Poitou and in Spain. The Emperor Constantine's brothers resided at Narbonne and his nephews were educated there. St. Jerome had correspondents in Armorica and outside the Empire a critic in independent Ireland, Pelagius taught in Rome. Lastly, the Latin persecution of the Gauls had ceased, and it is manifest that to be a Druid or of Druidic extraction was no longer an impediment but an assistance to a man's career, it was evidence that he was a member of a distinguished and cultured race.¹

¹ It is worth noting that Ausonius places the noble cities of his time as follows: "Golden Rome, the home of the Gods," stands foremost, of course: the delicate flattery of one line suffices its description, all others require many.

Prima urbes inter, Divum domus, aurea Roma.

Next come Constantinople and Carthage, rivals; Antioch and Alexandria, also rivals, potent Treves, marvellous Milan, Capua, Arles—"little Gallic Rome" (*Gallula Roma Arelas*), Spanish Merida (surpassing Corduba and Tarraco), Athens ("whose is the glory of Attic eloquence"), Catunia, Syracuse, Toulouse from which four cities sprang, Narbonne, first to bear the Latin name, Bordeaux famed for its river, its wine, its fountain, its streets, its gates, its climate and manners, its great men, its noble Senate—his home. "I love Bordeaux, Rome I adore—Citizen of one, Consul in both: here is my cradle, there my curule chair."

PART III

CELTIC SURVIVAL IN ROMANISED GAUL

AMID such circumstances it would be strange that something of the old Gallic thought, culture, and expression should not appear through the overlying Latin. It would be more difficult to understand why it did not appear than why it did. St. Jerome noticed its presence in St. Hilary's work when he said that Hilary wore the Gallic cothurn.¹ It should, of course, be less easy to discern it in that of Ausonius, expert in Latin as he was, a rhetor, a poet, and a professor.

In moments of great emotion, however, the flood of feeling sometimes dissolves the force of artificial habit, and men will revert to their original dialect, and strangers to their native tongue. It was a time of great emotion with Ausonius when the object of his highest ambition had been gained, and, as Consul designate, he had received the Fasces. Then his latent Celticism breaks out, and he apostrophises in joyous verse the New Year, the sun, the winds, the rain, the seasons, the several stars, Cynthia, Arcas, Saturn, Jupiter, Cytherean Vesper, Cellenius, and

¹ Cothurnus was the buskin in use upon the stage in serious drama. Now an idiomatic version of Jerome's phrase would be that "Hilary has a Gallic brogue"—hence we come to the curious and interesting discovery that in using the words "an Irish brogue," one repeats a classic metaphor, for the Irish word "bróg" (buskin) is equivalent to cothurnus. Thus we find explained, unexpectedly, what seemed inexplicable.

the soil itself to be propitious and grant him a favourable and hopeful year for his Consulate !

The enumeration of the Stars reminds us that the Druids were skilled in celestial lore and astronomers. The appeal to the Sun and all the elements to be propitious and to favour his Consulate with a fair and fruitful year has its parallels in the Ancient Irish Annals, where it is recorded that in the reign of good kings the seasons were auspicious, the soil prolific, and the trees wonderfully fruitful. So late as the sixteenth century the bard O'Bruadair warned his king that he would sing no song of praise until he saw his high precepts adopted—then all nature would rejoice :

Then the Sun of day, the Sky,
Earth and Water, birds on high,
Every Element shall sing
To the praises of the King
On the boughs shall swarm the bees,
Salmon leap from shining seas,
All the fair tribes of the flood
Praise with me the Chieftain good.

An unprosperous season reflected adversely upon the King.

Take another instance of these relationships. In the year 457, about a century and a half after the appeal of Ausonius to the Sun, Stars, Winds, Water, Months, Seasons, and Soil, King Laegaire of Tara was defeated by Leinster. Made prisoner, he swore by the Sun and Moon, Water and Air, Day and Night, Sea and Land to renounce the unjust Borumeen tribute, and was liberated. Having proved false to his oath, say the Annals of the Four Masters, he was slain in the following year by the Sun and Wind.

Appreciation and love of Nature are acknowledged

characteristics of the Celtic temperament. In Irish poetry this is shown from the earliest verse extant. Here, again, Ausonius is their kin: in his poem on the River Mosella he says, and is perhaps the first to express though not the first to feel admiration for the work of Nature: "*Naturae mirabor opus*"—and he proves it by devoting nearly five hundred lines to a delicate and delightful description of that famous stream, its vine-clad banks, its crystal waters, its shining, shifting pebbles, its shadowy wavering water-weeds. The Caledonian Britons know the picture, he sings, when Ocean ebbing lays bare the green sea-weed, red coral and shell-germs, pearly berries, the delight of luxury. In the hot noon, unseen, the Naiads and the Oreads meet and play. When at evening the hills and scenes around are mirrored in the stream, the rowers in their little boats reach forth to pluck the illusive purple grapes. . . . Then we have the story of all its fishes, of the Angler with his agile rod, the nets with cork-floats, the merry races where skiffs and shadows compete, and the thousand beauties of wood, water, and sinuous mountain scenery.

But besides these remarkable resemblances is there not anything more noticeable, if more mechanical, say in the verse-structure itself? This is asking much, for it requires that a poet trained from his youth in Latin metre, shall under an inherited impulse fail in his art,—which is impossible to suppose, or else that he shall experiment in his art, by adapting Latin words to Celtic metrical rules.

This may strike the conventional classic scholar as unthinkable, but on the other hand, consider how, at first, poets in Italy fitted Latin words to the rules of Greek metric and say why should not poets in Gaul act in a similar manner?

Evidently it was possible, and probable, and in fact it was accomplished by Ausonius.

Take this example :—It is known that from of old the Celtic bards (in Ireland) were experts in the art of rime, assonantal, consonantal, terminal and inlaid, to mention some. It may be assumed that the Celtic bards, in Gaul, had similar qualifications. Now in the following epigram (intended for a statue of Bacchus in his villa) Ausonius diverges distinctly from the Latin types, and makes exceptional use of rime and of a rime which has certain marked Gaelic peculiarities.

These are the verses of Ausonius :

	Vowel rimes.
Ogygia me Bacchum vocat	o a
Osirin Aegyptus putat	u a
Mysi Phanacen nominant	i a
Dionyson Indi existimant	i i a
Romana Sacra Liberum	i e u
Arabica gens Adoneum	o e u
Lucaniacus Pantheum	a e u

Here the consonantal rimes are obvious, plainly intended, and distinguish it from Latin epigrams. But the more subtle vowel rimes require to be pointed out. Vowels are divided in Gaelic into two classes: the broad, a, o, u, which rime with each other as with themselves—and the slender vowels, e, i, which likewise rime together and with themselves. The permitted difference of consonants allows a variety otherwise unknown in the chiming sounds. To a Spanish or a Gaelic ear these rules need no explaining, but I may add that, c and t being “corresponding” consonantal rimes, the first two end-words have not only vowel rimes but consonantal correspondence.

Now, here is a case in which a Gallic poet, expert in his art, has produced verses which fulfil the subtle and difficult requirements of Celtic metric. He could not so have marred his classic fame by accident nor would he

have allowed such a thing to appear if the accident had happened. He must, therefore, have purposely prepared the verse so as to fit it into the Celtic mould. Just so did other Latins fill the Greek moulds.

Such an example from the descendant of an Aeduan Druid should strengthen the statement made in a former work¹ that Cicero studied (and imitated) Celtic verse-methods when he studied Celtic philosophy and religion with his and Caesar's Aeduan friend Divitiacus the Druid. Quintilian reprov'd, whilst other later critics mocked Cicero's verse, as if it came from a blundering school-boy; and yet Cicero was a very distinguished poet, as Professor Tyrrell has justly declared. These are the lines referred to :

cedant arma Togae,
concedat Laurea Linguae ;
o fortunatam natam
me consule Romam.

They would have seemed discreditable as Latin verse, and so good a poet could not have been guilty of them, but as an imitation of a Celtic model, they are correct and interesting.

There is yet another, a not less searching, and even a more remarkable test. The Milesians, Scots, or Gael, invaded Ireland in pre-Christian times, the year of the world 3500 is the date alleged. Amergin, brother of their Chief (Miled or Milesius), was their Bard, Druid, and Judge. In order to abate the storm-winds raised by the Island-Druids, Amergin composed an Incantation. This singular poem, whose exact date is not known but which is undoubtedly pre-Christian, was composed in an intricate Gaelic metre called Conaclon.

¹ *Bards of the Gael and Gall*. There is one-syllable end-rime in the first two lines, and two-syllable end-rimes in the last two ; c and t "correspond"—l and l alliterate.

These are the two essential and exceptional characteristics of that metrical mode :

1°. The last word of each line shall be repeated as the first word of the line following. And, 2°, the final word of the completed poem shall be a repetition from the first line of that poem.

The last condition is frequently observed in ancient Irish poems, the first is exceedingly rare and perhaps unique.

[There is, indeed, a modified and more modern form used in elegies (for Conaclon seems associated with solemn subjects) where it suffices that the last word of each quatrain shall be the initial word of the quatrain following.¹]

This is the incantation of Amergin :

Ailim iath n erend ²
 Ermac muir motach
 Motach sliab sreatach
 Sreatach coill ciotach
 Ciotach ab eascach
 Eascach loc lindmar
 Lindmar tor tiopra
 Tiopra tuath aenach
 Aenach righ teamra
 Teamair tor tuatach
 Tuata mac milead
 Mile long libearn
 Libearn ard Ere
 Ere ard diclass
 Eber dond digbas

¹ See "An Elegy," in *Bards of the Gael and Gall*, p. 340.

² *Ossianic Society*, vol. v. It is not quite perfect. The editor and translator, Professor Connellan, remarks: "The Poems ascribed to Amergin . . . are said to be written in the *Bearla Feine*, which was probably the old Celtic tongue of Gaul and Spain as it was of Ireland in early times."

Diceadal ro gaet
 Ro gaet ban breisi
 Breissi ban buaich
 Righ adbal Eremon
 Eremon or tus
 hir Eber ailseas
 Ailim iath n erend.¹

This is the poem of Ausonius :

Res hominum fragiles alit, et regit, et perimit fors.
 fors dubia, aeternumque labans : quam blanda fovet
 spes.

spes nullo finita aevo : cui terminus est mors.
 mors avida, inferna mergit caligine quam nox.
 nox obitura vicem : remeaverit aurea quum lux.
 lux dono concessa deum : cui praevisus est sol.
 sol, cui nec furto Veneris latet armipotens Mars.
 Mars nullo de patre satus : quem Thressa colit gens.
 gens infrena virum : quibus in scelus omne ruit fas.
 fas hominum mactare factis : ferus iste loci mos.
 mos ferus audacis populi : quem nulla tenet lex.
 lex naturali quam condidit imperio ius.
 ius genitum pietate hominum, ius certa dei mens.
 mens quae caelesti sensu rigat emeritum cor.
 cor vegetum mundi instar habens, animae vigor vis.
 vis tamen hic nulla est : verum est iocus et nihil res.²

In this poem of Ausonius we find repeated the essential and distinctive characters of that of Amergin : the end-word of each line is used as the initial word of the following line and an echo of the first of the poem is found at

¹ There is also a Welsh poem, in this metric, of the sixth century, so that Conaclone links together the literature of Ireland, Gaul, and Wales.

² This is entitled "Technopaegnon," Edyll. XII. Collectio Pisaurensis. Pisauri MDCCCLXVI. Ex Amatina Chalcographia. Publica Auctoritate.

its close.¹ Since both poems are formed in the same Celtic mould it is reasonable to believe that they have the same Celtic origin, and this belief is confirmed, when we find that the author of one was a Druid, and the author of the other a descendant of Druids.

¹ It is peculiar and noteworthy that every end-word is a monosyllable, for in another form of Irish metric—the “great metre”—“the last word of each line should be a monosyllable” O’Molloy, *De prosodia Hibernica*, cvii. (O’Flannghaile).

D



PART IV

THE CELTIC REVIVAL : EMPEROR CROWNED WITH CELTIC RITES : RELATIONS BETWEEN GAUL, CALEDONIA, BRITAIN AND IRELAND

IN Treves, that centre of imperial power and far-fetching commerce, Ausonius must have met natives of Northern lands. Apparently some were patriotic travellers from what is now called Scotland, for in praising the Moselle, he refers to the corals and pearls laid bare by the ebb-tide in Caledonia,¹ and, again in his ninth epistle, to the fine Caledonian oysters, which he may perhaps have eaten.² "There are some who praise them," he remarks.

But certainly he knew the work of at least one British critic and did not praise him. This was a certain Silvius Bonus (a latinised Briton clearly) who had had the audacity to carp at his poems, and for this offence Ausonius ridicules him in six slight-stinging epigrams—and by the preserving properties of that sting Ausonius has given the else unknown author a quivering immortality.

He is not rude or rough with his British critic : he lightly satirises him, with Gallic grace, playing on his name. "This Sylvius is good," he says. "What Sylvius?" "This Britisher." "Either Sylvius is not a Briton, or he is bad." Again, "There is no good Briton : if Sylvius

¹ nota Caledoniis talis pictura Britannis, etc., *Mosella*, v. 68.

² sunt et Aremorici qui laudent ostrea ponti :
et quae Pictonici legit accola litteris : et quae
mira Caledonius nonnunquam detegit aestus.

would simply be Sylvius, then simple Sylvius would cease to be good."

All this raillery falls upon the nation of Sylvius because that careless critic had censured the poems of Ausonius ! (qui carmina nostra lacescit).

These are the six Epigrams on Sylvius Bonus, a Briton :

Sylvius ille Bonus, qui carmina nostra lacescit,
nostra magis meruit disticha Brito Bonus.

Sylvius hic Bonus est. Quis Sylvius ?—iste Britannus,
aut Brito hic non est Sylvius, aut malus est.

Sylvius iste Bonus fertur, ferturque Britannus :
quis credat civem degenerasse bonum ?

Nemo bonus Brito est : si simplex Sylvius esse
incipiat, Simplex desinet esse Bonus.

Sylvius hic Bonus est : sed Brito est Sylvius idem.
simplicior res est, credite, Brito malus.

Silvi, Brito, Bonus : quamvis homo non bonus esse
ferris nec se quid iungere Brito Bono.

These epigrams do more than sting a Briton, they prove unexpectedly that there was at least one Briton of Britain sufficiently skilled in literary latinity to produce a criticism that required notice. Were there not others ? And this suggests the question : May not that gifted race which Beda complains were " ever delighted to hear something novel, holding firmly to nothing," have produced some literature in Latin, seeing that, in Wales, they have achieved great things in the language to which they held with such admirable fidelity ? If so, who effaced it ? Not the Romans—perhaps the more hostile Saxons.

There is no question that some Irish and Britons displayed in the Latin language an amount of literary skill which excelled that of St. Patrick, who came from the Latin Schools of Gaul with another and a greater gift.

Celestius is regarded as an Irishman by authorities such as Haddan and Stubbs: he stands in history as a writer of great piquancy and power and as a pleader of unfailing eloquence—his foes said “loquacity.” He was a follower of Pelagius whose theological error in doctrine gave rise to Pelagianism, but who, according to St. Augustine, his great opponent, was personally a good and holy man, and who as a writer possessed great grace, acuteness, and eloquence.

Now Pelagius is said to have been a Briton (by birth or residence) but “a descendant of the Irish nation, in the vicinity of the British.”¹ He not only travelled to Rome, but resided there, learned Greek, had a School, and was very popular until a published work gave rise to questions of doctrine.

An Irishman it certainly was who had the daring to criticise a passage in St. Jerome’s writings, which evoked a rough reply from that strenuous scholar and rigid moralist, for he was touched in a sensitive part—accused of laxity, or leniency, in disciplinary teaching.²

To assert such a thing, his critic, he said, was “most stolid and stupefied with the porridge of the Irish.”

What follows? St. Jerome’s Commentary appeared in the year 392, hence we must conclude that, so early as this date there were Irish Scholars, whose knowledge of Latin and whose intimacy with its literature enabled them

¹ Some think it applies to Celestius. This, however, is the view taken by Archbishop Healy in his valuable work, *Ireland’s Ancient Schools and Scholars*, p. 39, 2nd edition. The supposition that the name Pelagius was a latinised form of Morgan (as both names indicate the sea), and that therefore he was Welsh, fails, for there are many Irish names which might serve, *e.g.* Murcad, Muirceartach, Connamara, etc.

² ne recordaretur stolidissimus et a Scotorum pultibus praegravatus, nos in ipso dixisse opere: Non damno digamos, immo nec trigamos et si fieri possit autogamos, plus aliquid inferam etiam scortatorum recipio poenitentiam.

to occupy a prominent place in the discussion of vital questions.¹

Thus we have the remarkable fact that nearly forty years before the coming of St. Patrick and, even before the coming of his predecessor Palladius, Latin scholarship in Ireland had reached a mature condition! It might be fairly inferred, since a foreign language is not rapidly developed, that Latin had been known in some Irish schools for over a century. When St. Patrick came to Ireland, he came as St. Paul to Athens, to preach before a highly civilised people.²

The rough reply of St. Jerome may be passed over because it was provoked by criticism. Prosper of Aquitaine, praised by Beda, had not the same excuse for stigmatising as a viper, some time later, a man whom St. Augustine (his great but just adversary) had declared to be good and holy. Polemists defame when too feeble to discuss. Here we see the distinction between a petty polemist and a great theologian. The former does not always confine his abuse to an individual. For the petty polemist, who assumes he is defending religion when he violates its precepts, is at his lowest when through culpable ignorance he darkens a nation's fame by vulgar vituperation. Such is the reference made to the Scot (the Irishman) by Prudentius the Spaniard, about the end

¹ Mansuetus, of a noble Irish family, was first Bishop of Toul in France before Palladius came.

² From an anecdote given in the *Irish Life of St. Patrick*, it appears that he pronounced Latin differently. Daire, a chieftain, generously sent Patrick a fine bronze cauldron as a gift. Patrick accepted it and said, "Deo gratias." "What said he?" asked Daire of his envoy. "He said 'gratzicum,'" was the reply. "A small word for a large present. Bring it back," said Daire. "What said he?" again was asked. "He said 'gratzicum,'" was the answer. "That is a great word which serves for receiving and returning it," and Daire made friends with Patrick, who apparently pronounced the "t" soft, not hard, as the Irish would.

of the fourth century (b. 348, d. 410) when writing against the Sabellians.¹ Prudentius plagiarised his abusive epithet from Silvius Italicus.

Abuse, no doubt, is a method of warfare, but is outside the laws of honourable procedure, and often comes from defiled, not defiling mouths. Silvius Italicus, for instance (d. 101), who called the gallant Alpine mountaineers "semiferi" (apes) and who libelled the chivalric Gauls, by declaring that they used to hoop human skulls with gold and use them as drinking-cups at feasts,² was no doubt a poet and a Consul, but he was also a parasite and a delator, betraying men to share their spoil. Silvius was less libellous but still unfair when he wrote :

*vaniloquum Celtæ genus et mutabile mentis.*³

Juvenal presents a different view, severe satirist though he was, when he shows Gaul teaching eloquence to the lawyers of Britain.

Take another charge which is generally attributed to St. Jerome, whereas the least research would have shown that he did not make it. The Attacotti were a British tribe serving as soldiers in the Roman Army, and it is alleged that when in Gaul they came upon flocks and herds in the woods they sliced morsels from the herd-people and ate human flesh. It is plainly preposterous to think they would forgo the roast lamb or succulent pig at hand to hunt in the bush for a slice of a lean slave fighting for

¹ non recepit, neget ut regimen pollere Supremum.
illud et ipse Numæ tacitus sibi sensit aruspex.
semifer et Scotus sentit cane milite peior.

² This may be compared to the later story that the Norsemen drank blood out of skulls. A poet in a "kenning" had said symbolically they drank earth blood from "skull branches," which simply meant they drank ale out of horns.

³ With which compare the Saxon Bede's complaint of Britain :
"insulæ novi semper aliquid audire gaudenti, et nihil certi firmiter obtinenti infudit," c. viii.

his life.¹ St. Jerome did not witness anything of the kind ; he says, he was a little boy, " adolescentulus," in Gaul at the time the story was told him—and most probably it was one of the bogey stories invented to keep children from straying into the woods where wild boars and wolves were dangers.²

Those who take it seriously fail to see that it is a gross and incredible libel on the discipline of the Roman Army in a friendly province.

The animosity sometimes shown to the Irish by Latin writers is a compliment. There were special reasons for not taking Irish criticism placidly. The Irish Nation had been the First of the Free Nations (or Barbari) in the West to assail the dominance of Roman rule. They had encouraged and assisted others. Agricola had thought of an expedition to conquer Ireland, so as to quench that Light of Liberty which its free existence threw with disturbing ray upon the vassalage of Rome's subjugated nations. Its Light rendered uneasy the sleep of slaves.

Agricola thought Erin could be conquered by one Legion and auxiliaries, say 10,000 men, but the expeditions went not to but from the Irish shores.³ Severus, in the second century, had to build an earthen wall topped with stakes, from sea to sea in Britain itself to withstand

¹ These are his words : Quid loquar de ceteris nationibus, cum ipse adolescentulus in Gallis Atticotos gentem Britannicam humanis vescere carnibus, et cum per silvas porcorum greges et armentorum pecudumque reperiant, pastorum nates et feminarum papillas solere abscindere et has solas ciborum delicias arbitrari ?—*Adversus Iovinianum*.

² This may be compared with similar statements, published during the war in 1914.

³ Many hoards of ancient Roman coins have been found in Ireland and recorded in the Proceedings of learned societies. They were spoils or tribute of latinised Britain. Thus in 1830, near the Giant's Causeway, a hoard of 580 silver coins was found—possibly a result of an expedition by Calgach, whom Tacitus calls Galgacus. See also F. Haverfield, *Ancient Rome and Ireland*.

the inroads of the Irish and the Picts which later and greater ramparts did not prevent.

The Irish were then the Sea-Kings of the West and ruled the waves. Suppliant Britannia sought safety in the arms of the Roman General Stilicho, when the Irish moved all Erin and the sea foamed under the might of her menacing oars. So Claudian laments :

inde Caledonio velata Britannia monstro,
ferro picta genas, cuius vestigia vertit
caeruleus Oceanique aestum mentitur amictus :
“ me quoque vicinis pereuntem gentibus ” inquit
“ me iuvit, Stilico, totam cum Scotus Iernen
movit et infesto spumavit remige Tethys.
illius effectum curis ne tela timerem
Scotica.”¹

Romanised Britannia—veiled and suppliant Britain—was grateful that Stilicho saved her from dread of the Irish spears. The Roman poet thought it a famous feat, and reverts to it, in his poem “ *De bello Getico* ” :

Quae Scoto dat frena truci.

The fierce Irish had been curbed, and again Claudian recalls this matter of mighty moment in his panegyric of the fourth Consulate of Honorius :

Scotorum cumulos flevit glacialis Ierne.

Icy Erin wept her mounds of Irishmen. But this vain vaunting did not erase the Roman Wall, nor fortify the coast, nor remove the suppliant's garb from “ *velata Britannia* ”—then the Niobe of nations.

“ The groans of the Britains ” in that piteous appeal to Aetius, thrice Consul (A.D. 423), spoke their real state : “ The Irish thrust us to the sea, the sea thrusts us to the

¹ Claudian, *De laudibus Stiliconis*, lib. ii. Collectio Pisarenensis. Stilicho was father-in-law and war minister to the Emperor Honorius, and was a Gothic warrior.

Irish, between them two kinds of death confront us : either we are slaughtered or we are drowned.”¹

Of course they call the Irish “barbari.” But Rome was then engaged with Attila, and Beda relates how the Irish invaders possessed the country for so many years, and that numbers submitted to them, but others held out (the latinised forces, no doubt), and had some success for a time, but only for a little time, as Beda implies : “The insolent Irish raiders returned home to come back again after a short time.”²

The Irish invaders were to latinised Britain not altogether what the Barbari were to latinised Gaul ; there were two important differences. The Irish went as a Free Nation to support the remnant of the kindred free Britons, and again, being a civilised people with written laws and chronicles, they left their adventure on record.

On the Continent the fifth century was a century of barbarian avalanches descending on the breaking ramparts of Roman power. Is it not remarkable that this self-same century was also that of the Irish invasion of Roman-ruled Britain ? It is a curious coincidence perhaps, but may it not have been a concerted one ? There is often a more intelligent sympathy among conquered peoples than official writers recognise.

In Gaul, notwithstanding Roman force and favour, there must have remained masses of the people constant to their old language, custom, and faith. That they influenced the speech of their rulers is shown by the Celtic terms which became loan-words in the Latin language, such as *bardus*, *braca*, *bascauda*, *bardocu-*

¹ Repellunt Barbari ad mare, repellit mare ad Barbaros : inter haec oriuntur duo genera funerum, aut iugulamur aut mergimur.

² Revertuntur ergo impudentes grassatores Hiberni domum post non longum tempus reversuri.

cullus,¹ etc., the latter, being the "capote" with hood, was acceptable to the Roman, and is still in use in France.

It is true that Professor Kuno Meyer, in the Introduction to his valuable work *Ancient Irish Poetry*, says, "By the fifth century the Gaulish language was everywhere extinct, without having left behind a single relic of its literature."

To the statement that the Gaulish language was extinct in the fifth century I cannot assent. Would it not be strange that whilst the Irish, the Caledonians, and the Welsh retained their speech, under much severer strain, until the present time, the kindred Gaul should so rapidly forget it? Official and fashionable society, and place-seekers generally, of course, forgot or ignored it. But as St. Jerome found it spoken in Galatia, it is more than improbable that it was not spoken in Gaul. When Phoebeicius, the Armorican Druid, became professor at Bordeaux he addressed his pupils in Latin, but did he therefore forget the language in which he invoked his God?

He lived indeed some time previously, but there are traces of continuity. The life of St. Eloi bears witness to the fact that there was, in the fifth century, a College of Druids in Auvergne near Clermont.

Penal laws do not always abolish rooted principles. Again, Ireland's history shows that a man might have a foreign title and yet retain his Gaelic chieftainship with its greater influence among his people.

So it must have been in Gaul, the native nobles had a heart for their people, a mind for the potency of ancient custom, and a memory of great traditions as well as a policy for the Roman dispenser of dignities.

M. F. Fauriel clearly understood the case, as this

¹ Gallia Santonico te vestit bardocucullo. M.

translated passage shows : " To learn Latin, the Gauls should forget their ancient languages, and a forgetfulness of the sort, even with a firm will to succeed, is always for the mass of the people the slowest and the most difficult thing in the world. The national terms and idioms should emerge, at every moment in the Latin of a Celt, a Gaul, an Aquitanian who had not learned it systematically, but by use and only of mere necessity."

Perhaps there might have been a Celtic literary revival had it not been for successive billows of Barbarians. For it was the Latin language and culture that were falling out of fashion.

Mamertus Claudian, a distinguished author states that not only was Latin neglected, but people were *ashamed to speak it* ! This was about the year 460. He was ready, he says, to write the Epitaph of the Sciences but for a few scholars who were still at work.

Not only is Latin neglected, he proceeds, people are ashamed to speak it. Grammar is despised ; dialectic feared like an Amazon sword in hand ; music, geometry, arithmetic are repelled like so many furies. Philosophy is a bird of ill omen. True rhetoric receives no welcome, eloquence is crabbed and magniloquent. Poets make free to change the quantity of syllables, long for short and short for long. St. Sidonius Apollinaris is cited as an example.

But if we can only guess at the possibility of a Celtic literary revival, we have ample proofs of a great Celtic political revival, which after stormy struggles resulted in a separation from the Empire.

Evidence of the Gallic upheaval is found in the Panegyric on Avitus by Sidonius Apollinaris. This noble Gallo-Roman was born at Lyons in 431, his father and grandfather had been Prefects of the Praetorium of the Gauls, whilst he himself became chief of the Senate,

Prefect of Rome, and a Patrician. He married Papianilla, daughter of Avitus, in 452. Three years later Sidonius published his Eulogy, and relates how Avitus was chosen Emperor of the West.

Owing to the irruptions of the Barbarians and the decrepitude of the central power the seat of authority had been removed from Treves to Autun and thence to Arles. Valentinian III. had died. The Empress Eudoxia had traitorously called in the help of the Vandals; Genseric had sacked Rome. The Official Representatives of Rome in Gaul had faltered, failed, and fled.

Then it was that the old Gaulish nobility took action; gathering from the snowy Cottian Alps, the borders of the Tyrrhene Sea, the River Rhine, and the long Pyrenean mountains, their chosen delegates met at Ugernum (now Beaucaire) on the Rhone. There they held a great deliberative assembly and resolved to elect an Emperor worthy of their nation and of the throne. Avitus was unanimously selected. Now Avitus was himself a descendant of a famous native family of Auvergne; he had been Prefect of the Gauls under Valentinian III., and had governed wisely, honourably, and with indomitable courage, for he was a famous General.

The historic poem of Sidonius gives a vivid account of the condition of Gaul under its incapable and transient rulers.

It is embodied in the appeal to Avitus, by the spokesman of this great assembly, the most illustrious of its nobility. He began by declaring that it was needless to remind Avitus of the miseries they had suffered, for that he more than all had grieved for the wounds of the fatherland.¹ Amid such disasters—"the Funeral of a World"—to have lived was death (*mors vixisse fuit*). Respecting their forefathers' word, they had served the

¹ *maxima pars fueris, Patriae dum vulnera lugens, etc.*

Government rule, though ignoble, and thought it a sacred duty to stand by the old State in its fall. Then, in memorable phrase, he exclaims: "Portavimus umbram Imperii"—"We have upheld the Shadow of an Empire"—content even to bear the vices of a decrepit ancient race and to tolerate the purple rather from habit than from conviction of right.

Latterly, Gaul might have displayed her strength when Maximus occupied the trembling City. Now, he declared, theirs is a greater opportunity, a more urgent necessity, corruption, or cowardice must not prevail, when imminent danger demands the bravest man. The Emperor is dead, the Empire may be seized by anyone:

captive, ut aiunt

orbis in Urbe iacet.

"'Tis said: 'When Rome falls, the world falls.' Accept the tribunal, Avitus, we beseech thee; rescue us from ruin—No venal gifts have won the centuries.¹ None buys a world's votes (*suffragia mundi nullus emit*). Poor, thou art chosen: it suffices that thou art wealthy in worth. Why delay what the Country desires? It commands that thou shalt command (*quae iubet ut iubeas*). This is the decision of each of us all: 'If thou'lt be lord, I shall be free' (*si dominus fis liber ero*)."

This noble, frank, and spirited speech, reported by Sidonius, declares certainly the poet's own sentiments, as well as those of the independent Gallic people. It was, he says, greeted with great enthusiasm. The nobles, rejoicing, carefully organised the night-guards.

Now we come to the description of the acclamation of Avitus, as Emperor.

It might be thought—one could expect nothing else

¹ Companies of an hundred.

after so many centuries of military discipline,—that the ceremonies of Rome should be followed. But here is the unexpected, the wonderful—and yet really the natural thing—the ceremonies adopted were those not of the Romans, but of the Celts !

They may be compared with the recognition on his Rath or throning rock of an ancient Irish king. This is a literal translation of the verse of Sidonius :

When the third dawn had restored the sun, and dispelled the stars, the Chieftains assembled and placed him on a prepared mound, surrounded by the army, and crowned him with the martial Torque and gave him the Symbols of Sovereignty.¹

Nothing could have been devised more closely Celtic.

This account reads like an extract from ancient Irish history. We have the assembling of chieftains from all parts of the region, the selection of a king, the choice of the third day, the placing of the new chief on a mound (or rath), the crowning with martial honours, and the grant of the insignia of the kingdom.

The *torques* or *torquis*, now commonly called the torque,² was a distinctively Celtic ornament, being a circle of gold curiously twisted on itself, sometimes serving as a collar, sometimes larger as a girdle, and yet again smaller, perhaps for the head. Virgil, indeed, has used the term as a synonym for a crown, but even so this proves that this Celtic ornament was held in high honour—another evidence of the persistence of Gaulish or Celtic usage. Can it be supposed possible that in that

¹ *tertia lux refugis Hyperiona fuderat astris :
concurrunt proceres, ac milite circumfuso
aggere composito statuunt, ac torque coronant
castrensi maestum, donantque insignia regni.* 576.

² The finest collection of Torques is to be found in the Museum of the Royal Irish Academy, Dublin. It is significant that torques have been noted in Galatia.

century, when a Druidic College (perhaps several) still existed, when the ancient customs of king-choosing and king-making were so faithfully observed, no word of the old language was spoken in the enthusiastic crowds? It is of all things the most improbable—Sidonius himself the great Gallo-Roman must have known the Gallic language.¹

Indeed, M. Nisard, commenting on a certain strangeness in the prose of Sidonius says the classic mould is broken and asks, "To what should we attribute this change? Very probably to the vulgar Latin spoken around him, and itself necessarily much modified by the Celtic: perhaps to the Celtic itself, which must have been the language of the great majority of the population, since the nobility had but very recently given up the use of that language."²

But had the nobility quite renounced their ancient language, even at this period, save for domestic use, and

¹ This may be inferred from a passage in his "Farewell to My Booklet." Directing its course to the homes of his friends he observes that it will reach a snowy region:

et quantum indigenae volunt putari
sublimem in puteo videbis urbem.

This might be rendered, as M. Nisard notes: "Here the natives would have it you shall see in a well a magnificent City." But the poet was playing on the Gaulish word "Puy" (puteus), a hill—"Puteus a Gallico mons, collis." Ducange.

The jest would not have been made if the poet had not an audience knowing Celtic to appreciate it.

Recently some caverns were discovered in central France, and it was noted that the natives called them "Avens." Now there is a district in Cork County, known as the "Ovens," where there are caverns: both words come from the same Celtic term: "Uamha" (Uava), a cave.

² "Peut-être au Celtic lui-même, qui devait être encore la langue de la plus grande partie de la population, puisque la noblesse n'avait renoncé que depuis fort peu de temps à l'usage de cette langue." Nisard, *Études*.

occasions? The statement seems to be based on a passage in a letter, written by Sidonius to his brother-in-law, Ecdicius, in the year 474,¹ that is at the beginning of the last quarter of the fifth century. Ecdicius, the son of Avitus, and General-in-chief of cavalry in Gaul, had just, by a brilliant exploit, driven back the Visigoths, who were besieging Clermont. With but eighteen mounted soldiers he charged down upon their thousands with such dash and daring that, taken by panic, they retreated to a hill-top. Never, wrote Sidonius, did the Auvernese love him with such passionate devotion. There were many reasons, he writes, for their affection from the first, these he mentions, and passes (till he comes to his exploit), all the dear claims of one's native place, the happy memories of childhood, boyhood, youth, games, and college friends. His education made Clermont a great resort of learned men, and increased its fame.

Then come these passages: "1° Mitto istic ob gratiam pueritiae tuae undique gentium confluisse studia litterarum, tuaeque personae quondam debitum, quod sermonis Celtici squammam depositura nobilitas, nunc oratoris stylo, nunc etiam camoenalibus modis imbuebatur.

2° "Illum in te affectum principaliter universitatis accendit quod, quos olim Latinos fieri exegeras barbaros deinceps esse vetuisti."

This may be rendered: "I pass here, that it was because of thy youth men flowed hither from all parts, for the cultivation of Learning, that it was once owing to thyself that, on laying aside the shell (or the mail) of Celtic speech they now began to be imbued with the art of oratory and even with metrical methods."

There has, I think, been some misapprehension as regards the expression "sermonis Celtici squammam

¹ *Epistolae*, xc.

depositura." M. Nisard translates it "de dépouiller la rouille du langage celtique," and Mr. Dalton wrongly says, "to forsake the barbarous Celtic dialect." Now "squama" is not "squalor," it means a scale, and here I believe it is used figuratively for scale-armour, which might be commendable (as in Virgil: "Duplice squama lorica fidelis et auro"). When they had laid aside the scale armour of their Celtic speech they could imbibe Latin rhetoric and verse. Sidonius would certainly not have insulted his beloved Averni by calling them barbarians. But what of passage No. 2: "That which chiefly quickened the affection of all the people for thee is that those whom thou had once laboured to make Latins, thou hast henceforth prevented from being barbarians"?

What does this passage prove? Evidently, that the Averni nobles did speak the Celtic language generally until late in the fifth century, and next that Ecdicius induced them (or some of them, not the people) to lay aside their Celtic prepossessions and to take to the study of Latin rhetoric and verse.

This Sidonius thought much of, naturally. But how willingly one would suffer the sacrifice of a score of his fastidious poems, for one genuine song of the Celt, or one lay of the Goth, of that time!

But what of the second phrase cited? Mr. Dalton, having inaccurately rendered "sermonis Celtici squammam" by "barbarous Celtic dialect," thinking the second phrase refers to the barbarous dialect, turns it as if a "relapse again" were the danger. He translates it: "Nothing so kindled universal regard for you as this, that you first made Romans of them and never allowed them to relapse again."

Now that is not the meaning of the words of Sidonius: "That which lights up all men's love for thee is that those whom thou hadst once laboured to render Latins, thou

hast prevented being barbarians." And he then at once shows how it was prevented — by a description of the victory of Ecdicius over the Visigoths !

There was the danger. This is clearly proved by a previous letter (xl. 470) where four years before, Sidonius presses Ecdicius to go to Clermont quickly, as Seronatus was favouring the barbarians and depreciating the Romans, "exultans Gothis, insultansque Romanis." Mr. Dalton saw and translated this : "He cries the Goths up and the Romans down." He failed to notice that this was the danger from which Ecdicius delivered them, not from that of a "relapse."

From the evidence placed before the reader, it is shown that the Celtic language still existed behind the official Latin, that it possessed a vitality so vigorous as to modify the Latin speech, and that consequently it was reasonable to seek and natural to find traces of its influence in Latin verse by Celtic authors.

PART V

THE GOLDEN AGE OF CHRISTIAN LITERATURE :

GAUL, GREECE AND ROME

THE fourth century may well be styled the Golden Age of Christian Literature, and Gaul is brightened in its radiance. Treves became a centre of Empire. Constantine Chlorus was already there when the era opened, and gave encouragement to learning and the Schools. Lactantius, who had gone to teach rhetoric in Africa, was recalled to teach in Gaul. Constantine the Great adorned Treves, and increased the privilege of the professors of the arts and sciences throughout the land.

The vision of the celestial Cross was seen by Constantine in Gaul. His brothers dwelt and his nephews were educated there.

St. Athanasius, Archbishop of Alexandria, was banished to Treves for three years, and in this Celtic city was born St. Ambrose, whose father was Prefect. To this home of his youth he returned from Milan on at least two occasions : once to prevent Maximus from invading Italy, and to conclude a peace in the name of the child Emperor Valentinian II., in which he succeeded ; and later to plead for the slain body of Gratian, in which he failed. Constans resided at Treves, but Julian, as Caesar, preferred Paris, where the ruins of his great baths still remain in the Latin Quarter.

He called Oribasius to that newer centre, but St. Hilary,

the first Gallic hymn-writer, was banished to far-away Phrygia, from which place Hilary sent his daughter two hymns ; he returned free, however, in four or five years. Arborius, Exuperius, and Ausonius, all three Gauls, were preceptors of the Emperor Constantine's son, of his nephews, and of Gratian.

There were also Gallic women of high distinction—Aemilia Hilaria, an esteemed physician, the aunt of the poet Ausonius, and Eunomia, daughter of the Orator Nazarius, who became celebrated for her great eloquence. With these were the two correspondents in far Armorica of St. Jerome, who himself spent his youth, as he says in Gaul, and who evidently knew enough of Celtic to recognise it when he heard it spoken in Galatia, the ancient Celtic Settlement in Asia Minor.

Not until the tenth general Persecution of the Christians was over can we look with fairness for their appearance in the fields of general learning. When the Theban Legion had been slaughtered and the Era of Martyrs had concluded, their opportunity came, and they used it. At the beginning of this fourth century the frightful Persecution drenched the earth with their blood ; at the close of it they had accomplished so much that this has been named the Golden Age of Christian Literature.

Nor must we imagine that they stood fanatically aloof from the instruction of pagan philosophers, intent only on denouncing them. The esteem in which Plato and Aristotle have ever been held should teach a different lesson. But surely no evidence could be more satisfactory than the kind and constant correspondence kept up between the steadfast old pagan rhetorician, Libanius of Antioch and his illustrious pupil, St. Basil the Great, of Cappadocia.

St. Basil used to send him Cappadocians as pupils, to his School at Athens, and Libanius was always willing to

instruct any poor friend of his friend's gratuitously. One sent his sermons to be criticised, the other his orations. The letters of both abound in pleasant interchange of gentle repartee and play of Attic wit.

The surly separation which some conjure up had no existence in fact. When the Christians were permitted to show themselves they poured into the Schools.

At Antioch St. Basil and St. Chrysostome were pupils of Libanius. At Athens St. Gregory and his brother Cesarius were fellow-students with Julian—afterwards that Emperor named "the Apostate," who sought to revive paganism.

In the busy commercial city of Alexandria, so famed for its Schools and its fine researches and discoveries as regards the brain and other organs, where the Christians were more numerous, they established Schools of their own, but made use of the great Library which was common to all. It might be that some of the eminent pagan teachers, like Victorinus, were won to their belief. Thus by instruction or through conversions the Christians succeeded to the great heritage of whatever of the arts and sciences were the possession of the elder world. Here is a picture illustrative of the time and yet surprising by its unexpectedness :

In the middle of the fourth century, two Cappadocian brothers, born at Nazianzus, met once again—after completing their studies in the imperial city of Constantine. One came from Athens, the other from Alexandria : the first was Gregory, now a bishop and an illustrious Christian orator, the second was Cesarius, already renowned as a philosopher and a physician. This capacity for knowledge, which would injure his medical practice if he were now alive (as that of Harvey was injured by his discovery of the circulation of the blood), did him no hurt but rather credit in those larger and more liberal times. Nor did

his religion exclude him from recognition. The position of Senator was pressed upon him, although he was a Christian, and his attainments were so great that he was acknowledged to be the first physician in Constantinople.

The Emperor Julian the Apostate consulted him professionally as a physician and was pleased to hold discourse with him as a philosopher and to number him amongst his friends. The fact is not less honourable to Cesarius than creditable to Julian, an Emperor who stands in need of all our charity, for Cesarius withstood every effort made to induce him to renounce his faith, and Julian contented himself with exclaiming, "Happy father, hapless children." If this were a menace no ill consequence followed.

By the oration which it was the sad privilege of St. Gregory to deliver over the bier of his dead brother, we learn what were some of the elements of this philosophic physician's education in the fourth century, and how deep was his brotherly love. This is my translation of the words of the preacher :

He will never more study the works of Hippocrates, of Galen and of their adversaries, but he shall never again have to endure the pain of sickness nor suffer from another's woe. The writings of Euclid, Ptolemy, and Hieron shall no longer be explained by him, but neither shall his eyes be offended by the sight of presumptuous ignorance. Henceforth he will not comment the philosophies of Plato, Aristotle, Pyrrho, Democritus, Heraclitus, Anaxagoras, Cleanthus, Epicurus, or other sages of the Porch or of Academe, but he is set free from the toil of unravelling their doctrines. . . . Now the time comes when I shall hear the voice of the Archangel Michael and the sound of the last trumpet, when heaven and earth shall be transfigured and the whole world renewed. Then I shall see Cesarius, not in sorrow, nor in tears, but in

radiant splendour and triumphant—as thou hast appeared to me in my dreams, O dearest and fondest of brothers!

With this most beautiful, most pathetic passage, which moves the human heart after more than a thousand years, we leave the Eastern world for Rome.

When Christianity came forth from the glorious gloom of the Catacombs, it next passed into the splendour and the perils of imperial fosterage. Theodosius the Great wore the diadem of Constantine, but Arianism had become powerful in the East and paganism was still strong in the West. Because the Emperor Gratian had ventured to remove from its place in the Capital the Statue of Victory—a last remnant of Paganism—Maximus raised aloft its old standard, in the van of its veterans, encountered and slew him at Lyons, refusing his dead body to the prayer of Ambrose.

Not until four years later did Theodosius and Maximus (both Spaniards by birth) meet in conflict, when that death was avenged and the pagan empire crushed. But neither this conquest of paganism in the West, nor the repulse of the Goth in the North, neither the arrest of the Persian march in the East, nor the annihilation of Arianism and of idolatry throughout the Roman world availed Theodosius when, red from massacre of Arians in Thessalonica, he sought to enter a Christian Church. Ambrose, unarmed, stood in the portal, and the conqueror, conquered, passed in as a penitent. This was the triumph of the Spirit over the Sword, which, till then, had made morality for the masses of mankind.

This sight Sedulius may have witnessed in Milan, but he came too late to profit by the teaching in the State School of an African professor of rhetoric, Augustine. Their lives, however, had certain lines of likeness. Both had been pagans in their youth, both were foreigners, both came to Italy and taught philosophy, both became

converts to Christianity, both taught schools and both died bishops. From St. Augustine's *Confessions* we get a vivid picture of southern school-life in those early days, and of experiences that were more or less common to both. Boys were boys even then: they sometimes went unwillingly to school, were chastised when negligent, and felt keenly the unkind laughter of their elders. Balls and birds served as playthings, they trafficked in trifles, ransacked the pantries, and occasionally left their own goodly gardens to rob a neighbour's sour pears. In the primary class, arithmetic had no charm for some young minds like Augustine's: "One and one two; two and two four"¹ was an odious chant; the rudiments of Latin grammar were bad and Greek was worse, but how entrancing to hear the tale of Troy, to watch the wooden horse, to see the flare of flames, to pale before the shade of Creusa, and weep the hapless fate of Dido! What a triumph to stand up before professors, students, and strangers, and win first place by the delivery of a spirited oration, showing how pious Aeneas baffled imperious Juno, and reached the shores of Italy safe at last. The applause was delicious, but masters and audience were most particular. You might hate your neighbour and escape hisses, but you were disgraced utterly if you dropped your "h"—and said "ominem" for "hominem."²

From small schools boys went to larger, and thence again to larger. Thus Augustine went from Tagaste to Madaura and from Madaura to Carthage, where he became head scholar in the School of Rhetoric—the object was to excel in oratorical art and artifice so as to become an expert and unscrupulous advocate. Here

¹ Iam vero unum et unum duo, duo et duo quatuor odiosa cantio mihi erat et dulcissimum spectaculum vanitatis equus ligneus plenus armatis et Troiae incendium atque ipsius umbra Creusae.

² Its occupation by Romans and by French may account for a similar defect in London.

was a clique of students, the "evertores," whose chief sport was to delude and bewilder strangers. As all the school-work was over in the forenoon there was plenty of time to listen to declamation in the Forum, and to hear Terence played in the evening.

When his course of study had been concluded, and some reputation gained in public discourses, Augustine returned to his own small town as professor of rhetoric. Then he succeeded in setting up a school in Carthage itself, but the Carthaginian students were unruly and turbulent. Bands from one school used to break into other schools upsetting everything. Rome attracted him. Hiereus, known as the Syrian, though a Gaul by extraction, the renowned orator, was there, and Augustine had already dedicated a book to him. The young African was assured that fees and fame awaited his coming; and above all, the students were urbane and orderly. To Rome he went, but discovered, when he had gathered pupils to his lodgings, that the urbane and orderly pupils had, too many of them, the disconcerting habit of studiously attending lectures and suddenly disappearing when fees were payable.¹

This induced him to apply for a vacant professorship at Milan. Symmachus, Prefect of Rome, had the appointment, as the school was maintained by the State and the Manichaeans had interest enough with him to secure the place for a competent candidate. So he obtained it, and went to teach in Cisalpine Gaul.

Whilst studying oratory, Augustine happened on Cicero's *Hortensius*; this turned his mind to philosophy. Following wisdom he made an examination of the new faith which had survived all persecution; but he, like many others, was at first repelled by the style of the sacred

¹ In Ireland the law provided for the support of outworn masters by their pupils.

Scriptures, so different from the Ciceronian in which they had been trained. Still, drawn by spiritual desires, he came amongst the Manichaeans, but left when he found that their Bishop Faustus, an eloquent shallow man, was ignorant of the liberal sciences, then he dabbled for a while in astrology, until dissuaded by a learned pagan physician. In this uncertain state was his questing intellect when he came to Milan, and met Ambrose, who, overlooking differences of faith, welcomed him with fatherly kindness. Often the young professor went to hear him preach, weighing his words and methods as a study of oratory ; the substance and spirit finally caught his reason and convinced him. The Bishop's house was open to all comers, and Augustine frequently came to confer with him. Sometimes, when there were no visitors, Augustine would find the old saint so deeply absorbed in silent reading, that the young scholar quietly retired, not having the heart to disturb him.

PART VI

IRELAND INTERVENES : SEDULIUS WRITES HIS DEDICATION : ITS WISDOM AND KIND WIT

AMBROSE was still a living centre of influence when Sedulius reached Italy, and his works with those of Augustine and Jerome had rapidly built up a new literature. It was no longer so difficult for a classical scholar to become a Christian. It may, however, be assumed that the state of the Schools had varied little, and that, in Augustine's story we have what Sedulius might have said, with this difference, that he did not become a Manichæan. He taught philosophy in Italy, and appears to have given special attention to poetry. Macedonius was his Ambrose. Some suppose that Macedonius baptized him a Christian, but that is uncertain. What is certain is that this revered friend, having apparently some position of eminence either as Bishop or as Abbot, invited Sedulius to Greece, and that Sedulius followed his counsel, established a School there—no doubt, at Athens. It appears to have been especially renowned for the instruction given in the art of poetry : in this it differs from the rhetorical and philosophical Schools of Rome, and indicates the influence of Irish bards.

The new Eastern Empire was responsible for this revival. Three score years before, Julian the Apostate had attempted to re-build the walls of Jerusalem, and, when we are told that Sedulius travelled in Asia it can

scarcely be doubted that he made his way to that Holy City and the land of wondrous history around it.

He was the first pilgrim from Ireland, if not the first Jerusalem-farer from Western Europe. Life must have been more marvellous to him than one can readily conceive. Born amidst the seas, his youth spent with nature, and the aerial wonder-world of Gaelic myths he passes through stately portals into the sculptured literature of Rome and Greece—the loftiest effort of disciplined art—and then beyond this, and beyond all human things, into the sacred orient land where, at every step, he finds memories of divine mysteries and hears the song of angels from the azure sky.

He pondered these matters in his heart. His ardent mind and enthusiastic nature impelled him to achieve something for his faith. Whatever his personal ambition had been, his position satisfied it. To a man of culture it must have seemed little to be set on a throne by the swords of sordid men, as culprits had been, but it was a high thing for him—a stranger from far-off Thule—to be called to teach the art and measures of poetry in the very fatherland of classic verse in the homestead of Homer!

Everything—his former fame, his present surroundings, the welcome he was sure to win—seemed to command him to continue in the ways of the great masters. But the new Christianity had touched and taken his heart; his impassioned spirit left him no rest until he had essayed to do for the True Faith what others had done for the false. The very success he had obtained would make him feel a dastard if he shrank now from devoting his acknowledged talents to divine things.

This purpose could only be entertained by a mind as original, independent, and adventurous as it was sincere. What other could conceive a revolt against the suzerainty

of Homer, whose imperial sceptre has such control even now that every day tribute is brought to his feet by scholars and statesmen, proud to be his subjects?

Thus came the "Carmen Paschale"—the "Easter Song" of the world—whose very name is a poem.

Sedulius was conscious that his work would be regarded as an audacious innovation. The fact that Juvenius had already produced a metrical Christian work was calculated rather to deter than to encourage, for it was little more than a versified narration of Scripture-history. It encumbered the ground, but did not occupy it. Students accustomed to the winged ways of pagan verse would not travel in its low levels. To this subject, however, our poet does not directly refer, whilst introducing his own work to his dear old friend Macedonius.

For, fortunately, we hear him still, as he excuses his boldness and explains its cause, in a grave and charming dedication. His prose style is somewhat involved, but its very elaboration adds a piquancy to the gentle humour and kindly badinage addressed to his friend. It is unnecessary and it were too long to insert a translation here where a summary may suffice to show the author's ideas.

Addressing Macedonius, our poet says, in substance :

Before you judge, Venerable Father, and perhaps condemn me for this work, since I launch a tiro's skiff on an ocean feared by mariners, let me explain. Then if you find me not presuming but devoted, you may give it a harbour in your heart, safe from shipwreck. Whilst engaged in secular studies I gave the energies of an eager intellect to an empty life and my literary skill to fruitless labour. The divine compassion overtook me. When the cloud had passed from the eyes of my heart, I found myself in a land of flowers, and my whole mind was dedicated to God's worship. Not indeed that I was fit for the work, but Christ's yoke is light, and

silence were a fault if the service of a studious mind which I had offered to Vanity I should refuse to Truth. Some little fire was supposed to glow in me, yet the torpid heart was a flint, barely emitted a spark. Even that gift it were wrong not to share, like him who kept his talent hid. So, with many and anxious fears I laid the foundations of this work, feeling that, whilst calling others to the harvest in the words of truth, their echoes would reach and remind me too, if needful.

Why I chose a metrical form is simply said. You know how rarely sacred things are moulded in verse, yet there are many who, in secular studies most delight in poetry and the pleasures of song. They follow Rhetoric negligently, caring nothing for it, but should they see something in the caress of honeyed verse they catch it up so eagerly that they grave it deep in memory by frequent iteration. Such habits should not, I think, be repudiated, but used so that one may be drawn naturally and won to God by the bent of his mind. These then are the reasons, eminent Father, and not over-empty, as you have said, for my work, to which, out of kindness, you may turn, of a leisure hour. The eagle does not always soar aloft above the clouds, but sometimes with closed pinions descends to earth. The veteran warrior sometimes puts aside his arms and enjoys a game.

So far Sedulius explains the origin of his great work : Now he comes to the dedication. In order to overcome the modesty of Macedonius to whom he wishes to dedicate it, he playfully feigns to believe that his friend objects to the dedication because he should have to read the poem, and that he suggests other names in order to avoid this tedious task :

But perhaps—in secret hope of escape from a wearisome reading—you may say, in your most gracious manner : “ Why, affable friend, whom I embrace affectionately, should you by selecting me offend others, my equals in doctrine, and members of the same community ? You have the most revered priest Ursinus, who never deserted the camp of the Eternal King,

pious amongst barbarians, peaceful amid wars. You have Lawrence, who so loved his property that he shared it all amongst the Churches and the poor. You have my Gallicanus, not learned in secular books but the kindest of men, teaching the rule of Catholic discipline rather by deeds than words. What need I say of the many-yeared patience of the priest Ursinicus, or of Felix, in every sense felicitous for whom the world is crucified? These and many other eminent men there are well suited for your purpose."

There were women, also, amongst these early Christians, held in high esteem :

Nor should you be ashamed to follow the example of Jerome, interpreter of the Divine Law, and fosterer of the Celestial Library, by dedicating a work to noble women, renowned for their talents, learning, and wisdom. Who would not choose and endeavour to please the distinguished mind of Syncletices, a holy virgin and deaconess? So learned is she that she might be a professor, if sex permitted, having a virile mind in a woman's frame. Her sister Perpetua, also, though of fewer years is her equal in deeds, illustrious because of her husband's power and yet more illustrious by her piety.

Having thus introduced the names of others as if by the voice of Macedonius, and so honoured each of them by a sub-dedication, Sedulius now in his own name endorses all the praise, and with fine wit makes it a crowning compliment to his old friend Macedonius :

All these things are right and proper, and again I reply : I beseech you, Sir, my father, do not cast off one you profess to love, nor harshly discountenance one you are wont to favour. Not one of all you mention do I pass over, in very truth, I believe in the merits and acquirements of each, but *in you I behold them all !* " (*sed in te cunctos aspicio*).

Could there be a finer compliment ? Then, having

given a gracious sketch of his friend's influence, he exclaims :

Cease, I beg, the waste of words, let all the long excuses end, nor feel it irksome, after the ocean-danger run, to lend the anchor of your authority to this wave-tossed work.

Sedulius concludes by stating that his poem treats of the Divine Marvels, and that he gave it the name of the Paschal Song because of Christ, our immolated Pasch, "to whom be honour and glory, with the Father and Holy Spirit, for ever and ever. Amen."

In this Dedication, as in a mirror, one sees the mind of an Irish "barbarian" of the fourth century; and it cannot be denied that the mirrored mind makes a charming picture. It was a kind and loyal act to dedicate his Epic to Macedonius rather than to some great ones of the Christian world. The highest would have hailed it as an honour, for an Emperor accepted the dedication of a transcribed edition. Little is known of Macedonius, who was then a priest, possibly an Abbot and perhaps a Bishop later; what is known is due chiefly to the mention of his name by Sedulius. The good old scholar was his friend, whom fame had not followed; Sedulius sought to do him honour by asking as a favour that which, granted, has made his name immortal.

Could there be anything more graceful than the device by which the Irish Scot makes Macedonius put forward other friends, or more gracious than the kindly wit which turns all into a compliment for his beloved Macedonius? Then what genial humour, what pleasant Irish banter is that which, in his correspondent's modest apologies, discovered artful excuses for not reading the Epic! Clearly a delightful companion and professor was this poet of ours, in whose character gravity and gaiety were so harmoniously combined.

His metaphors show how deeply his sea voyages had impressed him, and there was something of the sea in his great enthusiastic nature, that sparkles with sunshine, and darkens with clouds, rages stormily or flows smoothly, changing often but running deep. Here, one finds the lines of Irish character at its best ; respect for age, learning, and leading, loyal comradeship so sacred and so revered of old, with praise of women, recognition of noble ideals, playful humour shown even in a grave dedication, and an ingrained love of conflict directed to the overcoming of an old friend, to his honour.

Strong as was his preference for the poetic form it did not hinder him from undertaking the labour of giving a prose version of his work. This was done at the suggestion of Macedonius, to whom he likewise dedicates it, under the title of the " Paschal Work "—*Paschale Opus*. This is a close but not a servile rendering of the subject matter of the poem, the author occasionally going more into details and quoting texts. The Dedication of this work abounds in nautical metaphors and ocean imagery, so natural to the natives of an Isle whose ancient poetry reveals their love of the sea.

He knew what were " Wet Sails " ¹ (*vela madentia*),

¹ These are some of his sea-references in the second very short dedication :

" Sanctis tamen iussionibus non resiliens, iniunctam suscepī prouinciam, et procellosis adhuc imbribus concussae ratis vela madentia tumentis pelagi rursus fatigationi commisi per emensos cursus reuoluti discriminis, et Cycladas ingentes, quas praecipitanti formidine celerius ante transieram longa maris circuitione discurrens, ut illos portus et litora quae dudum praetereundo lustrari diligentiore opera nunc viserem." And again : " velut mare fluuiorum penitus incrementa non sentiens." And yet again : " nauigare rursus in aequore, nunc in portu iam nauigem. Tandem aliquando post undas calcare liceat nos arenas : tetigimus montes ex pelago, tangamus montes ex saxo et infirmos aquis irruentibus gressus nauali positos statione firmemus." *Caelii Sedulii Opera omnia, a Faustino Arevalo. Romae MDCCXCIII.* From this are taken all Sedulian quotations.

the lash of rain-storms and the surge of swelling ocean smiting the shivering vessel in the long circuit of its venturous voyage. Anticipating criticism, he cites the examples of elder writers who gave more than one version of their work, for which he says they deserved praise rather than the censure of a rasping tongue. Let those who carp at others produce their own work. All are readier to judge than to achieve, and calmly to criticise a fight from a fortress.

PART VII

THE EASTER SONG : ITS PUBLICATION : ITS EDITIONS AND MARVELLOUS POPULARITY

WHEN of old the work of an author was finished it was transferred to professional writers that copies might be made, multiplied, and published. In after times a great amount of such labour was done in the scriptoria of monasteries. Do any of those ancient manuscript editions of Sedulius still remain ? Happily, the question can be answered in the affirmative. Arevalus, who made very careful research, enumerates about seventy ; and he found traces of others. Fourteen were preserved in the Vatican Library alone ; almost all are on parchment, only a few on paper, and some of the former excel in beauty. A few are most exquisitely produced, adorned with figures, gold letters, and different colours.

But the most ancient, the most important, and the most interesting is one preserved in the library of the Royal Athenæum of Turin. This copy is on parchment in the antique square letters of the sixth century, to which period some authorities assign it. Its beginning is set out in capitals, and the occasional red letter lines are similarly shaped. The corrector, Abundantius, secures a little immortality for his name, by noting that he has revised the third book to his satisfaction.

The inscription, however, which gives an exceptional interest to the work is one which appears on the first page,

in antique writing, though less ancient than the text. It stands thus :

Liber Sancti Columbani de Bobio.

"The Book of Saint Columban of Bobio." It is a remarkable thing that the earliest copy extant of the Epic of one Irish poet-saint should have been preserved for posterity by the care of another Irish poet-saint—one, too, who revived the fallen classic literature of Europe.

Nor was this the only copy which Bobio preserved. Its library catalogue (tenth century) gives four books of Claudian, one of which includes some of Sedulius, and four books (perhaps separate copies) of Sedulius. One of these is supposed to be the Turin manuscript. Then Dungal, king of the Scots, presented to the most blessed Columban an orthograph of Sedulius amongst other books.

From the sixth to the sixteenth, scarcely a century passed without leaving behind it a manuscript edition of Sedulius, whilst, of course, some centuries are more prolific than others. In the revival of letters which distinguished the fifteenth century, the works of Sedulius, and of other ancient Christian writers, were eagerly sought for and elegantly produced.

It might be supposed that, on the discovery of the art of printing, Sedulius would be put aside by newer authors. There could not well be a greater mistake. His works stand prominent amongst the first few which were chosen for publicity, in print. Some of the earliest editions bore no date, and this is the case as regards the great Paris edition in quarto revised by Nicholas Cappusotus, and printed by the famous Jehan Pettit, which Arevalus considers to be the first. Utrecht, however, printed an edition in the year 1475, which possibly may claim precedence.

In the succeeding centuries France, Spain, Italy,

Germany, Holland, and Switzerland kept up a spirited rivalry. Edition after edition appeared from the presses of Paris, Lyons, Tours, Madrid, Saragossa, Venice (the Aldine edition), Milan, Turin, Rome, Leipzig, Frankfort, Halle, Cologne, Basle, Antwerp, and other cities. Edinburgh gave one edition. England and Ireland are missing from the names of the nations which have honoured him, and themselves, by publishing his works. Hence, the present volume has the singular chance of being the first, in these countries, to reproduce the words of Sedulius, though not all his words. It is also the first attempt made to present in another language a partial translation in verse of the first great Christian epic.

The marvellous and enduring popularity of the poems of Sedulius will be best appreciated after a glance at the following table, where I have compiled the result of the researches of Arevalus, supplemented by my own, in the British Museum, which add a few editions to those enumerated by that excellent editor, and supply those which have appeared since his own, the chief edition of all. In this table the edition-number is given in Roman letters, and the dates, so far as known, in Arabic numerals. There are, no doubt, a considerable number of other editions, which I have not had time or opportunity to enumerate :

TABLE OF PRINTED EDITIONS

Edition.	Date.	Edition.	Date.
I. . . .	1475	XIII. . . .	1510
II. . . .	1480	XIV. . . .	1510
III. . . .	..	XV. . . .	1512
IV. . . .	..	XVI. . . .	1514
V. . . .	..	XVII. . . .	1515
VI. . . .	1499	XVIII. . . .	1516
VII. . . .	1499	XIX. . . .	1517
VIII. . . .	1501	XX. . . .	1524
IX. . . .	1501	XXI. . . .	1528
X. . . .	1504	XXII. . . .	1534
XI. . . .	1509	XXIII. . . .	1537
XII. . . .	1509	XXIV. . . .	1537

Edition.	Date.	Edition.	Date.
XXV.	1538	LI.	1721
XXVI.	1538	LII.	1724
XXVII.	1541	LIII.	1736
XXVIII.	1545	LIV.	1739
XXIX.	1548	LV.	1747
XXX.	1551	LVI.	1751
XXXI.	1551	LVII.	1754
XXXII.	1553	LVIII.	1754
XXXIII.	1554	LIX.	1761
XXXIV.	1560	LX.	1765
XXXV.	1564	LXI.	1766
XXXVI.	1566	LXII.	1773
XXXVII.	1568	LXIII.	1794
XXXVIII.	1573	LXIV.	1844
XXXIX.	1575	LXV.	1866
XL.	1588	LXVI.	1868
XLI.	1603	LXVII.	1869
XLII.	1610	LXVIII.	1874
XLIII.	1616	LXIX.	1877
XLIV.	1618	LXX.	1878
XLV.	1654	LXXI.	1878
XLVI.	1671	LXXII.	1879
XLVII.	1677	LXXIII.	1881
XLVIII.	1701	LXXIV.	1885
XLIX.	1704	LXXV.	1886
L.	1713		

If we analyse this table, we shall find the following remarkable results :

In the fifteenth century there were seven editions of Sedulius printed and published.

In the sixteenth century there were thirty-three editions.

In the seventeenth century there were seven editions.

In the eighteenth century there were sixteen editions.

In the nineteenth century there have been twelve editions.

Hence, since the first printed edition in the year 1475 to the last in 1866, there have been seventy-five editions ; this gives, on an average, one edition to every five years and five months of the four hundred and odd years which have elapsed.

Excluding standard professional and collegiate works, how many books possess such a record of enduring popularity? There is not another Christian poet whose productions have so largely and so long delighted generations of man.

PART VIII

EDITED BY A ROMAN CONSUL : HONoured BY THE EMPEROR
THEODOSIUS : SIGNALLY PRAISED BY THE FIRST GENERAL
COUNCIL : IMITATED BY KING CHILPERIC : ANGELS
SAID TO SING THE ELEGIA OF SEDULIUS

LET us look a little more closely at some evidence of the high esteem in which our poet was held, and at some causes and proofs of his influence.

The first appearance of a great Christian epic made a profound sensation in the imperial world. At last an articulate voice had spoken for Christendom, and it was thrilled by the glorious sound. Here the deities of a phantom paganism formed no longer the machinery of epic poetry, marvellous in its beauty, false in its philosophy ; here the Christian found the beauty of spiritual life, and the moving might of the eternal verities.

One of the highest dignitaries of the State, the Consul Turcius Ruffius Asterius, assumed the honour of being the first editor of the work. "Sedulius," says a very ancient Vatican manuscript, "left his work dispersed in certain small documents which were collected, combined, and most elegantly published by Turcius Ruffius Asterius, an eminent man, a Patrician and ex-Consul Ordinary." Asterius was one of the two Consuls who held office in the year 449. He prefixes a graceful dedication, in elegiac verse, addressed to some person not named, but supposed to be the Pope. There is also a dedication in heroic

verse, of which the author is unknown, addressed to the Emperor Theodosius. Then comes a Virgilian Cento forming a poem on the Incarnation ; and, finally, the poets Belisarius and Liberius celebrate the genius of Sedulius in double acrostics.

One historic and most significant incident, which took place in the year 494, proves beyond all things else how important to Christendom the work appeared, and how highly it was esteemed. In that year was held the first Roman Council of the Church, where seventy bishops sat with Pope Gelasius. They had to consider the vital question of the authenticity of the Scriptures, to decide which were genuine, and to eliminate apocryphal writings. Having determined this grave matter, the Council next took cognisance of all notable works relating to Christianity, discriminating the spurious from the authentic, and those which it judged unsound from orthodox works. The Decree, which embodies the memorable decisions extends to fifty-four paragraphs. The thirty-fourth paragraph reads in English as follows :

“ 34. Also, we distinguish by signal praise the Paschal Work of the Venerable man, Sedulius, which he has composed in heroic verse. We do not nevertheless disdain but admire the laborious work of Juvenius.”¹

The distinction which the first Roman Council made between the works of the two poets has secured the assent of all succeeding generations. Juvenius made a metrical history, Sedulius an epic poem.

The Easter Song was welcomed, with such sanction and on its own merits, in every great school in Christendom. The list of its admirers from the days of Asterius

¹ 34. Item, venerabilis viri Sedulii paschale opus, quod heroicis descripsit versibus, insigni laude praeferimus. Item Iuueni nihilominus laboriosum opus non spernimus sed miramur.”

is long and bright with eminent names. Scholars praise it, age after age ; poets, amongst whom was Petrarch, extol it in verse ; saints quote it to enforce a moral or to define a doctrine. Its favour was confined to no nation. It had some illustrious imitators.

Chilperic, king of the Franks, produced two books of verse, in imitation of Sedulius ! It is true that Gregory of Tours critically condemns them as feeble, without feet to stand on ; long syllables were put for short and short for long. This doubtless was due to the absence of the classic metre-sense in the " barbarian " monarch and to the growth of the accentual method. But, whatever its intrinsic merits, the attempt of Chilperic proves the great popularity of Sedulius, and the respect felt by the Frankish king for higher things than wars. How few monarchs, since his reign, have made any signal in the high latitudes of literature !

Aldhelm, the Anglo-Saxon—a pupil of the Irish scholar, Mailduff¹—had better training when he, as Bede tells us, imitated Sedulius by presenting his work on *Virginity*, in prose and verse ; though he inverted the order, as Arevalus notices, having composed the prose first. The Irish poet appears to have been a special favourite with the Anglo-Saxons, who were so fond of flocking to the great Schools of Erinn, where they were welcomed as friends, and entertained as guests, by the generous Irish. Alcuin, a pupil of Clonmacnois, master of the School of Charlemagne, quotes and eulogises Sedulius ; but an even more certain evidence of his popularity is found in the unique honour assigned to one of his hymns, in the *Vision of St. Dunstan*.

It is related by Eadmer that when Dunstan was at prayer in St. Mary's Chapel within the Church of St.

¹ Mailduff was first Abbot of Malmesbury ; the name of which place is modified from Mailduf's burgh.

Augustine, he beheld in luminous vision the Blessed Virgin, surrounded by a choir of maidens, all singing a hymn of Sedulius in praise of Christ. She herself, in a voice of surpassing sweetness, inviting them, began : they followed, giving the distichs, alternately, to a celestial melody.¹

This supplies both an evidence of the renown of this hymn and an assurance of its increasing favour amongst the Anglo-Saxons.

But indeed every nation seemed desirous of showing that Sedulius was its own especial favourite. If his great epic were composed amid the plaudits of the Greeks, a Roman Consul was its first editor, a Roman Emperor accepted the dedication, and Italy produced the most beautiful copies. Yet let us not forget that the most ancient copy extant is from an Irish hand, and that Dungal, king of the Irish, presented an orthograph to Bobio. The Frankish king appeared in letters as the poet's pupil ; the Germanic world gave the most numerous editions ; the Anglo-Saxons showed the poet unique and exalted honour, whilst Spain (to whose liberal Primate the great edition of Faustinus Arevalus was dedicated) declared its affection by a fervent, though futile, attempt to claim Sedulius as its son.

His influence over Spanish literature, so far as verse-structure is concerned, had hitherto been overlooked, yet it was distinct and notable, as I have shown elsewhere.²

Sedulius prefaces his *Easter Song* by a short metrical address to the reader, in which he pleads modestly for a

¹ The hymn was the Elegia which begins thus :

Cantemus, socii, Domino, cantemus honorem,
dulcis amor Christi personet ore pio.

See Appendix, Irish Metrical Characteristics in Sedulian Verse.

² *Bards of the Gael and Gall*. Introduction.

hearing, and pays a splendid tribute to the great Pagan masters of classic verse. This is a characteristic of him. A Christian, in an empire yet red with the blood of martyrs, he felt his great cause demanded great intellectual service. He was not of those starveling Christians who condemn without creating, thinking it enough to censure men who work in error, whilst they themselves will not work for truth.

Still moved by the spirit of the Free Nation in which he was born, he could withstand the Roman yoke, whilst admiring Roman art. His effort was to break the bonds which subjugated poetry to paganism, and set free the literature which he loved. Both classic verse and Christian faith had been new to him, and he cherished a passionate love for both. The former appealed to his bardic training by novel metres, and magnificent epics, echoing with the clang of arms in which the Celt delighted, the latter broke down the walls of the material world and gave to his spiritual nature the luminous liberty of faith.

A true poet, profoundly convinced of the truth, beauty, and greatness of his subject, he was the ardent Knight-champion of a Cause against which all the imperial traditions of pagan culture strove, as yet unopposed. Modest as regards his own powers, his invitation to the reader is at once so gracious and so generous that it should disarm censure, if censure could exist unarmed. But when he entered on the subject of his Easter Song—the wonders of the Almighty's love, wrought for man's redemption, his tone is no longer apologetic nor his attitude deprecatory; he, like the stripling Israelite against the Philistine, stands forth before the mighty men of Pagandom, alone but undismayed, impassioned, bold, the great Interpreter of a great Cause.

THE EASTER SONG

TO THE READER

WOULD'ST deign, a guest, unto our Easter fare ?
Refrain, if thou'rt a friend, from scornful mood :
Nor hope repast of sumptuous state, but rude,
Content a frugal board, our best, to share.

Thy choice the feast of mind o'er feast of food—
If caught by sweetness of the rich and rare,
Go, seek the Lords of Lore, whose splendid fare
All dainties yield in countless multitude.

Whatever sea sustains, earth keeps, or air,
Thou'lt find it then : in jewelled vessels there
The golden honey gleams in glowing gold.

But ours, a platter of red earthenware,
Doth, with an offered welcome, only hold
The gathered herbs of one poor garden mould.

THE EASTER SONG

THE first Epic of Christendom opens in a manner not unworthy of its lofty theme. The prose literature of the age was almost exclusively pagan, the great poems embodied nothing but pagan ideals of heaven and earth. These, by their literary power and beauty, kept in thrall the cultured sense of Christians, whose admiration for the Masters was not lessened by the adoption of a higher faith. The celestial machinery of the classic epics to them, as to some indifferent pagans, was no more than the poetic presentation of an unreal mythology. Yet there must have been many, on the borderland, whom the splendid verse still affected, and it influenced, as nothing else could influence, the ideals of heroism and conduct of life amongst the people. Sedulius beheld this, and was fired with indignation. The figments of paganism had called forth all the powers of the human mind, and had been exalted in the world's noblest verse. With such efforts and achievements before him, how should a Christian—skilled in the poetic art—stand mute, who had a theme ineffably greater, infinitely beautiful, to inspire his intellect and command his allegiance?

Thus Sedulius begins his Easter Song :

BOOK I

WHEN Gentiles study their vain themes to raise
 In sounding words, and pomp of purple phrase,
 Assume the tragic mask, or comic mood,
 Or what of varied verse may seem them good,
 And search the soiled scrolls of traitor Time
 For murk memorials of storied crime,
 Shall I—though standing in the sacred choir
 Where song celestial mates with David's lyre—
 Shall I be mute ? nor striking Judah's string
 The wond'rous work of Christ the Saviour sing ?
 Whom all things vouch on earth, who thunders
 Lord

On every sense, by all the heart adored,
 Who heart and sense themselves bestowed, and
 Whom
 All Nature serves !

 He, by eternal doom
 Supreme, and with His Father One, by right,
 Apex of All, Creation's Crown, the Same, in
 Light,
 In Splendour, Virtue, Power, and Timeless Sway,
 Consort of Glory, Kingship, and all Might,
 In Majesty Alike ! Behold the Way
 Which leads to safety and the Paschal Day !

 This theme shall be my song : Turn every mind
 And heal, at last, the wounded hearts and blind
 Which mortal ill, which Attic thralldom keeps
 In fond delusions whilst the venom creeps,

Forsake Cecropian mire at length, and draw
The odorous air of health from Living Law.

It would appear from this that, in the days of Sedulius, Athens still had great influence over the southern world of thought. It may also be inferred that the poet composed his Epic whilst in Greece. Continuing his protest and appeal to the Athenians he proceeds :

Why, Sons of Theseus ! wander in the maze
Of blind Daedalean caverns, void of rays ?
Why choose the barren, where the good vine
 grows,
And for grey lavender neglect the rose,—
Give stone and brass in fanes profanely faith
And bond your minds to mute metallic death ?
No more abide in squalid dust of fields
And sterile strands, where arid earth now yields
No fruit ; nor longer tear from gory ground
The bitter herbs that feed ye not but wound
For feast Tartarean fit.

Far rather steer
O'er welcome waters that will float you here
To meads delightful mid the forest's flower,
Where home is blessed by God's supernal power ;
Where sparkling streamlets animate the path
And lave the soil, that never prickle hath,
So that to barns an hundredfold it yields
When brimming harvest fills the happy fields.

This is the first indication of that love of natural scenery of which we shall meet many and more striking instances. To me it seems the produce of another civilisation than the Graeco-Roman, but this question may be deferred. Here,

the great distinction lies between the Christian and the Pagan, in the matter of the invocation. Sedulius breaks boldly with classic tradition, from which even Milton could not free himself in *Paradise Lost*, and puts aside all appeal to the Muses, even as poetic fiction. His appeal is to God himself, eternal, omnipotent, infinite; and the great and solemn Invocation speaks the absolute and intense sincerity of the poet:

Eternal God omnipotent ! The One
Sole Hope of worlds, Author and Guard alone
Of heaven and earth Thou art, whose high behest
Forbids the tempest's billow-bearing breast
The land to whelm—which fires the orb of noon,
And fills the crescent of the milder moon ;
Who'st meted forth alternate day and night
And numbered all the stars—their places bright,
Their signs, times, courses only known to Thee—
Who hast to many forms, most wondrously,
The new earth shaped, and given to dead dust life :
Who hast lost Man restored, for fruit of strife
Forbid, bestown on him a higher food,
And healed the Serpent's sting by sacred blood :
Who hast, when men (save those borne in the
Ark)

Were tombed in floods of whelming waters dark
From one sole stock again the race renewed
(A sign that sin-slain man, through noble wood
Once more should be redeemed), and sent to save
One Fount baptismal all the world to lave !

Ope me the way that to the City bright
Leads forth ; let thy Word's lamp be light
To guide my footsteps through the narrow gate,

Where the Good Shepherd feeds His sheep elate :
 There first the Virgin's white Lamb enterèd
 And all His fair flock followed where He led !

With Thee how smooth the way : for Nature all
 Thine empire owns ! Thou speak'st, her fetters
 fall

And all her wonted shows new forms assume :
 The frozen fields will into verdure bloom
 And winter gild with grain : if Thou but will
 'Mid budding Spring the swelling grape shall fill,
 And sudden labour tread the bursting vine.
 All seasons answer to the call Divine !

So ancient Faith attests, so tell the hours—
 No time can change, no age abate Thy powers !

Whereof to sing, in little part, afraid
 I seek, as entering a great forest-glade
 One strives an over-arching bough to reach.
 What were an hundred tongues, an iron speech,
 Or what were man an hundredfold to show
 Things more than all the lucid stars that glow,
 And all the sands where all the oceans flow !¹

¹ This is an allusion to the passage in the *Aeneid* (Bk. vi.) where Aeneas describing the punishment of the wicked, says :

Had I a hundred mouths, a hundred tongues
 And throat of brass inspired with iron lungs,
 I could not half those horrid crimes repeat
 Nor half the punishment those crimes have met.

DRYDEN.

Almost the last and worst of criminals, mentioned just before this passage, are thus described :

To tyrants others have their country sold
 Imposing foreign lords, for foreign gold :
 Some have old laws repealed, new statutes made
 Not as the people pleased, but as they paid.

It is impossible to remain unmoved by such passages, and this effect—the triumph of poetry—is produced not so much by the art as by the deep feeling of the author. Pope's *Messiah* does not so withdraw our attention from admiration of the form to sympathy with the substance. It is exquisitely wrought, but we note too soon the excellence of the workmanship. This possibly was a result inevitable from his adoption of Virgil's *Pollio* as a model—a pagan poet could scarcely efface his art in worship. With Sedulius it is otherwise: we do not notice the carven stones but the altar built of them. His invocation is a prayer, from the impressive opening, with its rapid reference to the illimitable powers of God, its deliberate enumeration of his acts of beneficence towards mankind, to the pathetic personal appeal which humanises all. It is instinct with enthusiasm and all reverence.

Then the poet enters immediately upon the subject matter of the Easter Song. He has put aside all the figments which served as scaffolding for the elder edifices of imagination: his faith is too fresh and pure to admit of that superstructure which even Milton adopts. He dares impute nothing to the Divine Being and His angels for which there is no authority in Holy Writ. However, his genius forbade that his poem should be a simple versification of sacred history. Hence, he adopts a new and different plan.

In language of sustained dignity he recalls the chief miracles contained in the Old Testament, not infrequently assigning a mystic symbolism. Here is a summary:

Enoch, he cites first, the beloved of God, whose years outlasted centuries: Earth was entitled to his birth, but Death was deprived of its heir. Barren age, in the person of Sara, was endowed with offspring—the Hope of the Chosen People was nourished at her breast. Over this, his only son, the faithful father at the altar raised the sword of Death, when the ram was accepted as victim in his stead. This is a symbol of the future free-will offering of Christ, the gentle Lamb, whose blood flowed for the deliverance of Man. Lot fled the chaos of Sodom, but his wife looking back bore the penalty,

for none should revert to evil things, nor turn away from the plough. The marvellous Bush glowed unharmed, burning yet unburnt, not yielding fuel to the ascending fire, but all its foliage fed by the friendly furnace of caressing flames. The harmless rod changed into a harmful serpent, writhing in clustered coils, which, with swollen scaly throat and darting trifold tongue, swallowed the hostile snakes and then, resuming its form, stiffened once more into a rod. The Sea separated, and through its divided waters the pilgrim-people passed dry-shod. To them, suffering in the wilderness, hosts of angels ministered, with nectar in the dew, manna in the air, food in every shower, and banquets in the rain. When after long drought the dry earth sickened, and life lost hope, the parched soil drank sudden waters, streams flooded the stones, the barren Rock became a flowing fount. These celestial gifts are types of Christ, the Bread, the Rock, and the Fountain of Life.

Again, beholding an angel in the path, the stolid ass stopped, trembling, and admonished the prophet. At Gabaon, in the midst of the heavens, the sun stood still, and kept the panting light with a longer eve, nor did the resting moon run her course till the sword had consumed the foe. The servitor stars saw in the herald name¹ the Jesus who was to come. Elias, a fugitive, was fed by the ministering raven, which daily brought him food, untasted, in its beak. True to Elias, though faithless to Noah, the raven expiated on land its delinquency on the waters. After many miracles, Elias was borne away to the golden stars in a flaming chariot. Right it was that he should outshine the lights of heaven, who was radiant by works and by name, for by a slight change of accent and letter Elias in Greek is the Sun.² Jonah, fallen from the ship, did not touch the water, but was borne safe through the sea in a Living Sepulchre. Cast into the seven times heated furnace by a Babylonian tyrant, the Three Youths conquered the penal flame by the mightier fire of the

¹ Joshua, the Hebrew form of Jesus.

² The Greek form of Elias is 'Ηλίας, whilst the sun is 'Ηλιος.

spirit. Great was the glory of the Believers, but prompt the doom of the ruthless king who ran raving from the resorts of man to herd with beasts in the field, and wander in the woods and hills. So, too, by the despot Darius was Daniel, the honour of Israel, confined in the lions' den : forthwith the wild beasts grew meek, and rather than injure the just one they accepted hunger, put away wrath, and kept fury in their fearful jaws. Then first fierce lions learned to spare their prey.

These miracles Sedulius first recites, with ample sweep of phrase, next, with terse recapitulation, he kneads them into a close and complete argument. Given his premisses, his conclusion is irresistible. The problem dealt with is one which apparently every generation re-discovers and thinks out anew. To-day those who claim for "Nature" or "natural law" a coercive domination imagine this to be a novel view, the outcome of progressive centuries. Yet, fifteen hundred years ago, Sedulius confronted it.

There is great originality and power in the poet's apostrophe to Nature wherein he blends and condenses his reasons and these illustrative examples :

Say, Nature ! these beholding, where thy laws ?
Who took these many rights from thee ? What
cause

Bade Death ignore its prey ? What potent breath
Blessed barrenness with fruit, and moved to death
The willing ram ? What changed to statued salt
The peccant spouse ? What told the flames to
halt

At leaves unharmed, the rod to writhe a snake,
The parting sea a pathway dry to make,
Dews manna yield, and arid rocks a stream,
The lowly ass to speak ? What stayed the beam
Of rapid-running hours, made birds delight

A man to feed, and who, in chariot bright
Conveyed him o'er the starry heaven's height ?
Who made the dying King live lustres three,—
Leviathan—a Refuge in the sea,
A Monarch mate with beasts ? Who could
 assuage
Th' indomitable lions' furious rage ?
 Who, but The Maker !—Whose are all things
 seen,
All unseen things, whose Word is the machine,
His works obey him, and His empire still
Delights to follow at its Sovereign's will.

Thus he reasons to vindicate the attributes of a Free
Creator not subject to His works, but they to Him.

Having established his position and demonstrated the
claims to respect of the Faith he champions, he makes a rapid
survey of the views opposed to it. Here, he displays not
only subtle analysis but a strength of keen yet genial satire,
more effective than any denunciation. Nothing could well
be seen more modern than his wit, or more recent than his
humour. It is worth noting that he deals most earnestly
with Sun-worship, and this perhaps because of a backward
glance at Erinn, where this as well as some other superstitions
mentioned then prevailed. Of course, many were also found
in the vicinity of the Mediterranean. That the vision of the
Author reached not only to Greece and Rome and Egypt but
beyond may be inferred from his words :

Ah, hapless hearts of men that evermore
Shape out some foolish figment to adore,
Your Maker flee and what you make implore !
What witless folly takes the senses now
That full-grown Man before a bird, a cow,

Half-human hound, or twisted snake shall bow ?¹

Some venerate the sun, because 'tis seen
To shed clear rays upon the earth serene
And light the farther pole—itself would show
By change and scattered fires its place to know—
A servant, not a God—that, ordered right
Must rise and set, and then give way to night,
And is not everywhere, in every clime,
Nor has it always been, throughout all time.

So some the moon adore, whose changing horn
Now fills, now fails ; and some the stars, that
morn

Will put to paling flight :—these worship fire
Those founts, but dare not with joined rite con-
spire,

The Fount might dry before the Fire-God's
frown,

Or else, if stronger, might the Fire-God drown !

Some, too, build altars at the roots of trees
Bring food, and then beseech the boughs to
please,

Rule o'er their homes beloved, their fertile farms,
Keep offspring, wives, and fortunes free from
harms.

O Wooden ! praying wood, to deafness cry !
And seek from dumbness a benign reply !
What god shall govern, when to help the house,
Ye prop the sinking roof with broken boughs,

¹ From Prior's *Solomon*, Part II., we get a passage (imitated from the xv. Satire of Juvenal) which is a curiously close parallel to this portion of the Sedulian passage, but without its wit.

Or feed the fire with chips for your carouse ?

Some worship herbs and, planting them, like
pease,

Go water well their dry divinities—

Sure, servers of transplanted Gods be these !

I shame to mention more, in sacred song,
Ev'n in rebuke, lest brambles so should wrong
The lilies fair, and thistles raise their heads
Amid the purple bloom of violet beds,
Enough we have of follies in the heap
To move a laugh, or rather make us weep.

This reveals the poet's heart. Gifted with satiric power, he uses it with leniency and grows compassionate, not bitter, over human errors. He kept thorn and thistle from the white lilies and the violet fields of his spirit as well as from the fold. There is no kinship with wrath or warfare in all he wrote, rather with ideal beauty, luminous with love.

This will be felt in the picture which he next presents of the Celestial City, the end and object of his pilgrimage on earth.

And now it joys to journey forth—to climb
The shining steps that mount the Hill Sublime,—
We haste unto the City of our love
For Freedom : bright, its royal halls above
The gold domes gleam afar ; the gates apart
Do welcome those who come, nor need depart—
All portals ope to knocking of a heart !

Behold the corner stone once spurned with slight,
Now set on high, most wondrous to the sight—
How sweet Thy yoke, Thy burthen, Lord, how
light !

The seventh line gives the quintessence of the Sedulius spirit and of Christian doctrine. In the original Latin it rolls in good Irish rime.¹

This glimpse of the Desirable City of which Christ is the corner-stone moves the poet to explain and define his course. He has shown, by the concordant miracles of the Old Law what was accomplished by the Father, in conjunction with the Holy Spirit, and by the associate power of the Son. Now he will relate what was accomplished by the Son in conjunction with the Holy Spirit, and by the associate power of the Father—ever remaining One God, wherein the simple is tripled and the triple simplified. This is the true Faith. With lucid and subtle eloquence he next explains the doctrine of the Holy Trinity, and dispels erroneous views.

Having shown the true path of Faith, and warned away misleading guides, the poet resumes his account of the ascent of the Hill Sublime, and the vision of the Celestial City. Before him Virgil had described the entrance to the Elysian fields, Pluto's palace, the description is brief :

The walls of Pluto's palace are in view
The gate and iron arch above it, stands
On anvils labor'd by the Cyclops' hands.

Before entering Aeneas, having made ablution, had to fix the golden bough above the gate.

How different is Sedulius's vision of the Celestial City, to which he is led, not by a Sibyl, but by Hope and Faith his fair companions :

Whilst we, discoursing, make our path more
light,
With comrade Hope and Faith we climb the
height :—

¹ *Pervia pulsanti reserantur limina cordi.*

There is perfect alliteration of initial consonants (p p c), and dissyllabic vowel rime, or assonance (in "anti" and "cordi"). See Appendix, Irish Metrical Characteristics in Sedulian Verse.

The topmost Citadel is reached, and there,
 See all the sacred Banners, high in air,
 That sparkle with the Cross ! Lo, glittering
 How shine the lovely Towers of The King !
 The Master-trumpet sounds ; the Gates invite
 The soldiers to march in—they pass who fight.
 On you the Eternal Gate doth call, whose voice
 Is Christ's, with golden guerdon to rejoice
 In life perpetual, who fought his fight,
 His weapons used, and bore His Symbol bright.

Thy Symbol and Thine arms, dear King, I've
 borne,

The least of all Thy hosts I wait, war-worn.
 Here, in Thine own abode, within Thy wall,
 Grant me a little Home amongst them all ;
 That, in Thy holy places I, Thy guest,
 May dwell and be on the white roll confest,
 Last ranked of all the City of the Blest.

Great things I ask, but Thou dost greatly grant
 Whom little hope offends and not large want.

None will fail to be moved by the exceeding tenderness
 infused into this appeal and by the beauty of the vision of
 the City of his hopes. What Milton has accomplished in a
 similar description has the great advantage of appearing in
 the author's chosen words ; but, if the question of diction
 be waived the passages may be compared.¹ The Celestial

¹

. . . far distant he describes

Ascending by degrees magnificent
 Up to the wall of Heaven a structure high,
 At top whereof, but far more rich, appeared
 The work as of a kingly palace-gate,
 With frontispiece of diamond and gold
 Embellished : thick with sparkling orient gems

(closed) Gate is presented by Milton as that of a kingly palace, but "more rich" crudely embellished with diamonds, gold, and gems. As the only kingly palace known to most of his readers was that of St. James' or Whitehall, their ideal of Heaven's gate was somewhat humble. His description is essentially that of Virgil's, being based on material structures, though transposed and adapted from an infernal to a celestial castle-gate. He does not give the gleam of the gold domes seen afar, nor the welcoming portals that open to the knocking of a heart, he does not see, as Sedulius sees, the flutter of the sacred banners above shining towers, nor hear the master-trumpet sound, and the cry of the Gate, whose voice is Christ's, nor touch the soul with the note of personal appeal.

In sight of the Celestial City, Sedulius implores the favour of its King for the work undertaken, calls his witnesses and introduces some of that mystic symbolism in which he delights:

Incline, O Christ ! Thou who, to make, through
love,
A dead world live, descending from above—

The portal shone, inimitable on earth
By model or by shading pencil drawn.
The stairs were such as whereon Jacob saw
Angels ascending and descending . . .

Each stair mysteriously was meant nor stood
There always, but drawn up to Heaven sometimes
Viewless ; and underneath a bright sea flowed
Of jasper or of liquid pearl, whereon
Who after came from earth, sailing arriv'd,
Wafted by angels, or flew o'er the lake
Rapt in a chariot drawn by fiery steeds,
The stairs were then let down, whether to dare
The Fiend by easy ascent, or to aggravate
His sad exclusion from the doors of bliss.

There are jewelled words, no doubt, in profusion, but what an appalling ideal of a Celestial City, where stairs were let down, and snatched away, "to dare or aggravate" Satan—like the mean trick of a malicious schoolboy.

To things terrene and human form hast deigned—
This nature bearing, yet Thine own retained.

So Matthew, first of men, declares to all :
So Mark, whose voice thrills like the lion's call :
So Luke, a young ox which the ark doth bear :
So John, whose eagle-cry ascends the air ;¹
Four chiefs who sing Thy glory with one voice,
As the four seasons bid the world rejoice.
So shine the Twelve, the apex numeral,
As months, as hours, that make the year in all
For Thee, an Army Apostolical.

Recalling now the birth of Ancient Death
I haste with eyes serene, to Life's new breath,
Long joys to reap : who sowed in Adam tears
Shall at Christ's coming put aside our fears,
And walk, exulting, with our harvest-ears.²

Thus Sedulius nobly concludes his first Book of the Paschal Song, by showing the glorious conquest of New Life over Ancient Death—the reversal of the Fall—the real Paradise Regained.

¹ The Symbols of the four Evangelists are : a man's head, a lion, an ox, and an eagle.

² Sedulius finishes this Book of his Latin Poem (as he does every Book) by two Latin lines cast in the Irish Metric, to wit :

*semina mittentes, mox Exultabimus Omnes,
Portantes nostros, Christo veniente, manipulos.*

In the first line, there are two one-syllable slender vowel end-rimes, "es," "es," and two internal two-syllable slender rimes "semin," and "mitten" which interlace with "ente" in the second, and "omnes" interlaces with "tantes" (broad-slender rime). There is vowel alliteration, e and o, for all vowels alliterate, though they rime only in their class—slender with slender, broad with broad. In the last line p c give consonant alliteration, whilst broad vowel rime is obtained in "os," "os." It is remarkable that, according to an ancient Irish custom this ending of the First Book is echoed or repeated in that of the Last Book.

BOOK II

THE Second Book tells first, the expulsion of the Primal Parents from Eden, because of their disobedience, and relates the advent of Death, and the decadence of the human race. There was no hope for it, had not the Lord, prompt to forgive, intervened to redeem that fallen race, so that what He had made in His own image should not be rendered unlike it by decay and death. He gave it the means of a new birth, and from the race of Eve, as a gentle rose from a thorny stem came Mary the Virgin. Having told of the Annunciation and of the birth of Christ, the poet narrates the incidents of the Holy Child, the Massacre of the Innocents, the baptism in the Jordan, His Fast and Temptation in the desert, and concludes the Book by a description of Christ's choice of the disciples and His teaching and explanation of the Lord's Prayer.

There are many passages of beauty and feeling throughout the Book conveyed in stately Latin verse : it gave Milton his frontal verse for *Paradise Lost* and the germ of *Paradise Regained*.

THE first of Man, by ruthless serpent cast
From Eden's flowerful seat, woeful, at last
In lures of pleasant taste drank bitter death ;
Nor he alone, presumptuous cause of wrath,
Fell 'neath the mortal law, but all of Man
The sequent race, who all in him began.¹

¹ Milton thus renders the original more freely, but with fidelity :
Of man's first disobedience, and the fruit
Of that forbidden tree, whose mortal taste

Ah, guilty spouse—who wrought the greater
ill,
Thou, or the loathly snake's perfidious will ?
Guilty the serpent, but not guiltless thou,
Alas, the double crime—eternal now !

The growing Race begins, and soon decays
With seed of ruin sown—where now the days
Of numerous life ?—where now on earth behold
The happy sires of centuries manifold
Whom sons in ten succeeding lines enfold ?

The Race doth know itself no more : by Fate
Irreparable conquered, its estate
Brought low, and through long lapsing times of
strife

Nought may endure, enclosed in short'ning life :—
Nor Hope bring turning help, for nought could
save

The future nations from the primal grave
Had not the loving Lord, forgiving all—
(Lest that His handiwork a ruin fall,
And what was made His image by His breath,
Should be unlikened by the taint of Death)—
Redeemed the world and caused the fruit, which
so

Set their sons' teeth on edge, its pain forgo,
Where Guilt gave Death now Love would Life
bestow !

Brought death into the world and all our woe
With loss of Eden.

See Appendix I. for the original text and a full account of Milton's
debt to Sedulius.

As from sharp thorns there springs, all soft and
 pure
 The Rose, which doth its mother's self obscure
 With honour fair, so sacred Mary came
 From stock of Eve and cleansed away her shame.
 Man's sullied nature in Death's empire lay
 Till, through Christ's birth, new birth all Mankind
 may
 Secure, and ancient taint put quite away.

Though Sedulius may follow Virgil in showing the rose blossoming from the briar, yet the greater poetry is in the fine conception of the flower cancelling and concealing the hurtfulness of its parent by its own beauty—literally, the faultless rose “obscures its mother with honour.”¹

Next Sedulius tells of the Annunciation, of the Incarnation and of the birth of the Redeemer, when the Word was made flesh and dwelt amongst us. Inspired the poet sings :

What new Light to the World—to Heaven what
 Grace !
 What Splendour, when, through Mary, to our race
 Came Christ with glory new, as comes again
 The Bridegroom, fairer than the sons of men,
 His lips more sweet and graced than ever spoke !
 O easy love, for Him who, lest the yoke
 Of mastering sin should hold the soul a slave,
 Assumed a servant's form—even He, who gave

¹ *et velut e spinis mollis rosa surgit acutis
 nil quod laedet habens matremque obscurat honore.*

These lines are clearly constructed according to the laws of Irish metric. There is consonantal alliteration (s, s and h, h), and there are vowel rimes, in this case of two syllables, inlaid “mollis” with “habens,” and three syllable end-rimes, “acutis” with “honore.”

Their every garb to all things that have birth,
Conceals His Majesty in garb of earth :—
Whom not the greatness of the mighty deep,
Nor all the land of all the Earth could keep,
Nor spacious vault above, our God confest—
Lo, in a manger lies, a child at rest !

Hail, holy Mother, thou who'st borne the King
Who Heav'n and Earth upholds and everything
Embracing, is Eternal, Infinite !

Thou, with a Virgin's honour, the delight
Of Motherhood hast owned : there hath not
been

Thy like on earth, nor ever shall be seen,
Sole pleasing Christ, incomparable queen !

These last seven lines in the original have had special favour and vitality. The salutation beginning "Salve, sancta parens"—"Hail, holy Mother" has been used, and is at the present time chanted, in Catholic churches over the world, as an Introit, on six festivals of the Virgin Mother.

Again, St. Bernard, in his sermon on the Assumption quotes the three verses beginning "Thou, with a virgin's honour" varying the order but not the sense.

The appearing of the Angels to the shepherds, keeping night-watch in Palestine, and the coming of the Magi, are thus told :

Then to the simple Shepherds in the night
The Angel Choir sang first the wonder bright—
For Lamb He was and Shepherd true, of right,
The while o'er Bethlehem such signs appear
The eager Magi came and, with strange fear
Alarmed the Tyrant, ever questioning
Where in Judea was its new-born King ?

For in the East a Planet shone, and far
Had led where now would shine His radiant Star.

Then Herod, having taken counsel with the high priests and scribes, sent the Magi to Bethlehem that they might discover the child-king, and return with the information, so that he too might adore—the while he purposed to slay the infant. Sedulius vehemently brands such treachery. His narrative of the mission of the Magi displays his love of symbolism :

Then sped the Magi, following the light,
In heav'n set, that royal Star and bright,
And kept their chosen way, where future law,
To that blest home, adoring hosts should draw.

Their Treasure, open in their hands, they bring
In fealty :—this Gold for offering
Is made as gift unto the new-born King,
To God that Incense, for the Tomb that Myrrh.

Why triple gifts ? Because Hope's harbinger,
Our Faith, the triple number doth enfold,
As God doth Future, Present, Past, behold—
Is always, ever hath been, will endure,
Triune for aye.

Admonished by a pure
Celestial dream, the faithful Magi spurn
The ord'ring Tyrant ; and forthwith return
To Fatherland. So too if we would know
Our Holy Fatherland, to Christ when so
We come, we must no more to evil go.

The massacre of the Innocents evokes the most passionate indignation of the poet. He questions whether a man, who lacks justice and cannot govern his rage, can be called a king of right. This gives us a trace of how the spirit of Christianity

fostered Freedom. Sedulius tells thus of the slaughter of the Babes of Bethlehém, by order of Herod :

His hope undone, now raves the impious king
In raging wrath—if king we call that thing
Who justice lacks nor rules his passions right.

So raves a lion, fierce from hunger's spite,
When from his jaws the tender lamb takes flight.
He rushes on the harmless flock amain
To rend, to mangle :—O'er the bloody plain
The air is filled with bleating cries in vain.

Thus ruthless Herod, when his prey he lost,
Let loose red Murder on the harmless host
Of Bethlem's babes.

Why die this multitude ?
Their lips, scarce oped to breathe, are choked in
blood !

Not reason, Fury rules the king, who slays
The first weak wail of Life—nor slaughter stays
Till guiltless thousands fall. One fearful cry—
A thousand Mothers' shriek !—assails the sky.
One tears the tresses from her head—one rends
Her cheeks—one smites her naked chest, one
bends,—

Ah, hapless Mother ! 'tis no mother's breast
Upon the cold lips of thy child thou'st prest !

What tragic power in the contrast between the tyrant's violence and the tender helplessness of opening life, whose first faint cry is stifled in blood ! We see also the distraught mothers rushing to save their babes and agonising over their mangled bodies. Then in the last two lines, what sudden poignant pathos !

The passage is the more noticeable as there is no special emphasis given to a display of grief in the Gospels. St. Matthew is the only Evangelist who mentions the massacre, and his reference to the bereavement is only implied in a quotation from Jeremiah, whose prophecy was then fulfilled : " In Rama there was a voice heard, lamentation and weeping and great mourning, Rachel weeping for her children and would not be comforted because they are not."

It is probable that Sedulius had in his memory the custom of his own nation. Lamentation for the dead, no doubt, existed among the Greeks, as amongst the Israelites and other peoples : but nowhere does the expression of passionate emotion, by voice and gesture, appear to have been so intense, so general, and so persistent as amongst the Celts. Even to-day their wail is uplifted in "caeine" and "coronach" over the dead, and strangers are startled at "the Irish cry." Some have been derisive in their ignorance, not knowing that it recalls the ancient rites of Rome, of Athens, of Troy ; and that it echoes, through thousands of years, the Lamentation of Rama.

The supposition that Sedulius was moved by the Celtic spirit, here, receives distinct and remarkable support from the fact that other Gaelic poets chose the same theme. In the "Lebor Breac" for instance, there is a most striking poem where one Mother after another comes forth to utter wild laments over her babe slain at Bethlehem. No people were so profoundly pious and none so little servile in their piety, so free, and even so bold. The Three Mothers have told their deep desperate anguish—the fourth is made to speak in fierce raving frenzy, calling on Christ to take her soul as well as her son—calling on "Mary of might," Mother of God's Son : "See sonless am I—for thy Son are slaughtered my mind and my sense, I am made a mad woman for want of my son. My heart is a death froth."¹

It is remarkable that Sedulius anticipates this cry by declar-

¹ See "The Mothers of Bethlehem," in *Bards of the Gael and Gall*, London. T. Fisher Unwin. 1897.

ing that Christ was present and suffered himself the wounds the victims felt. Apostrophising Herod, no monarch but a butcher, the poet exclaims :

What were thy feelings, butcher, gazing down
From lofty tower upon the slaughtered town ?
What thrilled thee when, through all the shudd'ring
sky

Despairing sounds and shrieks arose on high ?

Though absent from the slain, yet Christ was
there

Who all the dangers of His saints doth share
And feels, Himself, each blow that others bear.

We are next shown Christ, at the age of twelve, expounding the law in the Temple ; and then, at more length, the baptism in the Jordan, when John, who as an unborn babe had borne testimony of Him, now salutes Him : " Behold the Lamb of God who cometh to take away the sins of the world."

With the Fast in the desert, the Temptation is described in animated language :—when the Adversary is conquered, Shining Hosts of Angels are seen ministering to Christ.¹

Now, when twelve years of human life had
passed

He came within the Temple, and was seen
In wisdom older than the Elders ; He
Mid Masters of the Law a Master stood.
Nor did the close of Youth delay. What does
A world, flying through time, know of delay ?
Six lustres nearly, when to peaceful Jordan
He comes to get what He had come to give.

¹ This is unquestionably the original of Milton's *Paradise Regained*, its brevity expanded by long disputatious discourses.

Him when the Baptist from the stream beheld,
 Whom he, within His mother's womb, unborn,
 Had recognised, though closed as yet the prophet's
 Lips, which now bore witness crying aloud :
 " Behold the Lamb of God, Who taketh away
 The sins of the World."

That which I, not He
 Had, that He takes—the ill He has not done
 But has undone ! As when a brilliant light
 Shines through the clouds, and with its ray serene
 Undimmed, drives shadows from the unharmed
 face,

The Saviour thus, expelling all our faults,
 Cleanses and makes each stain to disappear.

Then in the flowing stream He entered, pure,
 So washed our lives' contagions all away—
 He naught having of that He lost—the torrent
 Itself was cleansèd by His sacred form,
 Its wave made by His presence consecrate.

The elements discerned their God—the Sea
 Retired—back toward its source the River rolled.
 So sang the Prophet : " Wherefore fly, O Sea !
 And Jordan thou, why draw thy waters back ? "

Emerging from the water's mystic gift
 He trod the strand, when lo ! the Heav'ns oped—
 To glorify Him came the Holy Ghost
 Descending as a dove (which has no gall,
 Thus teaching sweetness), and from Heav'n came
 A Voice, saying : " This is My belovèd Son
 In whom I am well pleased." Thus is declared
 The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit there

One only God by threefold reason proved.

Then having borne for forty days and nights
The Fast, still with the Holy Spirit filled,
The Tempter came to Him, with art insidious
Armed, and falsely off'ring a phantom feast :—
“ If thou’dst appear the Son of God,” he said,
“ Then bid this stone to bread be sudden changed.”

As though such marvel He did not, all days,
Perform, who to Earth’s stony breast gives power
In wheaten grain to fructify, and bread
From rock creates. Then the Redeemer’s voice
Repelling said : “ Man doth not live by bread
Alone, but by every word of God.”

Stricken, the Foe new arms in venom sought
And from a mountain showed Him all the world’s
Rich Kingdoms thence outspread. “ All these,”
he said,

“ I give, if thou’lt bow down and worship me.”

Perverse the speaker, and perverse the speech,
That He seek honours of frail kingdoms here
Who wins for man Eternity !—that He
Bow down to wretch unspeakable, Whose throne
O’ertops the Ether, Earth His footstool is,
Whom none perceives, Whose praise high
Heaven sings !

Christ answered to the Tempter, “ It is written :
Thou shalt adore the Lord thy God. Him only
Shalt thou serve.”

Defeated still, still he dares
With will superb, to wage the futile fray,
Thrice rising proud to be thrice thrown to earth.

For, next, above the Holy City, he
Placed Christ upon the Temple's highest peak
And said : " If thou wouldst seem the Son of God
Cast thyself down, for Scripture has declared
Thou shalt go safe on angels' arms upborne
Lest thou shouldst strike thy foot against a stone."

How blind a mind within how black a heart—
By its own clouds obscured, to think the height
Of Temple or its lofty pinnacle
Should Him dismay, Who bow'd the mighty
members

Of highest Heaven ; and, borne thro' all the skies
To Earth's extreme of lowliness, descends—
Who sought the low, nor did the lofty leave.

But Satan, by the true Word's glaive trans-
pierced,
" 'Tis writ, Thou shalt not tempt the Lord
thy God,"

Fled, moaning, from the Victor's face. Then
came

All Heaven's Princes, and the Shining Hosts
Of Angels came and ministered to Christ.

Then we are made present at the choosing of the Disciples :

He chose them first from Fishers, apt to fish
For human souls, which slippery joys enmesh,
As buoyant billows that uplift the head
Then bear it down, precipitate, and dead ;
These His Disciples were, these He did teach
Of life eterne, whom windy pride of speech
Filled not, nor vanity of birth : they came

In lowly minds refulgent, and mute fame—
Kindred of Heaven ! for He the Weak would
choose
To break the Mighty and the Wise confuse.

His teaching is summarised in the Lord's Prayer, which he explains with high authority and sweetness, defining God's sole Will and Man's good Liberty. This is a subject which seems difficult for a poet to mould into verse, yet the exposition which Sedulius gives has a peculiar interest and charm, both because of its subtle strength and of the light it reflects upon his pure and loving nature :

Now, therefore, showing swift Salvation's way,
The Judge benign His people taught to pray,
To briefly ask that they might quick obtain :
“ Our Father ” saying—ours, by baptism's gain,
His own by right : His honour thus He gave,
What He alone possessed this all might have,
Rememb'ring God our Father is, in Him
We all should brothers be—not through the dim
Sad bond of Flesh original, but flame
Of spiritual Fire, to end our shame—
And don the new man lest we, who have been,
Through Christ, adopted sons of that serene
High Father, fall, degenerate, terrene.

Where hallowed should He be, Who every
part
Has hallowed ? Where, unless in the pure heart !
That we might hallowed by our worship grow
He first Himself permits, and orders so
That we bless Him who blesses all below.

His Kingdom come : that Kingdom all so fair !
Where end is none, nor Death is anywhere,
Nor changing times deplorable, nor Night
O'ermasters Day ; where reigns our Prince of
 Light,
And Victor Victims throng rejoicing round,
Their noble brows with crowns eternal crowned !

With constant vows, by noon, we pray, and
 night,
His Will be done on Earth as in the light
Of Heaven—who nor sin would have, nor fell
Assault of foe, malign, implacable :
Lest bodies now tow'rd Heaven drawn, anew
Revoked on Earth, might in the thralldom rue :—
Who, all things fostering with love, would even
Preserve the body with the soul 'twas given—
One part of earth we are, and one of Heaven !

We hope the Food of Faith—our daily bread—
Lest that of Truth our minds be hungerèd,
And fast from Christ, Who feeds us with His Word
And Body : He, the Food, the Word—our Lord !
How cleaves His speech delectable, which comes
More sweet than honey in the honeycombs !

We ask Forgiveness as we do not fail
Ourselves to pardon debts ; He holds us bail,
Our word, His ward—more strictly bound if we
(Released ourselves) another will not free.
Should He—a thousand pounds forgiving—find

We nothing bate, but for a crown will grind
Some wretch ; forthwith the Judgment falls, and
cast

In dungeon dire we bide in bondage fast
Till all be paid, the uttermost and last.

Our Lord—the Way of Light, of Peace the
Path—

No tempter's snare will spread, but when He
hath

Our evil left, He leaves us go—who loves
The world's soft lures, its pomp and pride,
approves

Perdition's path : the Lover of all Good
Leaves him to go the downward way he would.
Let us step back, and seek ere it be late,
In heart, that rougher path which leads, though
strait,

To climes celestial through the Narrow Gate !

If man would Evil shun, advancing, we
Must follow Good—that fetters, this makes free,
This nourishes, that kills ; remoter far
Than fire from water, light from darkness, star
From Earth, from discords peace, and all
Abounding Life from the sepulchral pall,
Is Good from Evil. Lo, before the eye
Two paths, to right and left diverging, lie :
One calls the Just unto the joys above—
Thy welcome, Abram ! and thy breast of love—
One takes the guilty to their punishment.
God's Sole Will and good Liberty are meant

That all His Flock should, wolf-escaped, keep
 tryst
 And live in joy amid the meads of Christ.¹

So closes the Second Book.

¹ ergo agnis ouibusque Dei est haec sola voluntas
 et bona libertas, euadere torua cruenti
 ora lupi, vitaeque frui per pascua Christi.

The last two lines are in Irish metric: they have two syllable end-rimes (slender vowels) to wit, *enti* and *isti*, preceded by three-syllabled inlaid rimes (broad vowels) *torua* and *pascua*. There are two consonants alliterations in each, t c and p c. See Appendix II.

BOOK III

THE Third Book opens with that beginning of Miracles wrought at the Wedding-feast of Cana. Sedulius relates how Christ deigned to be present, not to receive but to bestow food. Having come, He wondrously changed the outpoured waters into wine. The liquid rejoiced to dismiss its pallid hue, the happy fluid to assume a flavour not its own. Generously on all the tables the sweet cups blushed ¹ with the best pure wine, though not vine-born.

From this until its close the Book is chiefly concerned with the miracles of the New Testament, which are related with so much poetic skill as fidelity to the Scriptural text allows. These need be only briefly enumerated here.

A certain nobleman besought the Lord for his dying son and Christ, denying nothing to the Believer, not delaying his boon, said : " Go, thy son liveth." He then passed, with healing in His hands, through cities, towns, and countries, hamlets, houses, and forts, curing all who were sick. One white with leprosy, cried to Him from the crowd and was made whole. Peter's mother-in-law at the gate of death from fever was saved, and many another was delivered from sufferings, whilst devils were cast out from those they tormented.

Then we come to the scene where, the poet having more

¹ mensasque per omnes
dulcia non nato rubuerunt pocula musto.

This does not quite anticipate but it may have suggested Crashaw's verse :

vidit et erubuit nympha pudica Deum.
The modest water saw its God and blushed.

freedom, can display more poetic power. This relates to the sea, which Sedulius knew and loved, as we are shown not only by this passage but also by other allusions in prose and in verse. Referring to our Lord he writes :

He sought the sea ; His footsteps press the dry
Shore-weed, and where an oaken skiff lay nigh,
He entered—His disciples followed fast
And raised the shiv'ring sail upon the mast ;
The ship ploughed onward and with fav'ring
breeze

Soon lost the land and crossed the middle seas.
But then a sudden storm the waters smote
Which surged in fury and o'erleaped the boat.
Fear seized His people, deeming all was lost
They stretched their shipwrecked arms towards
the coast.

He peaceful mid the tempest slept, Who keeps
Eternal watch—(because He never sleeps
Who Israel guards), so when, tumultuous,
Their terrors cry : “ Be merciful to us,
Lord, help, we perish ”—naught delayed His will.

The Lord arising bade the Winds be still,
The swelling Waves subsided at His word—
Not even Ocean when its deeps are stirred
With fellest rage resists ; nor yet the course
Of storms careering all in furious force.

The happy Sea to Christ in homage brings
Its lofty billows down, the Tempest springs
In joy away on softly wafting wings.

This is in the spirit of one who delighted in waves and winds. The purpose of the Book, however, commands his

attention. When Christ and His disciples had landed, there were brought to Him in the country of the Gergesenes, two insane men exceeding fierce (maniacs) whose violence had caused them to be bound in chains. They were healed. The unhappy spirit banished from them did not dare to enter a man—as Christ had assumed man's form—and so he took refuge in a wild swine, “niger, hispidus, horrens,” black, bristly, and horrid.

It is of interest to see that Sedulius, in depicting their approach, deploras the need of restraint by fetters; for this is, perhaps, the first time that any deprecation of manacles was made. Rigid restraint of the kind remained in force for over a thousand four hundred years after his time.¹

It is a happy thing for humanity that the poet's vision sees things in fresh lights and is not controlled by the commonplace and customary.

Another example of that perceptive power follows. It relates to one who, the Gospel simply says, was “sick of a palsy, lying on a bed.”

Then sought the Lord, sea-borne, another strand,
His body's birthplace, where His own command
To Him, its Father, made a Father-land,
Behold there come, a living corpse who bear,
Four men : and, on the litter lying there,
One, hardly man, alive, but void of use,
Death's Image he—his prostrate limbs lie loose,
Their every service gone, and flaccid all
His joints inert and strengthless sinews fall.

¹ In England, patients were still bound in fetters in Bedlam in Newton's day, and later, Lord Shaftesbury gave an appalling picture of them. St. Dymphna, an Irish saint, was the first to arrange home life for harmless lunatics, and still her good work survives at Gheel, in Belgium. Provision was made in the Ancient Brehon Laws, in the fifth century, in Ireland, for the care of lunatics, for medicinal plant gardens, physicians, and for hospitals, which should have a stream flowing through and a door opening to each point of the compass.

Within such brief compass no better description of complete paralysis could be given, nor is there any more vivid extant. One might deduce from this passage that Sedulius was a physician as from others that he was a mariner, if we were to apply to him some of the methods applied to Shakespeare—with whom, by the way, there are points of contact in that play on ideas and words in which they both at times take pleasure. But the fidelity of a poet's description may only prove his possession of exceptional powers of intensive observation. He can see not only with the bodily eye, but with what Shakespeare named the "mind's eye," and what Sedulius long before him called the sight, the vision, the "light of the heart."

The prayer of the ruler of the Synagogue for the restoration of his only daughter is given in moving terms, and we have the incident of the healing of a woman who touched the hem of Christ's garment. On the arrival of the Redeemer at the house of Jairus, the sound of lamentation was heard. St. Mark mentions that Christ saw "the tumult and them that wept and wailed greatly"; St. Matthew, that He saw "the people and the minstrels making a noise." Sedulius, recalling possibly similar lamentations in his native land, depicts the scene in language which would apply even to the Celtic Ireland of to-day :

He reached the wailing walls, the House of
Sighs,
Where smote by doom the death-pale maiden
lies :
A trembling tumult ululates, of groans
And bitter cries, the flute funereal moans,
In weeping dirge, and frequent sound on sound
Of lamentable blows ¹ the place confound.

¹ In lamentation, the Irish Gael often smite the palms of the hands together : this would give the "plangorque frequens." Their minstrels also played the airs of lamentation.

This is a marvellously exact description of the Irish "caoine" the wailing dirge, with beating together of hands and mournful music.

The maiden was recalled to life. Two blind men were enabled again to see the light of day, and a deaf-mute made to hear and speak.

Then the Redeemer having compassion on the multitude sent His disciples into the harvest, first empowering them to teach and to work miracles. Sedulius lays very noble emphasis on the pure and selfless nature of the service that should be given by Christ's followers :

Then that His own disciples might achieve
Like deeds, it pleased Him all full power to give :
" Go forth," He said, " and to my people tell
(Enlarged not yet the House of Israel)
The Reign of Heav'n ; their cruel pests expel,
Cast demons out ; and heal the leprosid ;
Call life unto the chill limbs of the dead ;
Freely receiving, give to all men free."

As though He said : " I now confide to ye
My flock to guard. I am their Shepherd good,
And largely open all My fields for food ;
Let no man sell my sheep these pastures—Mine."

Thus taught th' Omnipotent the law divine
In apostolic ears, that thence the lore
Through after times should flow for evermore.

As from one crystal fount of Paradise
Four mighty ways of water take their rise,
And spread, diverging, all the world to bless,
Whatever be God's work—not selfishness
Of man, but God-confided—comes, be sure,
A pure gift, one that shall be given pure,

As though by Stewards not by Traders held.
 So David sang in canticles of eld :
 " I yet shall enter, where my hopes aspire,
 My Lord's repose because I know not hire."

Then the poet relates the healing of the withered hand in the Synagogue, that of the blind and stammering man, and of the woman bowed down with infirmities. Moses in the desert, feeding his people with manna, is taken as a true prophetic type of Christ, who, in the wilderness, multiplies the loaves and fishes for the multitude on whom He has compassion.

We come to the time when Christ at eve, having sent His disciples across the sea, retires apart to pray. Here the poet gives a beautiful description—vivid as a picture—of the approach of night and of the appearance of our Lord upon the waters :

The dying Day beyond the warm blue wave
 Of ocean sinks, that forth may come the grave
 Pale Night, and Hesper lead her starry shades.

Leaving their Lord amongst the mountain
 glades

The Twelve put out upon the lake, where now
 The threat'ning waters rock the labouring prow
 And winds adverse.

As darker grows the air
 The Lord walked forth upon the waters there
 And trod their fluid fields ; with ripples fleet
 The sea, subsiding, kissed His sacred feet.

Th' amazed disciples saw the pathway o'er
 Ship-bearing seas : then Peter, evermore
 The first to know his Lord, essayed the wave,
 But, sinking in the waters, called, and clave
 Unto his Master's hand, outstretched to save.

That hand his haven !—forth he moved and free
O'er crystal meads, a Walker of the Sea.

Here, the raging billows change to happy ripples which kiss His feet, in the other sea-scene the tempest did homage by fleeing on softly wafting wings. The vessel reached the farther shore, and the sick at Gennesaret are healed. They depart to the coasts of Tyre and Sidon, and the beneficence of the Redeemer is shown in healing the woman of Canaan, then so abhorred by the Hebrews. The return to Galilee is followed by the multiplication of the loaves and fishes to feed the famished multitude.

Then Sedulius relates how, taking with Him three disciples, Peter, James, and John, the Messiah retires to a high mountain where they witness the great miracle of

THE TRANSFIGURATION

The mortal vesture, of His mother ta'en
With human form, was seen to veil in vain
The Lord divine. No city on a hill
Is ever hid, none neath a bushel will
A lamp enclose, but raising let it light
With spreading beams the darkness of the night.

Upon the mount He stood, made manifest,
His Form in all ethereal Splendour drest :
Sun-bright His Glory was ; His Face excelled
The glowing Day ; His robe such Radiance held,
Its fairness far the whitest snow dispelled !

Sublimely favoured Three, who thus received
On Earth to see what Earth has not believed :
With Moses and Elias to take part—
Unknown, they knew them by the seeing heart—¹

¹ *Ignotos oculis viderunt lumine cordis.*

That we, with larger faith, might henceforth learn
 The first and last of all things to discern,
 Alpha and Omega.

At either side

Th' adoring Prophets there have testified
 One entering Life, and one who never died.
 All heard the Voice descending from above
 Proclaim the Son and speak the Father's love.

By the prophet who never died Elias, of course, is meant. In describing Moses as at the threshold of life, Sedulius refers to the transference of his Soul from Limbo and the resurrection of his body when Christ arose from the dead, taking captivity captive.

Next we are told of the healing of one afflicted with (epileptic) convulsions, who fell, during his paroxysms, into fire and water ; of the tribute, and of the take of fish when Peter, at the Master's command, cast his hook into the water.¹

Finally comes the great lesson taught to mankind, through the disciples who came disputing as to who should be greatest in the Kingdom of Heaven :

Soon came disciples asking with debate
 Who should in Heaven's kingdom be most great ?
 Then He, as God and Doctor Wonderful,

¹ Sedulius describes this with the zeal of an angler. He tells in verse how the hook was thrown, and the fish bit the hanging line. In his prose work he goes further : " Then," he writes, " the more active swift inhabitant of the waves devoured the tremulous lures of the deceiving hook and was lifted from his nocturnal element by the whipping rod." This is a clear indication that fly-fishing was known to Sedulius. The " tremulous lures of the deceiving hook " (*tremulas hami decipientis insidias*) can mean nothing else when taken in conjunction with the epithet given to the rod—from *calamo flagellante* we must infer the action of whipping the water, as in fly-fishing. This form of angling is therefore of high antiquity, and still older writers show that the use of artificial flies was known.

Replied : " The Humble highest is : he all shall
rule

Who unto all is subject, modest, mild,
Who thinks himself the least "—ev'n as the child,
Whom in their midst He placed that men, made
wise,

The child-like character might recognise,
Nor years but mind regard :

The youthful heart

No pomp nor honours seeks in worldly mart,
Nor swells superb. A pure life's path though
driven

Most close to earth is yet most nigh to heaven.
For minds aspiring sink from what they seek,
The heart that would descend ascends the peak !
Behold, the Lord exalts the lowly things,
And gives them place among the mighty kings,
But casts the arrogant and haughty Great
To deeps Tartaric down, disconsolate.

Little I say His special acts to trace
Whilst meditating on His general grace.¹

¹ The last two lines are not essential nor even required, and are the more interesting because they appear to me added, in order that Sedulius might conclude this, like each of his Books, with a distich fashioned in Irish metric. These are his words :

*Parua loquor, si facta dei per singula Curram,
et speciale bonum, quum sit generale reuoluam.*

The last words in the lines, " curram " and " reuoluam " give perfect double-syllable vowel-rimes, and there is consonantal alliteration—p c and s s.

There are also four inlaid two-syllable rimes, " parua," " loquor," " facta," " bonum," which rime also, by their vowels, with the end-rimes, whilst " generale " and " speciale " rime in each of the four syllables. See Appendix II.

BOOK IV

THROUGHOUT the Fourth Book, the poet continues his narration of the miracles, partly told in the Third. It contains a wonderful passage, wherein Christ is shown weeping over the grave of Lazarus His friend. The Book begins with a scene beside the Jordan and concludes with the entrance of our Lord into Jerusalem, amid the acclamations of the people. It opens thus :

Beyond the placid Jordan's sands, He stood
Where, followed by a nameless multitude
Of human Ills, He, still compassionate,
The stricken healed and sent them home, elate.

For never to those hoping in His ruth
He finds it hard to give, who renders smooth
The rough, and straight the crooked ways.

In sooth

He does, Himself, what Nature does deny.
For, as the Camel through the Needle's Eye
Can never pass, even such would be the fate
Of rich men venturing the Narrow Gate
Had not the Lord of all (the Primal Cause
Who rules by law, yet uncontrolled by laws,
With whom to will is to accomplish, He
All things beholding, whom no eye may see),
Declared His power upon all things that are

Impossible to men, and lowered the bar
That stops the burthened Rich. For even they
Do well with riches who their riches lay
In Heaven's store, where rust shall not corrode
Nor busy moth destroy, nor their abode
Shall robbers break. Who feeds the hungerèd
Gives thirst to drink, receives th' unshelter'd head,
The naked clothes, comforts the sick, and these
In prison bound—who all necessities
Helps well, will for himself his substance sure
In Heaven place :—in giving to the poor,
Beneath that semblance he to Christ shall give,
So, losing, gain : and make the dead thing live.

On the way from Jericho, two blind men calling on Christ, with loud appeal, are restored to sight ; and so giving Light to the blind and strength to the lame He returned to Bethany. The unfruited fig-tree is judged and condemned in precept, not smit by malediction, as Sedulius admirably explains in his Paschal Work, adding that the incident is not accepted literally, for the insensible wood could not sin, but as a parable. Whosoever is unfruitful towards God, like the barren tree is likened to the wood for burning, whilst the Just shall flourish like the fair Palm-tree, ever bearing leaves, and shall, like the Cedar of Lebanon, be multiplied and reach to the stars on high.

When He has healed one afflicted by insanity and dumbness, our Lord accepting the invitation of the Pharisee sits down to eat with him. Then happened that incident of the woman who was a sinner and repentant, which Sedulius gives in a passage of pathetic beauty :

Then one, a woman came, all blemishèd,
Who bowed unto the ground her humble head

And suppliant clasped His feet ; she washed them
fair

With tears incessant, and, with loosened hair
She wiped them dry ; nor ceased the while to kiss
And them with fragrant oils anoint—till this
Her happy doom He spoke, whose hand still went
To heal the bruised and raise the penitent :—

“ Thy faith hath saved thee, Woman, go in peace.”

Thus says the Lord. Confess and thou shalt
cease

The carking ill ; the great cure this, indeed :
Who hides, augments, the wounds that inward
bleed.

He fosters hurts who will not bare for cure.
Yet see how one, long sullied, is made pure,
Cleansed by the tresses, when washed clean by
tears.

One moment's grief effaces many years.

From the Synagogue of Capharnaum, where the evil Spirit acknowledges the Lord, the poet follows to the shores of Tyre and Sidon, tracing the benefits conferred on suffering humanity. We are shown the Saviour, seated in Simon Peter's boat, teaching the people who are in a crowd upon the shore, and the marvellous draught of fishes when, after a night's vain labour, the nets are again cast into the water at his Lord's command. Entering Nain, they are made aware of the death of the only son of a widow—a woman twice bereaved. There is no long delay, Love—Grief's enemy—bade the youth arise, and the funeral gloom is changed to white rejoicing. Then also the woman tormented by a demon is restored to health.

In order that naught of the abounding harvest, from the seed sown, should be lost, Christ called other disciples,

seventy-two in number, upright men. He sent them forth as lambs amongst sanguinary wolves, giving them power, and charging them to fear nothing for they should tread over vipers, scorpions, and all power of the Enemy, and naught should hurt them. They should not rejoice that spirits were made subject to them, but that their names were written in the Book of Life.

It is the law of God which gives life to the dead : for on the cessation of pure service there is no miracle. Many have wrought in evil ways, to whom the Almighty shall say : " I know you not, go from me, ye workers of iniquity." So, in the time of Moses, some in Egypt, with the vain rites of Memphis, gave signs not of God but false illusions to the sight.

Sedulius resumes the narration of the miracles. His reference to those suffering through different ailments are not confined to generalities but are specifically described. And this is done with such vivid exactness and detail, in many instances, that the portraiture identifies the disease, and might be cited in works of medicine. To give such faithful pictures he must have been skilled in discerning symptoms, and have had experience amongst the sick, sure medical teaching, and an imagination quick to perceive how the ailment affected the individual. A poet might say of a dropsical patient, he was " big with unborn death," an ordinary observer might depict his increase in bulk, but it required expert knowledge to detect the hidden atrophy, and to say that " turgid emaciation wastes the inflated sick."¹ So also when he relates the healing of the lepers, he gives a forcible picture of leprosy.

Blind Bartimaeus² by the wayside, who refuses to cease his cries at the bidding of the crowd, until they reach the ears of our Lord and bring him relief, is compared to one who through the opaque silence of the night calls a friend in

¹ It is evident, I think, that Sedulius had read the works of Hippocrates and of Galen, and that he probably attended a Medical School.

² Sedulius has " Son of Timaeus," a translation of the Bar-Timaeus.

his closed house, for bread, and ceases not until he obtains it, by insistent pleading. The incident of the Samaritan woman who, drawing water from the well, gave Christ to drink, suggests that He is the true Fountain of the Waters of Life. The case of the woman taken in adultery is told in the simple language of the evangelist.

The sightless eyes of one who was born blind, his Redeemer anointed with native clay and bade him wash in the pool of Siloam, and he beholds the day. Know that this miracle is mystical, for we were all born blind ; the offspring of Eve, and bore through long error our natal shadows ; but God, deigning to assume human form and substance, is made through the Virgin our Clay of Healing, which, when we are laved in the sacred fount, sets free the cleared openings of renascent light.

The coming to Bethany follows, and that most pathetic passage, where the Divine Redeemer is seen weeping over the grave of Lazarus His friend. In these lines we have the great words, "Flebat et Omnipotens,"¹ "He wept, the Omnipotent," and the extremely fine and subtle explanation that as Man He mourned through all that flesh—which was itself about to die—with instinctive or innate shrinking from its own disruption and disintegration.

He came once more to Bethany, and there
Found Lazarus, cold within the sepulchre :

Four days had closed since first the stone was
laid

O'er him, now one of the decaying Dead.
His sisters wept, and all the people moan,
He wept, th' Omnipotent !—as man alone,

¹ flebant germanae, flebat populatio praesens,
flebat et Omnipotens, sed corpore non Deitate
exanimisque artus illa pro parte dolebat
qua moriturus erat, lachrimisque implevit amicam
maiestate Deum.

Not God,—through all that flesh which was to die,
He showed as friend His grief with tear and sigh,
As God his majesty.

Why, Mary, weep ?

Why, Martha, stay thy faith ? From caverned deep
Ye doubt that one may rise through Him, by whom
Unnumbered hosts of Earth shall leave the tomb ?
So when the loud Voice of the Lord was heard :
“ O Lazarus, come forth,” all broken, bared,
In mighty fear fell Tartarus ; the sound
Oped all of Erebus the dark profound,
And lethal Chaos cowed.

Death's rigid law

Was broke. The Soul resumed its Home again,
The Corpse rose Living to the eyes of men—
As though New-born, from out the sepulchre,
Himself His Offspring posthumous, and Heir !

This passage is characteristically Sedulian in subtle and antithetic thought, the daring paradox in the last lines would have delighted Shakespeare.

Immediately following this miracle we have the description of our Lord's entry into Jerusalem :

Contemning all the passing pomp of Time
To show His power He came, not borne sublime
With mortal pomp, on chariot's flashing speed
Through rolling dust, nor set on lofty steed
With clinking collar bright, and purple fold,
And tossing head that champs the blood-wet gold.
The Ruler's pomp a lowly ass sufficed
With service slow, but nobler, bearing Christ—
The burthen marvellous—and not unfit

Companion of that ox which stood with it
In Bethlem worshipping.

Behold the crowd
Strew garments in the path : Hosannas loud
Arise. Ye Gentiles ! say, had ever king
On earth such glory ?—palms for welcoming
With leafy boughs, and eager crowds who sing
Celestial hymns ?—save Christ, our Lord alone,
Who with His Father rules from Heaven's high
throne !¹

There are two points in these verses, which may need explanation. It seems an error to speak of collars on horses used for riding, but the collar in question was an ornament formed by hollow balls of silver or gold worn sometimes by victors and their steeds, as tokens of honour. The reference to the worshipping animals alludes to an ancient opinion. The words of Isaiah : "The ox knoweth his owner, and the ass his master's crib ; but Israel doth not know, my people doth not consider," were taken by some early writers as having a mystical meaning. Hence the view that in the stable, at Bethlehem, the ox and the ass adored the Infant Saviour. Arevalus gives a print, taken from an old glass anaglyph in the Museo Borgiano, which represents the stable. St. Joseph is seated a little apart, near the feet of the half recumbent figure of the Virgin, above whom is the infant Jesus touched

¹ Sedulius, as usual, concludes this Book by two Latin lines moulded in Irish metric, *i.e.* :

obuia Turba dedit ? Domino nisi cum Patre Christo,
qui regit aethereum Princeps in Principe regnum.

In the first line are two double-vowel rimes, "ino" and "isto," and three consonantal alliterations, t p c. In the second line, besides the obvious alliterations, r r and p p, there are three two-syllable slender rimes, "regit," "princeps," "princip," and two other slender-broad, "eum," "regnum," which interlace with two in the first line, "ino" and "Christo."

by her raised right hand. Over His head the star of the Magi sends down a ray upon it, whilst over the head of St. Joseph is the crescent of the chaste moon. Just above the crib on which the infant is laid is a frame divided in two (the rack) through which appear the quaint heads of the ox and the ass watching over the infant Saviour, the former at His feet, the latter at His head as destined to more noble service. This beautiful belief, taken in connection with what is told of the ravens and the doves in Holy Writ must have deeply impressed the lesson of kindness to animals on the faithful followers of the Lamb of God.

BOOK V

HAVING told in the preceding Books, how Christ came amongst men for their deliverance, how He went about comforting the afflicted, giving health to the sick, sight to the blind, strength to the weak, and even life to the dead—endowing all the world with tidings of great joy—the poet now proceeds to relate the betrayal, desertion, false trial, and cruel death of the Redeemer, His agony intensified by his foreknowledge of Man's ingratitude. This, the last of the Books of the Easter Song (which closes with a marvellous description of His Resurrection and Ascension into Heaven), opens now at the eve of the Last Passover by recalling the beneficent works of Christ, and His preparation for the sacrifice :

Amid these gifts munificent, the eve
Of that great Day drew nigh, when He would
leave

The mortal and th' undying flesh assume—
Not other but the same—which should illumine
The plenitude of Light, and, raised on high
From the great Deep, outshine the starry sky !

Then He : " O Father ! save me in this hour
Who in this hour for this have come." In pow'r
He spake : " O Father ! glorify Thy name."
A Voice descending from the Heavens came,
" I glorified it and will yet again
It glorify."

How manifest was then
Th' excelling evidence of Heaven to men !—
But no acceptance met, for some there said :
“ An angel spoke ” ; and some “ It thunderèd.”
O blind of eyes ! O hardest hearts of earth !
No thunder nor no angel e'er gave birth
Unto its Maker, Christ, that thus it spoke
When He His Father's name did there invoke.
The Voice divine, which all the people heard
The Word acknowledging, reveals the Word !

The last lines express a very subtle thought. Christ being the Word of God, when He is answered by a Voice from Heaven this act reveals the Father in the Son and the Son in the Father—distinct in persons, one in Godhood.

The Passover, it may be recalled, dates from the deliverance out of Egypt of the oppressed Nation of Israel. For four hundred and thirty years they had sojourned amongst strangers and their sufferings appealed to Heaven. Deaf to the demands of Moses, enforced by many plagues, Pharaoh refused them freedom. At last the prophet was told of God to make ready for the day of their deliverance. The month in which this was announced was to be the beginning of the months, the first of the year. On the tenth day, each household should choose out a lamb without blemish ; on the fourteenth day, it should be killed in the evening by the assembled Israelites, hyssop should be dipped in its blood and smitten against the doorposts and lintels, through which none might go forth that evening. On this night, its flesh should be roast with fire, and eaten with bitter herbs and unleavened bread, and the remnants consumed with fire. They should eat it in haste, prepared for a journey, standing, their loins girded, shoes on feet, and staff in hand ; for, upon this night the Lord would pass over the households of the oppressed People, signed with the blood of the lamb, and smite all the first-

born of Egypt with death. Seven days thereafter the Israelites should eat unleavened bread, and that day was to be kept as a memorial through all their generations, so that when their children should say, "What mean you by this service?" they should reply, "It is the sacrifice of the Lord's passover, who passed over the houses of the children of Israel in Egypt, when He smote the Egyptians and delivered our houses."

This, the most wonderful Commemoration of a Nation's Deliverance—and of its Gratitude—was that memorial day now to be kept for the last time by the disciples in Jerusalem with the Messiah, of Whom the unblemished lamb was a symbol, and Whose blood was to be shed for the deliverance of all mankind.

On the first day of the Feast of unleavened bread the disciples, as directed by their Master, made ready the Passover in the Holy City, and when evening was come, Jesus sate down with the Twelve :

Then, in remembered ways, He kept the Feast,
The Passover, and, making Him the least,
He ministered to them, their gracious Guide—
Our true Exemplar—Who, arising, tied
The girded linen ; so that, loving, He
Might first His servants serve, with office free.
Nor yet, when washing His disciples feet,
Passed Judas by,—though plotting fell deceit.
But nothing, Traitor ! serves thy washing there
Of feet, whose heart is as a sepulchre,—
Without, all fair and newly washed in white,
Within, a fetid corpse and blackest night.

His Lord knows his treason and yet gives bread to him who is to betray the Bread of Life. At the Last Supper, Christ ordained the two boons of His Body and His Blood, that the faultless faithful might never know hunger nor thirst of

the soul. Then Judas, moved by an evil spirit, goes out that he may betray his beneficent Master, the very author of his being, Whom he had sold for thirty pieces of silver. Christ and His disciples withdrew from Jerusalem, crossing the brook Cedron to the Garden of Gethsemane where He was wont to go : there He prays apart, keeping the vigil of His agony, and comforts His disciples. Then comes the Great Betrayal. Judas appears with the chief priests and an armed multitude, and identifies his Lord, giving poison for honey, betraying Him by a kiss.

Sedulius, vehement against treachery, delivers a passionate denunciation of Judas. His verse which conveys the spirit so characteristic of the Gael in reference to betrayers, reproduces in Latin a metric style characteristically Celtic.¹

The narrative is resumed. We are told how Peter, who smote off the ear of the High Priest's servant with his sword, is admonished to put it up. The servant is healed. Christ, whom legions of Angels would surround at a wish, did not come to take the life of any but to lay down His own life for all. And Peter, who declares his readiness to die for Him, is told that, ere the cock should crow, he would thrice deny his Master.

The disciples having deserted Him, though Peter follows at a distance, the Messiah is taken to the Palace of the High Priest, where the Scribes and Elders are assembled :

They led Him, quite forsaken, to the hall,
Repellent, wherein Caiaphas, chief of all
The priests sat throned, and chief of all in
crime.

For he and they, devising, sought that time
To slay the Just, by witnesses forsworn :
A myriad lies fly out, a moment born,
And die inept—as when the withered straw
Takes flame and flares aloft, the very law

¹ See Appendix II., Irish Metrical Characteristics in Sedulian Verse.

That of its frailty makes a glare outflash
As sudden quenches it in sordid ash.—

But when they found no way, through guile, to
pass,

Their fury rose against Him then. Alas !
What tears do hinder when I must recall
The mob's tumultuous rage, the blows, and all
Th' affronts that sacrilegious hands have laid
With cruel wrongs upon that Sacred Head !

But He, all patient, did His Body make
Subject to scorn and suff'ring for our sake :
For of those wounds shall come our healing's fee,
And by those shameful slights we cleansed shall be,
And by those bonds are made for ever free !

As foretold, Peter, when challenged, has thrice denied knowledge of the captive Christ when the cock crows : then recovering his senses and recalling his fault, he goes out and weeps bitterly ; his fault, says the poet, flees in his groans, his offence passes away in his many tears. Bitter sighs bring forth sweet succour.

Day comes, gloomier than the night, opening on new crimes. But Judas, when he sees his Master condemned and delivered bound to Pilate, casts down the price of treachery and hangs himself. Once an Apostle, now an apostate.

To Pontius Pilate the Governor (representing the sovereign power of Pagan Rome over the once free people of Israel) the chief priests and elders deliver Christ, so that they may procure His death ; in order to convict One, Whom at least they considered their own countryman, before their alien ruler, they servilely framed the charge that their victim had claimed to be King of Israel.

As lamb unto the slaughter, when they brought
The patient Lord to Pilate's hall, they naught

Of evil could accuse Him, innocent :
" He saith He is a King " was their complaint—
True King indeed, and Falsehood judges Truth
Condemned as Crime. Nor wonder if the ruth
And rule of God the people should refuse—
Barabbas now, as Baal, of old they choose,
Reject the Righteous and the Wretch excuse :
Inverting thus the beam of just award—
Who death had given they to life restored—
To death they doomed Life's Author and their
Lord !

In vain did Pilate wash his hands before the multitude
declaring himself innocent of the blood of the Just, when,
by his judgment, eternal Justice was outraged and the innocent
condemned to scourging and crucifixion.

When now the Holy One was given, bound,
To suffer doom, rude soldiery around
Arrayed Him in a scarlet robe, the sign
And hue of gory Death ; a Crown they twine
Of thorns and press upon His bleeding Head
Which all our sins hath borne and suffered.
In His right hand with mock they set a reed—
A Sceptre, trembling, feeble, frail, indeed,
Then take the alien robe that He His own
Apparel may do on—by this be known
His garb of human flesh laid down, He will
Resume once more, and bear immutable,
Undying after death—when He shall rise
In fulness of His glory o'er the skies.

Nor deem disparate to the Life Divine
That He, when offered mingled gall and wine,

Should taste it, but refuse : this symbol saith
That now, about to taste a time of Death,
The flesh shall shrink before its bitter breath.

The mystic symbolism of Sedulius is not anywhere better or more beautifully shown than in the following passage descriptive of the signification of the Crucifixion and of the Cross :

THE PEACE OF THE CROSS

Upraised upon the spreading wood, He hath
By sacred Love displaced the rule of Wrath :
Peace of the Cross is He,¹ whose burthen there
Illumed its bond, and clothed with honour fair
The penalty of Hate—its every line
By torture sanctified and blessed benign,—
The Sign of Shame is made Salvation's Sign !

For who but knows the Cross we should revere
Which joyful bore the Lord : He gathered here
The symbolled Quarters of the World's great
Sphere :

The Orient shineth from His Head supreme—
Beneath His feet the Vesper planets beam,
And either Pole at either hand shall seem.
All nature lives of its Creator's face
And Christ doth on the Cross the world embrace !

Beside the question of the mystic symbolism, another of much interest arises in connection with this mode of placing the cardinal points. Usually, as in English, men speak of north and south, east and west ; children at school are taught that by facing the sun at noon-day they look south, with back

¹ Pax crucis ipse fuit. For original Latin verses see *Irish Metrical Characteristics in Sedulian Verse*, Appendix II.

to the north, and left and right hands to the east and west respectively.

But, the terms of the Irish language indicate quite a different position. In Irish, the same word designates both the right hand and the south ; the left and the north are named alike ; whilst " behind " and " west " are identical. Hence, the Irish *faced the east* : the orient was the chief or capital point, and the northern and southern poles were indicated by either hand. Thus the symbolism of the Cross, as given by St. Sedulius in the fifth century, which seems strange to modern readers, would appear quite natural and familiar to the Irish-speaking peasant of to-day.

The poet, continuing, notes that the threefold inscription on the Cross declares one King, and that the undivided garment for which lots were cast, is an emblem that forbade schism. Then he proceeds :

Now, when the Innocent they crucified,
They hung a Murderer at either side,
Thus striving by one sentence and one shame
To make the cause seem as the fate the same,
A common doom, but how unlike the cause !—
These, many crimes make forfeit to the laws,
These to the world are guilty, Robbers grim,
To Him the World is guilty, saved by Him !

Nor lost He there, amidst such sufferings,
His right supreme of judgment o'er all things,
Impartial, with inerrant balance weighed :
For both beholding, one is chosen made,
And one reproved. Him not ev'n in death
Ferocious life forsakes, his latest breath
Assails with savage mock his loving Lord,
As when by boar a tender vine is gored.

The other, suppliant, lowers his pained eyes

Adoring Christ whom Christ did recognise,
 As Shepherd gathers, in a desert wide,
 His wandering sheep, and leads him by His side
 Into thy vales, O Paradise, serene,
 Where flowers perennial charm the grasses green,
 Where pleasant fruits abound, and flowing floods
 With spray of waters feed the Joy of Woods !

There is a world of poetry in the words, "*nemorumque voluptas*"—the joy or delight of woods ; here speaks a heart that loved and understood them, as did the ancient bards of the author's native land, once known as the Isle of Woods. The Roman poets, on the other hand, seem to have taken no pleasure in them ; at best they describe woods as verdant and leafy, but usually as dense, dark, opaque, terrible, full of horrors, the resort of wild beasts.

The beautiful picture of Paradise glances like a sudden sunbeam across the gloom ; next, intensified by contrast, come the phenomena which follow the Crucifixion. These are described in verse that demonstrate a powerful and poetic imagination :

Then cloud on dreadful cloud was sudden
 hurled,
 And Darkness terrible o'erspread the World,
 Funereal black the day. The sun's great light
 Lay hid in shrouding gloom of mournful Night,
 Obscuring all with wailing and affright.
 Such aspect, God the Father's aid did give
 The orphaned Elements (so they might grieve
 This death)—which gladdened at their Master's
 birth,
 For as, at birth, Light radiant shone o'er earth,
 It vanished when He died, nor vanished long—

A mystic sign, through space, that as the throng
Of heav'nly stars lay hid three hours in gloom,
So should their Lord three days abide the tomb.

Nor did the Witness, Earth, escape unharmed,
But trembled through its depth, and, all alarmed,
Nature beheld its Author and took dread
Lest He descending—Nature's stay and head—
Its sequent mass should move, to Chaos led,
But Love unmeasured sought th' infernal realm
To save the Lost, and not to overwhelm.

Even these signs did not convert those who had accused
Christ, for they had become as sweet wine changed to sharp
vinegar. A noble passage follows closing with the great
Apostrophe to Death.

When now the end of Agony was come,
Himself His holy Spirit from its home
Corporeal sent, to be assumed again
And live for ever which had died for Men.
The body dying, God undying rives
Returning ways from Death and Hell, whose
gyves

Lie broken :—rent the rocks, and of the Just
The Souls re-animate the buried dust,—
And they arose, and from their graves came forth!

This Temple marvellous new-built on Earth
When th'elder Temple witnessed, sudden, prone
Its summit falls with noise as 'twere a groan.
Its Veil is rent in twain : its riven breast
Reveals the inner secrets, long repress,
To future man : so Moses' Veil shall fall

From off the Law, by Christ made free to all !

Where now, O Grave, thy Victory ? Where,
Death,

Thy dread sting irresistible, wherewith

Thy penal reign, insatiate of woe,

Was laid on suff'ring man ? Thou didst not go

To Christ, but Christ to thee—thine Overthrow !

For He alone might deathless die, Whose grasp
Upholds the world. He made not thee—of Asp

And Disobedience born : lo, now at length

Thy reign is o'er, and stricken all thy strength !

For when upon the Cross the Saviour died,
Wrath came and with a spear did pierce His side,

The Blood and Water from His Body flowed

Behold, three Gifts of Life on us bestowed :

That fount of water laves us with new birth,

These make us Temples of our God on earth,

Which rendered meet for that most high estate

He orders that we keep immaculate.

The Chief Priests and Pharisees seal the sepulchre and set
a watch, suspiciously fearing lest the disciples may deceive
the people by a false rumour of the Resurrection, which had
been predicted.

The sacred Treasure of His Body dead
Within the rock-hewn sepulchre was laid,
Ennobled then, but still more glorious made
When He arose.

Now craft a vigil kept
With sharp suspicion, lest, whilst others slept
His followers remove it, and might say

“ He hath arisen on the destined day : ”

Wherefore the stone they sealed and did enclose
His resting-place with guard of watchful foes.

If after all the Cross's martyrdom,—
And wounding spear—and burial in the tomb—
Ye, Men of Slaughter, think unfinished still
Your gory deed, and deem that He, Whose will
Brought many Souls enfranchised from the grave
Cannot His own recall—then Counsel crave
For arms of guile, seal down the sepulchre,
Roll on the stone, and keep your watch a-stir.

Who shall imprison God ?—before Whose
might

All matter opes—Who rules the Under-night
And thunders, Sovereign, from the starry Light !
Why waste your vigils, Foes ! why strive t'achieve
That proof of Faith which, proved, ye dis-
believe ?

Sedulius, in treating of the Resurrection, incidentally
points out the abandonment of the Jewish Sabbath, and
describes the institution of the Lord's Day.

This mournful Sabbath past, the dawning came
Of that glad Day which draws its lofty name
From Him, the Lord who gave it, in this wise,
To see the Earth have birth, and Christ arise.

For, as the Sabbath seventh is, this Morn
Is Head of orbèd Time, which now adorn
The glories of the King, Whose triumphs bright
Confirm anew its great primatial right.

At dawn, the Virgin Mother came, with her

Came other women to the Sepulchre
 With fragrant spice and lamentable sighs,
 When lo ! the tomb lay void before their eyes
 But full of glory : on the stone rolled nigh
 There sate an Angel, missioned from on high,—
 His Countenance shone like to light'ning, bright,
 And like the spotless snow his raiment white,
 Whose aspect did both joy and fear inspire—
 For to the hostile guard it flashed as Fire,
 As Light to those who wept, who learned with
 faith
 Their Lord had triumphed o'er defeated Death !

The guards, fleeing into the City, bear the witness of Terror to the Truth ; but, afterwards, bribed by the elders become forsworn, pretending that the body was removed whilst they slept. False guards ! exclaims Sedulius, criminal custodians, if the body were taken, whose were the grave-cloths by which the Angel sat ? Which were more swiftly done, as theft would do—to unbind all the cerements, or to bear away the body bound ? Iniquity has lied to itself, but here also is a symbol, for that has been removed from Israel, which we cherish in our hearts.

Lament thy priests about to perish ; wail
 Thy people for this deed, O Israel !
 Thy trump shall please no more, thine oil, nor fane.
 How could thy trumpet sound, whose King is
 slain ?
 Who thine Anointed be, who'st cast the True
 Anointed forth ? And with what victim sue
 Whose hands the martyred Shepherd's veins
 imbue ?

The Synagogue shall pass, in self-made gloom,
Christ takes His Church in happy love to
bloom.

Sedulius says that after the Resurrection, our Lord appeared first to the Virgin-Mother, that she by whom He came on earth might first announce His re-appearance. The recognition by the disciples is told, and the evidence of His material presence given, with the incident of Thomas, whose doubt they dissolve; for Christ, says the Paschal Work, encourages with gentle lenity the soul taken with doubt. He desired to be known of him the more, being the friend of the doubter.¹ Whosoever forges fraud does not wish to be known, nor his proofs to be called for. The simulator abhors investigating friends.

On the sea of Tiberias, Simon Peter and the other disciples were fishing all the night, but caught nothing; in the morning, One is seen standing upon the shore:

To Peter, fishing vainly through the night,
He bade to cast his net upon the right
Into the waters; forthwith, scarcely they
Could hawl the straining net's wave-wand'ring
prey.

Behold a type: for thus the casting line
Shall take, in precepts of our Lord divine,
And these the Apostolic hands shall bring
From the right side to be Christ's following.

Coming to the land, Peter leaps into the water that he may more speedily reach his Lord whom he has recognised. There, on the shore, the disciples behold, already prepared for them, a fire on which is laid a fish, and bread. Christ having invited them, gives them to eat, and speaks His last recorded words:

¹ Agnitus hinc potius, quod sit amicus dubitantis, L. v. l. 386.

Nor lacked they glowing fire upon the strand
With fish thereon, and bread ;—thence understand :
The fish for water, fire the Holy Ghost
And Christ Himself the bread : in that are lost
Our primal stain, these sanctify and feed.

Then He, their Teacher and their Host indeed,
Bade His disciples to the welcome board,
And all enjoyed the good gifts of the Lord,
And knew their Christ. Their hunger o'er, they
rose.

Then Peter questioned He, if more than those
He loved Him : answered Peter, " Yea," then He,
The Shepherd, loving His fair flock to see
Increase, did sheep and lambs to him confide
As to a workman, good in all and tried ;
And thrice He asked, so Peter cleansed might be
Of all the fault of his denials three.

Then taught He, saying : " Peace be with you
here,
Receive My Peace : through all the Peoples bear
My quiet Peace with holy counsels spread.
Empty the Earth of ills ; one Fountain-head
Shall lave all men, and therefore shall ye call
From Earth's extremes My scattered Nations all."

Then, and lastly, with the intense reserve of extreme
reverence, Sedulius describes

THE ASCENSION

Thus having spoke His sacred will, the crest
Of Bethany He sought (with those most blest

Who might such triumph see with mortal eyes),
 And thence sublimely passed into the skies
 Ethereal—where, at the Father's right,
 He sits and rules Who, governing the height
 Of Heav'n, descended to the Deep profound,
 And from the Deep arose.

All, standing round

Adoring, saw Him rise beyond the bars
 Of cloud and tread the luminous path of stars.

His heav'nly course in joyful hearts they bear
 So all might learn : True Witnesses they were
 By strength divine ; though much had met their
 sight

They few of acts innumerable write :—
 For not the world could all the books confine
 Were it ordained in Holy Writ to shrine
 All things accomplished by our Lord divine.¹

Thus with the impressive words of St. John the Beloved
 closes the Fifth and last Book of the Easter Song of Sedulius,
 the First Epic of Christendom.

Compare with its serene spiritual beauty of peace and love,
 Milton's scene of wrath and revenge. Plagiarising Homer's

¹ Faithful to his remarkable rule, Sedulius concludes this Book
 and, as it were, signs his great Epic by a couplet in Irish metric, thus :

*Facta redemptoris nec Totus Cingere Mundus
 sufficeret densos per Tanta volumina libros.*

In the first line are three dissyllables with perfect double broad
 vowel rimes, re-echoed by an interlaced riming word, " tanta," in the
 second line. There are also three consonant alliterations t t c. In
 the second line there are two dissyllables, with delicately varied vowel
 rimes, now slender-broad—densos, libros. Be it observed that the
 final riming syllable is in "os," which also is found to be the final
 of the First Book (and not elsewhere), a most marked Irish char-
 acteristic link between first and last.

account of Achilles' brutal deed, who dragged dead Hector round the walls of Troy, Milton thinks to glorify the divine Redeemer by imputing a similar deed to Him :

Then to the Heaven of Heavens he shall ascend
With victory, triumphing through the air
Over his foes and thine ; there shall surprise
The Serpent, Prince of Air, and drag in chains
Through all his realm, and there confounded leave.

An ineffective conclusion, for the Serpent was not slain, like Hector. Where Milton diverges from Sedulius he sinks sadly.

APPENDICES

APPENDIX I

THE FIRST AND THE LAST EPIC OF CHRISTENDOM

SECTION I

PART I

"Paradise Lost"—Milton's Debt to Sedulius

IF an architect should desire to raise a great though composite edifice, and find materials largely at his disposal in some ancient temple or stately mansion, what might be his course? Possibly he might adopt the general plan, modify it, add wings, an underground and an overhead story with a skyline after his manner. Then he would make use of the materials at hand. No considerable or complete mass of masonry taken from the old should be embedded in the new building to declare its origin; but it might be impossible to replace and therefore necessary to preserve some examples of elder art, such as a peerless portal, a noble arch, or many fine if lesser works of sculptor, carver, or designer. These are retained accordingly—displaced, dissevered, dispersed—and built into the walls of the new edifice, amid other rich spoils, or masses of material, shaped from the architect's own copious quarries—so that they should not conspire together against his originality, but rather co-operate to applaud his skill.

This has been Milton's method, and his great epic is, therefore, a great mosaic of pieces from the works of other

poets, immersed in the profuse products of his own genius. This might pass, because he has candidly declared that he considered it justifiable to take the goods of others, if improved in the taking. He did not, indeed, always improve but sometimes in conveying marred them.

The last limit of poetic licence, however, is exceeded when Milton distinctly states, and deliberately repeats that the theme of his epic is wholly original, and had never previously been attempted in prose or verse. There is nothing doubtful in his declaration, when, in addressing the Heavenly Muse, he writes :

I thence
Invoke thy aid to my adventurous song,
That with no middle flight intends to soar
Above the Aonian mount, while it pursues
Things unattempted yet in prose or rhyme.¹

Now, Sedulius wrote of them, both in verse and in prose !
Again, and more elaborately, he implores the Spirit, who led the " glorious Eremite " into the wilderness to

inspire,
As thou art wont, my prompted song, else mute,
And bear through highth or depth of Nature's bounds,
With prosperous wing full summed, to tell of deeds
Above heroic, though in secret done,
And unrecorded left through many an age :
Worthy to have not remained so long unsung.²

These statements have certainly misled his readers, and they cannot be excused by a suggestion that Milton was unaware of the existence of such ancient precedents, for he had borrowed from them largely—even at this moment, when the ink of his disclaimer lay wet on the page, he was amplifying and embellishing with ponderous orations the austere and faithful verse of Sedulius which, thus augmented, became *Paradise Regained* !

¹ *Paradise Lost*, Book i. line 12. It is startling (and edifying) to discover that this repudiation of plagiarism is itself a plagiarism—a direct translation from Ariosto, "Cosa, non detta in prosa mai, nè in rima," Norman Douglas, *Old Calabria*, p. 170.

² *Paradise Regained*, Bk. i. l. 11 *et seq.*

The majestic style of Milton, notable in the word structure of *Paradise Lost*, was evidently acquired from that of Sedulius, so clearly manifested, especially in the first Book of his *Easter Song*, where, explaining his high purpose and the magnificence of his theme, he is able to give full liberty to his spiritual fervour and his soaring genius.

At the entrance to the Second Book of the *Easter Song* is the peerless Portal, where Sedulius and Milton meet, or rather that Portal which Milton has taken, from Sedulius, and set as a frontispiece to his own Epic. It can be compared with that of Homer or that of Virgil, and not suffer by the comparison.

This is a close translation of what, nearly one thousand five hundred years ago, Sedulius wrote :

The first of Man, by ruthless serpent cast
From Eden's flowerful seat, woeful, at last
In lures of pleasant taste drank bitter death.
Nor he alone, presumptuous cause of wrath,
Fell 'neath the mortal law, but all of Man
The sequent race, who all in him began.¹

Milton's version, though more free, is still faithful :

Of Man's first disobedience, and the fruit
Of that forbidden tree whose mortal taste
Brought death into the World, and all our woe,
With loss of Eden . . .

Expulerat primogenitum saeuissimus anguis
florigera de sede virum, blandique saporis
illecebris lethum misero potarat amarum,
nec solus meritam presumptor senserat iram
mortali sub lege iacens, sed prorsus ab ipso
humanum simul omne genus.

Carmen Paschale, Bk. ii.

The prose version begins thus :

Expulerat serpens ille nequissimus de *paradisi* sede florigera primogenitum dolosis artibus virum . . . (*Opus Paschale*, Bk. i.).

This supplied the name of Paradise, and Milton with the title of his poem.

Besides the manifest identity of thought and form, the peculiar term "seat" (*sedes*) is used by both, and in the prose version Sedulius supplies the very name of Paradise. Following his system of displacement, Milton delays for nearly thirty lines—of invocation—to mention "the infernal serpent," as the cause of the expulsion. The cause of his enmity to Man, the Muse next explains, and describes, at great length, the revolt, war, and downfall of Lucifer, and this, his revenge.

Sedulius, with historical directness, avoids all figments. Having marshalled the evidence in favour of the perfection of God, he reviews, with reasoning, with ridicule, and with compassion, Man's errors and idols :

Ah, hapless hearts of men that evermore
Shape out some foolish figment to adore,
Your Maker flee and what you make implore !
What witless folly takes the senses now,
That full-grown Man, before a bird, a cow,
Half-human hound, or twisted snake shall bow ?¹

Milton has no compassion on man's errors, because he makes these part of the infernal revenge—"devils adored as deities." But he annexes the picture from Sedulius, with little change, but great amplification, after his manner. There is no mistaking this :

After these appeared
A crew who, under names of old renown—
Osiris, Isis, Orus and their train—
With monstrous shapes and sorceries abused
Fanatic Egypt and her priests to seek
Their wandering gods disguised in brutish forms
Rather than human.²

To fix the fact by a word (as in the case of "seat") we have Sedulius's mention of "transplanted gods," and Milton's of "wandering gods." His Second, and much of his First Book, record the proceedings of Lucifer and the fallen Angels,

¹ Sedulius, Bk. i.

² Milton, *Paradise Lost*, Bk. i. l. 476 *et seq.*

with much appreciation, and their orations are reported with such detail and apparent accuracy and at such interminable length as to add a new and unexpected terror to Hell.

They are not altogether original : some passages and many ideas in these speeches had appeared already,¹ and several picturesque horrors were taken from Virgil.

Not until mid-way in his Third Book does Milton recur to the great theme with which his First Book began—the Fall and the redemption of Man.

Sedulius keeps this theme in due prominence. Immediately after the declarative opening, he proceeds :

The growing Race begins, and soon decays
 With seed of ruin sown . . .
 The Race doth know itself no more : by Fate
 Irreparable conquered, its estate
 Brought low, and through long lapsing times of strife
 Nought may endure, enclosed in short'ning life :—
 Nor Hope bring turning help, for nought could save
 The future nations from the primal grave
 Had not the loving Lord, forgiving all—
 (Lest that His handiwork a ruin fall,
 And what was made His image by His breath,
 Should be unlikened by the taint of Death)—
 Redeemed the world, and caused the fruit, which so
 Set their sons' teeth on edge, its pain forgo,
 Where Guilt gave Death now Love would Life bestow !

The system of disseverance and scattering of the ideas and phrases of the original is visible in what of Milton follows, as elsewhere, but there are certain lines which seal and stamp the loan. Thus Sedulius wrote :

Where Guilt gave Death now Love would Life bestow !²

Milton makes it :

So Heavenly love shall outdo Hellish hate.

P.L. Bk. iii. l. 298.

¹ See later, Part II.

² et unde
 culpa dedit mortem pietas daret inde salutem.
Sedulius, Bk. ii. l. 26.

Again, Sedulius wrote, addressing the Almighty :

Who hast lost Man restored, for fruit of strife
 Forbid, bestown on him a higher food,
 And heal'd the Serpent's sting by sacred blood :
 Who hast, when men (save those borne in the Ark)
 Were tombed in floods of whelming waters dark
 From one sole stock again the race renewed.

Milton repeats the idea, but cautiously niggles at the number restored. The Father Almighty is supposed to address the Divine Son, in reference to Adam :

As in him perish all men, so in thee,
 As from a second root, shall be restored
 As many as are restored.

P.L. Bk. iii. l. 287.

Part of the passage, quoted above from Sedulius, with respect to the decadence and doom of Man, is almost literally taken over by Milton, for instance :

for nought could save
 The future nations from the primal grave
 Had not the loving Lord, forgiving all

 Redeemed the world.

Milton has it :

And now without redemption all mankind
 Must have been lost, adjudged to Death and Hell
 By doom severe, had not the Son of God,
 In whom the fulness dwells of love divine,
 His dearest mediation thus renewed.

Bk. iii. l. 222.

Another portion of this passage Milton transfers to the mediatory speech, attributed to the Divine Son, and certainly in an incongruous setting. It was a lofty thought that which Sedulius expressed, when he said that the loving Lord, always more ready to forgive than to punish, intervened because He would not that the great Creation of His love should fall a ruin, and that which He had made like Himself—in His own image—should be made unlike to Him, marred by eternal death.

But it is sad to find that Milton, using this fine passage, perverts it by venturing to attribute its use to the divine Son, in order to persuade the Almighty that to do otherwise were to give pleasure and triumph to the Devil—and get blamed Himself for it—"without defence." Surely a miserable motive!

Or wilt thou thyself
Abolish thy creation, and unmake
For him, what for thy glory thou hast made?—
So should thy goodness and thy greatness both
Be questioned and blasphemed without defence.

The mystery of the Incarnation is told by Sedulius, and this is an excerpt:

As from sharp thorns there springs, all soft and pure
The Rose, which doth its mother's self obscure
With honour fair, so sacred Mary came
From stock of Eve and cleansed away her shame.
Man's sullied nature in Death's empire lay
Till, through Christ's birth, new birth all Mankind may
Secure, and ancient taint put quite away.

Milton makes the Divine Father say to Christ:

Thou, therefore, whom thou only canst redeem,
Their nature also to thy nature join;
And be thyself Man among men on Earth,
Made flesh, when time shall be, of virgin seed,
By wondrous birth; be thou in Adam's room
His crime makes guilty all his sons; thy merit,
Imputed, shall absolve them who renounce
Their own both righteous and unrighteous deeds,
And live in thee transplanted, and from thee
Receive new life.

Milton is always anxious lest the mercy of God should include all mankind, and Hell be depopulated. Sedulius is more kind and Christian.

The glory and the joy of the Incarnation is sung by Sedulius:

What new Light to the World—to Heav'n what Grace!
What Splendour, when, through Mary, to our race
Came Christ with glory new, as comes again

The Bridegroom, fairer than the sons of men
His lips more sweet and graced than ever spoke !

He, Who, to save mankind, He, the divine Maker of all things, assumed a servant's garb—He, whose majesty the Heavens and Earth could not contain :

Lo, in a manger lies, a child at rest !

And then comes the salutation :

Hail, holy Mother, thou who'st borne the King
Who Heaven and Earth upholds, and everything
Embracing, is Eternal, Infinite
Thou, with a Virgin's honour, the delight
Of Motherhood hast owned : there hath not been
Thy like on earth, nor ever shall be seen,
Sole pleasing Christ, incomparable queen !

Besides that quoted, Milton has two other imitative references : one, when the Angel comes to dine with Eve in Eden :

On whom the Angel " Hail ! "
Bestowed—the holy salutation used
Long after to blest Mary, second Eve.

Bk. v. l. 385.

Again, when the Angel had revealed unknown things to Adam, the latter declares that now he understands :

Why our great Expectation should be called
The Seed of Woman. Virgin Mother, hail !
High in the love of Heaven, yet from my loins
Thou shalt proceed, and from thy womb the Son
Of God most High, so God with Man unites.
Needs must the Serpent now his capital bruise
Expect with mortal pain.

Bk. xii. l. 378.

These passages, taken from books so remote from each other as the third, the fifth, and the twelfth, reveal how widely Milton distributed his originals—it is significant that the last and most remote is most like the Sedulian source.

On the declaration of Christ's Atonement, to which celestial grace Sedulius refers, Milton says there was " a shout from all the Angels—Heav'n rung with jubilee." The flowers and

rivers of Heav'n are mentioned, where with golden harps the Sacred Song is sung, and the poet praises Christ, who shall be the theme of his song.

Now, it is significant that these three subjects are also together in the First Book of Sedulius. The first subject is most modified. Sedulius implores the Athenians to abandon their lifeless fanes and barren philosophies :

Why choose the barren, where the good vine grows,
And for grey lavender forsake the rose ? . . .

Far rather steer

O'er welcome waters that will float you here
To meads delightful mid the forest's flower,
Where home is blessed by God's supernal power ;
Where sparkling streamlets animate the path
And lave the soil, that never prickle hath.¹

This is the germ-suggestion of Milton's elaborated scene in Heaven, where the amarant, transferred from Eden,

there grows

And flowers aloft, shading the Fount of Life,
And where the River of Bliss through midst of Heaven
Rolls o'er Elysian flowers her amber stream.

As regards the Sacred Song itself there can be no question or denial : the splendid jewel is taken in its entirety, though placed in a new setting, according to Milton's method. Its cumulating epithets mark out the many-faceted gem.

Sedulius, beholding the efforts of Gentiles, exclaims :

Shall I—though standing in the sacred choir
Where song celestial mates with David's lyre—
Shall I be mute ? nor striking Judah's string
The wondrous work of Christ the Saviour sing ?

¹ Again, telling the pardon and reward of the penitent thief, Sedulius writes :

As shepherd gathers, in a desert wide,
His wandering sheep, and leads him by his side
Into thy vales, O Paradise, serene,
Where flowers perennial charm the grasses green,
Where pleasant fruits abound, and flowing floods
With spray of waters feed the Joy of Woods.

Whom all things vouch on earth, who thunders Lord
On every sense, by all the heart adored,
Who heart and sense themselves bestowed, and whom
All Nature serves !

He, by eternal doom
Supreme, and with his Father One, by right,
Apex of All, Creation's Crown, the Same in Light,
In Splendour, Virtue, Power, and Timeless Sway,
Consort of Glory, Kingship, and all Might,
In Majesty Alike ! Behold the Way
Which leads to safety and the Paschal Day !
This theme shall be my song.¹

In Milton, the Sacred Song, as he calls it, is also sung to the Harp, now by Angels : though he disperses, dims, and divides what should be indivisible—the splendour of the original shines irrepressibly forth :

Thee, Father, first they sung, Omnipotent,
Immutable, Immortal, Infinite,
Eternal King ; thee, Author of all being,
Fountain of light, thyself invisible . . .

Thee next they sang, of all creation first,
Begotten Son, Divine Similitude,
In whose conspicuous countenance, without cloud
Made visible, the Almighty Father shines.

Bk. iii. l. 372.

Then, after a disquisition, Milton concludes the passage in almost the very words of Sedulius slightly amplified :

Hail, Son of God, Saviour of men ! Thy name
Shall be the copious matter of my song.

Bk. iii. l. 412.

¹ These are the last six lines of Sedulius :

Cui iure perenni
Arcibus aethereis una est cum patre potestas,
Par splendor, communis apex, sociale cacumen,
Aequus honor, virtus eadem, sine tempore regnum,
Semper principium, sceptrum iuge, gloria consors,
Maiestas similis ; haec est via namque salutis,
Haec firmos ad dona gradus paschalia ducit.
Haec mihi carmen erit.

Bk. i. l. 29.

The scheme of Milton's Epic, awarding great space and importance to the war of hatred and of revenge between Hell and Heaven, compels the author to summarise—in an imaginary discourse between the Archangel Michael and Adam—the greater and more glorious work of the Redemption. This is related as a narrative of things about to happen in the far future, and the interest naturally diminishes during the telling of the lengthy tale. Even Adam wearies.¹

The plan of Sedulius, in his Epic, is quite different. He states his case with direct dignity and avoids all figments, whilst he summarises ancient history to explain his subject he devotes nearly all his space and the utmost efforts of his genius to present a real, faithful, and vivid picture of events, incomparable on earth. Hence the interest does not diminish but increase.

Some passages will serve to show how closely Milton follows Sedulius, and enable the reader to compare the discourse of his Archangel with that of the Irish poet.

This is Sedulius :

Then to the simple Shepherds in the night
The Angel Choir sang first the wonder bright—
For Lamb He was and Shepherd true, of right,
The while o'er Bethlehem such signs appear
The eager Magi came, and, with strange fear
Alarmed the Tyrant, ever questioning
Where in Judea was its new-born King ?
For in the East a planet shone, and far
Had led where now would shine His radiant Star.

Then sped the Magi, following the light
In heav'n set, that royal Star and bright,
And kept their chosen way, where future law,

¹ The Archangel noticed it, and bade him attend :

Much thou hast yet to see ; but I perceive
Thy mortal sight to fail ; objects divine
Must needs impair and weary human sense.
Henceforth what is to come I will relate ;
Thou, therefore, give due audience, and attend.

Bk. xii.

To that blest home, adoring hearts should draw.
 Their Treasure, open in their hands, they bring
 In fealty :—this Gold for offering
 Is made as gift unto the new-born King,
 To God that Incense, for the Tomb that Myrrh.
 Why triple gifts ? Because Hope's harbinger,
 Our Faith, the triple number doth enfold,
 As God doth Future, Present, Past behold.¹

Thus Milton's Archangel Michael speaks :

Yet at his birth a star,
 Unseen before in heaven, proclaims him come,
 And guides the eastern sages, who inquire
 His place, to offer incense, myrrh, and gold :
 His place of birth a solemn Angel tells
 To simple shepherds, keeping watch by night ;
 They gladly thither haste, and by a quire
 Of squadroned Angels hear his carol sung.

This might pass as a free yet close translation of the original. It merely omits to explain the mystic meaning of the offerings, or the tyrant's alarm, ominous of a future Massacre of the Innocents. Sedulius describes it with hot wrath and reprobation. Milton is silent. He is silent also, save for a casual allusion, as to the wondrous works of Him, Who, he declared, should be "the copious matter" of his song, but expands lengthily and repeatedly on prickly points of dogma and tedious repetitions.

Sedulius tells of Christ's choice of disciples, fishers first, apt to fish for minds meshed in pleasures :

These His Disciples were, these He did teach
 Of life eterne, whom windy pride of speech
 Filled not, nor vanity of birth : they came
 In lowly minds refulgent, and mute fame—
 Kindred of Heaven—for He the Weak would choose
 To break the Mighty and the Wise confuse.

¹ The last line is a signature, which Milton borrows, and plants in Book iii. l. 78 :

Him God beholding from his prospect high,
 Wherein past, present, future, he beholds.

Milton adopts the Sedulian Prose where (quoting St. Paul) the humble and meek of this world are contrasted with the strong and wise,

by things deemed weak
Subverting worldly-strong, and worldly-wise
By simply meek.

Bk. xii. l. 567.

In the Easter Song Christ explains the Lord's Prayer :

His Kingdom come : that Kingdom all so fair !
Where end is none, nor Death is anywhere,
Nor changing times deplorable, nor Night
O'ermasters Day ; where reigns our Prince of Light,
And Victor Victims throng rejoicing round,
Their noble brows with crowns eternal crowned !

He distinguishes the just from the unjust, and their rewards, but concludes that :

God's Sole will and good Liberty are meant
That all His Flock should, wolf-escaped, keep tryst
And live in joy amid the meads of Christ.

In other words, God desires the salvation of all, and gives them free will (*bona libertas*) in order to achieve it. Milton's statement of free will is fine and logical.

Christ's teaching is more fully told after the delivery from death of the daughter of Jairus :

Then that His own disciples might achieve
Like deeds, it pleased Him all full power to give :
" Go forth," He said, " and to my people tell
(Enlarged not yet the House of Israel)
The Reign of Heav'n ; their cruel pests expel,
Cast demons out ; and heal the leprosid ;
Call life unto the dull limbs of the dead ;
Freely receiving, give to all men free."

As though He said, " I now confide to ye
My flock to guard. I am their Shepherd good,
And largely open all my fields for food ;
Let no man sell my sheep these pastures—Mine."

Thus taught th' Omnipotent the law divine
In apostolic ears, that thence the lore

Through after times should flow for evermore.

As from one crystal fount of Paradise
 Four mighty ways of water take their rise,
 And spread, diverging, all the world to bless,
 Whatever be God's work—not selfishness
 Of Man, but God-confided—comes, be sure,
 A pure gift, one that should be given pure,
 As though by Stewards, not by Traders held.
 So David sang in canticles of eld :
 " I yet shall enter, where my hopes aspire,
 My Lord's repose because I know not hire."

Milton takes the central fact, setting it after the Crucifixion :

For the Spirit,
 Pours first on his Apostles, whom he sends
 To evangelise the nations, then on all
 Baptized, shall them with wondrous gifts endue
 To speak all tongues, and do all miracles
 As did their Lord before them.

Adam is informed that they shall win many in all nations, live and die well, but be succeeded by wolves, on whose guile there follows a long digressive disquisition.

Sedulius, after vividly relating many miracles, gives this beautiful description of evening at sea :

The dying Day beyond the warm blue wave
 Of ocean sinks, that forth may come the grave
 Pale Night, and Hesper lead her starry shades.¹
 Leaving their Lord amongst the mountain glades
 The Twelve put out upon the lake, where now
 The threat'ning waters rock the labouring prow,
 And winds adverse.

As darker grows the air
 The Lord walked forth upon the waters there
 And trod their fluid fields ; with ripples fleet
 The Sea, subsiding, kissed His sacred feet.

¹ These are the words of the original Latin :

iamque senescentem calidi sub caerula ponti
 oceano rapiente diem, quum pallor adesset
 noctis, et astriferas induceret Hesperus umbras.

Sedulius loved the sea, Milton did not—a townsman, he refers to it figuratively and artificially as of “jasper and liquid pearl.”

Here is how Milton adopts and adapts the beautiful passage, omitting the sea :

Now came still Evening on, and Twilight grey
Had in her sober livery all things clad ;

Now glowed the firmament
With living sapphires ; Hesperus, that led
The starry host, rode brightest.

Bk. iv. l. 598.

This, according to his system of displacement, is removed from the picture of Christ walking on the waters to serve as prologue to a nocturnal discourse between Adam and Eve, where the poet, “blind yet bold,” sets forth the whole duty of wedded woman by the lips of Eve—not yet marred by the guile of the Voltairean Viper :

What thou bidd'st
Unargued I obey. So God ordains :
God is thy law, thou mine : to know no more
Is woman's happiest knowledge, and her praise.

This, at least, seems Milton's very own¹—not traceable to the more chivalrous poet.

With regard to the homage of the subsiding waters, there is but this passage in Milton : it refers to the Flood, for he does not love the sea, whilst Sedulius takes every opportunity to mention it. Here, also, the homage—one of fear and flight—is to the hot thirsty Sun which

Gazed hot, and of the fresh wave largely drew,
As after thirst ; which made their flowing shrink
From standing lake to tripping ebb, that stole
With soft foot towards the deep.

In the last Book of *Paradise Lost* the author seems a little weary of his recital, or less interested in his subject, for whilst

¹ But no—even this was adapted from Salandra's *Adamo caduto*. Douglas, *Old Calabria*, p. 166.

he still expatiates on the Old Testament he curtly abridges the New. He begins, with a slight reminiscence of Dante : "As one who, in his journey, bates at noon, though bent on speed," so here the Archangel paused—"betwixt the world destroyed and world restored"—for Adam to speak. But Adam did not speak. Then the Archangel changed his mode of instruction, from the mental pictures to a personal recital. He said :

I perceive
Thy mortal sight to fail ; objects divine
Must needs impair and weary human sense.
Henceforth what is to come I will relate ;
Thou, therefore, give due audience, and attend.

Yet, at the outset he had removed the film (that came after the Fall) and purged his visual nerve with euphrasy and rue.

In this Book of nearly 650 verses, not 50 are devoted to the life and sacrifice of the Redeemer. This theme had from the first been indicated as the culmination and fulfilment of all hopes, and now is given in very brief summary.

Sedulius relates the great marvel of the Transfiguration of Christ on the high mountain whither he went with three chosen disciples :

The mortal vesture, of His mother ta'en
With human form, was seen to veil in vain
The Lord divine.
Upon the mount He stood, made manifest,
His Form in all ethereal Splendour drest :
Sun-bright His Glory was, His Face excelled
The glowing Day ; His robe such Radiance held,
Its fairness far the whitest snow dispelled !
Sublimely favoured Three, who thus received
On Earth to see what Earth has not believed :
With Moses and Elias to take part—
Unknown, they knew them by the seeing heart—¹
That we, with larger faith, might henceforth learn
The first and last of all things to discern,
Alpha and Omega.

¹ Ignotos oculis viderunt lumine cordis. The Prose has it "by the inner eyes" ("oculis interioribus").

Milton is silent on this subject, but we seem to have here the original of his address to the Father :¹

Fountain of light, thyself invisible
Amidst the glorious brightness where thou sitt'st
Throned inaccessible, but when thou shad'st
The full blaze of thy beams, and through a cloud
.
.
.
Dark with excessive bright thy skirts appear.²

In the Fifth and last Book of the Easter Song of Sedulius, the impressive facts are reverently told, with deep feeling, and sometimes with evident anguish.

The poem opens at the eve of the Passover by recalling the beneficent works of Christ, and His preparations for the sacrifice :

Amid these gifts munificent, the eve
Of that great Day drew nigh, when He would leave
The mortal and th' undying flesh assume—
Not other but the same—which should illumine
The plenitude of Light, and, raised on high
From the great Deeps, outshine the starry sky !
Then He : " O Father ! save me in this hour
Who in this hour for this have come." In pow'r
He spake : " O Father ! glorify Thy name."
A Voice descending from the Heavens came,
" I glorified it and will yet again
It glorify."

Then follow the keeping of the Passover, the washing of the disciples' feet, the Last Supper, the betrayal of Judas, the denial of Peter, and the flight of the other disciples. With scathing indignation the betrayal is told, whilst the desertion, the trials, the sufferings, and the Crucifixion are recorded with

¹ Book iii. l. 375. Sedulius, Bk. iii. l. 278.

² The curious word "skirts" here represents the "robe" or vesture, in Sedulius. It would appear, however, that Milton took this description more from the prose Work, where is mentioned the Supreme Light, beyond the power of mortal eyes to bear, or of mortal mind to imagine. Sedulius says the Apostles had to fall prone. Milton, that the seraphim in His presence covered their faces with their wings.

very noble pathos. Having related the affronts and injuries borne at the Hall of Caiaphas, Sedulius says :

But He, all patient, did His Body make
Subject to scorn and suff'ring for our sake :
For of those wounds shall come our healing's fee,
And by those shameful slights we cleansed shall be,
And by those bonds are made for ever free.

Milton embodies this and other lessons in scattered passages, and tortuous legal language, studded with qualifications. The Archangel is made to inform Adam concerning Christ :

The Law of God exact he shall fulfil
Both by obedience and by love, though love
Alone fulfil the Law ; thy punishment
He shall endure, by coming in the flesh
To a reproachful life and cursèd death,
Proclaiming life to all who shall believe
In his redemption, and that his obedience
Imputed becomes theirs by faith—his merits
To save them, not their own, though legal, works.¹
For this he shall live hated, be blasphemed,
Seized on by force, judged, and to death condemned,
A shameful and accursèd, nailed to the cross
By his own nation, slain for bringing life ;²
But to the cross he nails thy enemies.

Bk. xii. l. 402.

Sedulius notes that, though they sought to make Christ's fate seem that of a criminal by placing a murderer on either side, they failed—He showed His sovereign power by acting as Judge, and by admitting the penitent to Paradise. So different and so exalted is the aspect of the Crucifixion presented by Sedulius—where Christ is shown with arms out-

¹ Elsewhere, Bk. xii. l. 427, he qualifies this, writing : " By faith not void of works."

² "The mob chose to free Barabbas and not Christ" : but the city-mob, officials, hirelings, and others were not the Hebrew Nation, who gave Christ, His Apostles, Disciples, and reverent "multitudes," and who have suffered, most unjustly, for the crime of their Rulers.

Sedulius writes :

To death they doomed Life's Author and their Lord !

spread to embrace the whole world—that one can understand why Milton avoided it, emphasised its disgrace and hate, and became doubly exact as to the question of qualifications. Milton makes the crucifixion the Triumph of Hate, Sedulius makes it the Triumph of Love. He writes :

Upraised upon the spreading wood, He hath
By sacred Love displaced the rule of Wrath :
Peace of the Cross is He.
The Sign of Shame is made Salvation's Sign ! . .
Which joyful bore the Lord : He gathered here
The symbolled Quarters of the World's great Sphere :
The Orient shineth from His Head supreme—
Beneath His feet the Vesper planets beam,
And either Pole at either hand shall seem.
All Nature lives of its Creator's face
And Christ doth on the Cross the world embrace !¹

Whilst Sedulius reverently describes in detail the events which follow, Milton, taking a line or an idea here and there, rapidly summarises—pausing only to iterate and reiterate the conditions he imposes on the Redemption. Sedulius, telling of the Elements, which welcomed the birth of Christ by light, now mourning His death in darkness, says the stars being three hours so hidden indicated that He would be three days in the tomb. Milton says the stars shall see Him rise again. Then proceeds Sedulius :

When now the end of Agony was come,
Himself His holy Spirit from its home
Corporeal sent, to be assumed again
And live for ever which had died for Men.

Milton :

Thy ransom paid, which Man from Death redeems—
His death for Man.

More is supplied from Sedulius's great apostrophe :

Where now, O Grave, thy Victory ? Where, Death,
Thy dread sting irresistible, wherewith

¹ In the Jansenist crucifixes the arms of Christ were not outspread, but set closer—a significant symbol.

Thy penal reign, insatiate of woe,
 Was laid on suffering man? Thou didst not go
 To Christ, but Christ to thee—thine Overthrow!
 For He alone might deathless die, Whose grasp
 Upholds the world. He made not thee—of Asp
 And Disobedience born: lo, now at length
 Thy reign is o'er, and stricken all thy strength!

Then referring to Christ's wound, and the blood and water
 which flowed from it, Sedulius writes:

Behold, three Gifts of Life on us bestowed:
 That fount of water laves us with new birth,
 These make us Temples of our God on earth,
 Which rendered meet for that most high estate,
 He orders that we keep immaculate.

Thus Milton:

This godlike act

Annuls thy doom, the death thou shouldst have died,
 Defeating Sin and Death,
 Baptizing in the profluent stream—the sign
 Of washing them from guilt of sin to life
 Pure.

Bk. xii. l. 427, *et seq.*

Sedulius shows how the sepulchre was found a void on the
 third morning

But full of glory: on the stone rolled nigh
 There sate an Angel, missioned from on high—
 His Countenance shone like to light'ning, bright,
 And like the spotless snow his raiment white,
 Whose aspect did both joy and fear inspire—
 For to the hostile guard it flashed as Fire,
 As Light to those who wept, who learned with faith
 Their Lord had triumphed o'er defeated Death!

This Angel is more ethereal and spiritual than Milton's
 Raphael in his three pairs of wings or his Michael in military
 garb. Milton summarises:

So he dies,

But soon revives; Death over him no power
 Shall long usurp. Ere the third dawning light
 Return, the stars of morn shall see him rise
 Out of his grave, fresh as the dawning light.

Then Milton, still following the course of Sedulius, but omitting or abbreviating or qualifying, writes :

Nor after resurrection shall he stay
Longer on Earth than certain times to appear
To his disciples—men who in his life
Still followed him : to them shall leave in charge
To teach all nations what of him they learned
And his salvation,
All nations they shall teach

This passage immediately precedes the account of Christ's ascension into Heaven, precisely as it does in Sedulius. Milton proceeds :

Then to the Heaven of Heavens he shall ascend
With victory, triumphing through the air
Over his foes and thine ; there shall surprise
The Serpent, Prince of Air, and drag in chains
Through all his realm and there confounded leave ;
Then enter into glory, and resume
His seat at God's right hand, exalted high
Above all names in Heaven.

These are the faithful words of Sedulius concerning the Last Lesson of the Saviour and His Ascension into Heaven :

Then taught He, saying : " Peace be with you here,
Receive My Peace : through all the Peoples bear
My quiet Peace—with holy counsels spread.
Empty the Earth of ills ; one Fountain-head
Shall lave all men, and therefore shall ye call
From Earth's extremes My scattered Nations all."

Thus having spoke His sacred will, the crest
Of Bethany He sought (with those most blest
Who might such triumph see with mortal eyes),
And thence sublimely passed into the skies
Ethereal—where, at the Father's right,
He sits and rules Who, governing the height
Of Heav'n, descended to the Deep profound,
And from the Deep arose.

All, standing round
Adoring, saw Him rise beyond the bars
Of cloud and tread the luminous path of stars.

Here all is peace, serenity, and love, in Milton's account wrath, revenge, and hatred—his latest plagiarism is his worst: his transference to the self-sacrificing Redeemer of the brutal act of Achilles, who, Homer tells, dragged the body of Hector dead round the walls of ruined Troy. It is inept also—for Hector at least was dead, here Lucifer was merely left "confounded."

SECTION I

PART II

"Paradise Regained"—Milton's Debt to Sedulius

When this version of the Easter Song was begun, my sole motive was to make known the merits and beauty of the ancient poet, whose work exalted our Nation, and to prove that Ireland had produced an epic, and that the first of Christendom. It was not until, wishing to compare Milton's mode of treatment, that the similarity of many passages struck me, and the identity of the great exordium. Thence, came a strictly scientific comparison and the discovery of Milton's method of borrowing and his deep debt to Sedulius.

Paradise Regained appeared to stand completely apart, and the numerous interminable orations were not inviting. The work, too, was prefaced by a solemn invocation which, whether designedly or not, should make the reader suppose it had no predecessor in poetry.

He bids the Spirit who led the "glorious Eremite" into the desert to

inspire,
As thou art wont, my prompted song, else mute,
And bear through highth or depths of Nature's bounds,
With prosperous wing full summed, to tell of deeds
Above heroic, though in secret done,
And unrecorded left through many an age:
Worthy to have not remained so long unsung.

Then the poem opens by the scene at the Jordan, and the salutation of John the Baptist. In my first version of Sedulius,

I had merely summarised this passage in prose. Then, referring to Sedulius in order to compare his description of the Baptism with Milton's, I found it demanded a full translation—for this astonishing reason :

Here was and is the sketch-model of *Paradise Regained* ! Here are the very foundations and all the more essential elements of that poem ! It lacks only the long-winded speeches of the Devil, and that is a fortunate failure.

For consider the structure of Milton's work. It may be compared to one of those old "cage-work" houses, built in a frame-work of artistically shaped and carved oak, of which the empty interspaces were filled with stone, brick, and mortar, sometimes with clay or mud. The framework seems least in bulk, but most in beauty. So it is with respect to the Sedulian framework, and the Miltonic orations.

Just consider the case :

The First Book contains 500 verses, of which 446 are speeches.

The Second Book contains 486 verses of which 408 are speeches.

The Third Book contains 443 verses of which 434 are speeches.

The Fourth Book contains 639 verses of which 452 are speeches.

Note also this remarkable, if monotonous, and overwhelming fact :

Satan's speeches occupy more than half of every one of the first three Books, because he speaks in succession 261, 265, 290 verses. In the last Book only (being closed) he falls below the half but rises above one-third, so, at examination, he "compensates," excelling all epic records of elongated oratory !

Milton, in annexing the work of Sedulius, is true to his old method of dissevering and amplifying and dispersing his extracts, which was a wise if not a candid system. Here Sedulius proceeds historically, relating incidents of Christ's childhood before the Baptism : Milton inverts this, begins

with the Baptism, and inserts those incidents later. Thus Sedulius :

Now, when twelve years of human life had passed
He came within the Temple, and was seen
In wisdom older than the Elders ; He
Mid Masters of the Law a Master stood.

Milton reserves this for about 200 verses, and then introduces it, somewhat expanded, into what purports to be Christ's meditation in the Wilderness, with loss of delicacy, for what was praise in Sedulius, appears as self-commendation in Milton, thus :

Therefore, above my years,
The Law of God I read, and found it sweet ;
Made it my whole delight, and in it grew
To such perfection that, ere yet my age
Had measured twice six years, at our great Feast
I went into the Temple, there to hear
The teachers of our Law, and to propose
What might improve my knowledge, or their own,
And was admired by all.

A comparison of the descriptions of Baptism in the Jordan is most instructive, and, perhaps, edifying. Sedulius wrote it in verse, of which what follows is a close version :

Nor did the close of Youth delay. What does
A world, flying through time, know of delay ?
Six lustres nearly, when to peaceful Jordan
He comes to get what He had come to give.
Him when the Baptist from the stream beheld,
Whom he, within His mother's womb, unborn,
Had recognised, though closed as yet the prophet's
Lips, which now bore witness crying aloud :
" Behold the Lamb of God, Who taketh away
The sins of the World."

Then in the flowing stream He entered, pure,
So washed our lives' contagions all away—
He naught having of that He lost—the torrent
Itself was cleansed by His sacred form,
Its wave made by His presence consecrate.

The elements discerned their God—the Sea
Retired—back toward its source the River rolled.

So sang the Prophet : " Wherefore fly, O Sea !
And Jordan thou, why draw thy waters back ? "

Emerging from the water's mystic gift
He trod the strand, when lo ! the Heav'ns oped—
To glorify Him came the Holy Ghost
Descending as a Dove (which has no gall,
Thus teaching sweetness), and from Heav'n came
A Voice, saying : " This is My belovèd Son
In whom I am well pleased." Thus is declared
The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit there
One only God by threefold reason proved.

Milton writes :

To his great baptism flocked
With awe the regions round, and with them came
From Nazareth the son of Joseph deemed
To the flood Jordan—came as then obscure,
Unmarked, unknown. But him the Baptist soon
Descried, divinely warned, and witness bore
As to his worthier, and would have resigned
To him his heavenly office. Nor was long
His witness unconfirmed ; on him baptized
Heaven opened, and in likeness of a dove
The Spirit descended, while the Father's voice
From Heaven pronounced him his belovèd Son.

Satan, roving about, is said to hear this, and hurry off to
call a Council, and relate the scene, in which relation some
points, omitted above from Sedulius, are now reported, for
instance, the flood Jordan is now the " consecrated stream,"
—the rising from the water, which he had entered " pure."

Satan speaks.

All come,
And he himself among them was baptized—
Not thence to be more pure, but to receive
The testimony of Heaven.

I saw
The Prophet do him reverence ; on him, rising
Out of the water, Heaven above the clouds
Unfold her crystal doors ; thence on his head
A perfect dove descend (whate'er it meant) ;
And out of Heaven the sovran voice I heard,
" This is my Son beloved—in him am pleased."

Bk. i. l. 75.

Sedulius proceeds in sincere gospel-fashion to tell the retirement into the desert and the Temptation. Milton follows the same course, but dramatises. Satan calls a Council where he alone speaks, and his purpose is approved. In heaven, the Most High, with a smile, relates this futile purpose to the angels.

Sedulius proceeds :

Then having borne for forty days and nights
The Fast, still with the Holy Spirit filled,
The Tempter came to Him, with art insidious
Armed, and falsely off'ring a phantom feast :—
“ If thou’dst appear the Son of God,” he said,
“ Then bid this stone to bread be sudden changed.”

Milton develops and amplifies this. Thirty verses are given to a minute menu of the Feast—fish, flesh, game, roast, boiled, grilled, steamed, and so forth.

Sedulius treats, with high scorn, the Tempter’s proposed test to Christ :

As though such marvel He did not, all days,
Perform, who to Earth’s stony breast gives power
In wheaten grain to fructify, and bread
From rock creates.

Take another example. Sedulius writes of Satan :

Stricken, the Foe new arms in venom sought,
And from a mountain showed Him all the world’s
Rich Kingdoms thence outspread. “ All these,” he said,
I give, if thou’lt bow down and worship me.”

Perverse the speaker, and perverse the speech,
That He seek honours of frail kingdoms here
Who wins for man Eternity !—that He
Bow down to wretch unspeakable, Whose throne
O’ertops the Ether, Earth His footstool is,
Whom none perceives, Whose praise high Heaven sings !

Christ answered to the Tempter, “ It is written :
Thou shalt adore the Lord thy God. Him only
Shalt thou serve.”

In Milton the perplexed and troubled Tempter tries a new fraud, and from a mountain shows Him Rome and the World,

with geographical and political disquisitions, and offers them conditionally :

“ All these, which in a moment thou behold'st,
The kingdoms of the world, to thee I give
(For, given to me, I give to whom I please),
No trifle ; yet with this reserve, not else—
On this condition, if thou wilt fall down,
And worship me as thy superior lord
(Easily done), and hold them all of me ;
For what can less so great a gift deserve ? ”
Whom thus our Saviour answered with disdain :
“ I never liked thy talk, thy offers less ;
Now both abhor, since thou hast dared to utter
The abominable terms, impious condition.
But I endure the time, till which expired
Thou hast permission over me. It is written,
The first of all commandments, ‘ Thou shalt worship
The Lord thy God, and only Him shalt serve.’ ”

That sufficed for Satan of old, but Milton thought it required some seventeen other scolding verses of his own facture, and—the Tempter was not dismayed, but remained and delivered an elegant disquisition on Athenian Art, eloquence, hospitality, music, and the different philosophic schools, the Academic, the Peripatetic, the Epicurean, and the Stoic !

Now comes the last Temptation, thus told by Sedulius :

Defeated still, still he dares
With will superb, to wage the futile fray,
Thrice rising proud to be thrice thrown to earth.
For, next, above the Holy City, he
Placed Christ upon the Temple's highest peak
And said : “ If thou wouldst seem the Son of God
Cast thyself down, for Scripture has declared
Thou shalt go safe on angels' arms upborne
Lest thou shouldst strike thy foot against a stone.”

But Satan, by the true Word's point transpierced,
“ 'Tis writ, Thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God,”
Fled, moaning, from the Victor's face. Then came
All Heaven's Princes, and the Shining Hosts
Of Angels came and ministered to Christ.

Milton, after a description, proceeds :

There, on the highest pinnacle, he set
 The Son of God, and added thus in scorn :—
 “ There stand, if thou wilt stand ; to stand upright
 Will ask thee skill. I to thy Father’s house
 Have brought thee, and highest placed : highest is best.
 Now show thy progeny ; if not to stand,
 Cast thyself down. Safely, if Son of God ;
 For it is written, ‘ He will give command
 Concerning thee to his Angels ; in their hands
 They shall uplift thee, lest at any time
 Thou chance to dash thy foot against a stone.’ ”
 To whom thus Jesus : “ Also it is written,
 ‘ Tempt not the Lord thy God.’ ” He said, and stood ;
 But Satan, smitten with amazement, fell.

So Satan fell ; and straight a fiery globe
 Of Angels on full sail of wing flew nigh,
 Who on their plummy vans received Him soft
 From his uneasy station, and upbore
 As on a floating couch, through the blithe air.

Then there was a banquet, for, after the manner of his Nation, Milton apparently loved a banquet—and gives us three : one in the Garden of Eden, with Eve, an Angel (and real fruit), another here, with “ a table of celestial food divine,” with “ ambrosial fruits,” and “ ambrosial drinks,” and, surpassing all, that phantom feast, provided by the Tempter, under a shading tree :

A table richly spread in regal mode,
 With dishes piled and meats of noblest sort
 And savour—beasts of chase, or fowl of game,
 In pastry built, or from the spit, or boiled,
 Grisamber-steamed¹ ; all fish, from sea or shore,
 Freshet or purling brook, of shell or fin,
 And exquisitest name, for which was drained
 Pontus, and Lucrine Bay, and Afric coast.

There was also “ a stately sideboard ” for the wines !

It is acknowledged that *Paradise Regained* is a failure, and several reasons are obvious and have been stated. One, which

¹ Steamed ambergris.

I consider the most important, was unknown, and that is that Milton had found but one precedent, and consequently had to fill out the simple and sufficient structure of Sedulius with interminable speeches, of which Satan's alone formed more than half the poem.

SECTION II

PART I

Milton's Debt to Dracontius

If for *Paradise Regained* Milton had no precursor but Sedulius, he had several beside him for *Paradise Lost*, and he made copious use of them, unabashed and undetected. The noble and stately Sedulian structure was to be decorated, and a composite edifice formed, with vivid but suitable ornaments and additions. Virgil supplied the Titanic battle-pictures. For most of the scenes concerned with the Creation and the early history of Man, and those especially which we most admire, they were taken, without acknowledgment, from three Christian Latin poets of the close of the fifth century, Dracontius, Victor, and Avitus.

Dracontius,¹ first in point of time, but not in genius, dwelt in Carthage,² a lawyer and poet, who, having satirised the rapacity of the Vandals, was imprisoned by their King Guthamundus (Gonthamond), and there, appeals being vain, he gave his mind to spiritual things, and wrote his *Hexaëmeron*, or the Six Days of the Creation. He describes the great goodness of God and the exquisite beauties of Nature—especially shown in Paradise, which he calls “hortus Dei”—the Garden of God. His description of the trees and flowers is rather general, but he notes the variety of colours and the many fragrant odours, and his pictures of birds are characteristic

¹ Blossius Aemilius Dracontius. The Vandal king reigned, it is stated, from 484 to 496, so that this poem was not written until fifty years after that of Sedulius.

² Some call him a native, but the Pisa edition names him “Toletanus.”

and charming. Brightness and Light command his homage in a peculiar degree, probably because he was a prisoner. Milton also was a prisoner to darkness in his later days, so naturally he appreciated, admired, and imitated the intense and enthusiastic Apostrophe to Light, with which Dracontius begins his poem. But here Milton more than redeems his debt by his nobly pathetic reference to his own blindness.

APOSTROPHE TO LIGHT

Light is primal Day—the sole death of Darkness,¹
 Light, sent ere the sky, Light, the cause of Day,
 Light, ether's brilliance, Night's limit, Light,
 Light, aspect of elements and all things,
 Light, the vigour of all, Light, the Sun's glory,
 Light, the stars' grace, Light, the Moon's golden horn,
 Light, splendour of Heav'n, Light, the World's first Law,
 Light, flash of Flame, Light, Dial of great Time,
 Light, prize of Tillage, Light, rest of the Sick,
 Light, first act of God, Light, candour of Souls,
 Light, bound of seasons, Light, boundless, eternal,
 Which first the world's well-built order showed.

All bright is God, the author immutable,
 Whom densest cloud can ne'er in aught obscure,
 From whom no deed of darkness lurks concealed,
 The Fount of Light, Who first enlightened all,
 Who sent Life's herald Light into the world
 With precedence o'er all the works to come,
 Which showed the Sun's path, whose resplendent beams
 He bade shine o'er the new created orb.

This is Milton's Apostrophe :

Hail, holy Light, offspring of Heaven first-born !
 Or of the Eternal co-eternal beam,
 May I express thee unblamed ? Since God is light,
 And never but in unapproachèd light
 Dwelt from eternity—dwelt then in thee
 Bright effluence of bright essence increate !

¹ *Prima dies lux est tetris mors una tenebris,
 Lux datur ante polum, lux clari causa diei,
 Lux iubar aethereum, lux noctis limes et umbrae,
 Lux facies rebus cunctis, lux elementis, etc.*

Dracontius, liber i.

Or hear'st thou rather pure Ethereal stream,
 Whose fountain who shall tell? Before the Sun,
 Before the Heavens, thou wert, and at the voice
 Of God, as with a mantle, didst invest
 The rising World of waters dark and deep
 Won from the void and formless Infinite!

MILTON, *P.L.* Bk. iii. l. 1 *et seq.*

SECTION II

PART II

Milton's Debt to Victor

Claudius Marius Victor was born in Provence, and died about 450, twenty years after the publication of the *Easter Song* of Sedulius. He was a man of fine culture, high imagination, distinguished style, and virile character. His poem must have been a gold mine to Milton, who has not attained in his work so perfect and beautiful a description of Paradise, and whose portrayal of Adam's conduct (where not borrowed) is weak and puerile compared with the pathetic and noble portrait set before us by Marius Victor.

In the following passages, the reader will find full evidence for this judgment.

Here are close versions of the originals, which Milton had before him, when describing the beauties of Paradise, its loss and the banishment of Adam and Eve, their exile, despair, desire for death, and repentance. First then we have this vivid picture of the loveliness of the Garden of God on Earth.¹

PARADISE

Eastward lies a happy rich recess, fairest
 Of Earth—Paradise of pleasant woods

¹ Dracontius calls Paradise: "Hortus in orbe Dei, cunctis felicior hortis—the Garden of God on earth, more delightful than all gardens"—which Milton renders: "blissful Paradise of God the garden was," Bk. iv. l. 208.

Displays the beauty of its cluster'd trees.¹
 Here shines the sun with equal rays serene
 At all times tempered by the gentle Spring.
 Here stand the trees, rich in their hanging fruit,
 Where to sweet apples sweeter still succeed,
 Whose grateful juice gives mind and member strength,
 With fragrance and with flavours doubly fed.
 Here glows the varied land with starry hues,
 And still brings forth new flowers and novel fruit:
 Here breath of cinnamon delights the air
 And scents ambrosial melt the slender reeds.
 Not such the Mede perfumes, nor thy loose hair
 Achaemenius,² nor yet Assyrian
 Zedoir, nor Mareotic spikenard
 Of shrub Sabaeon, soft Tarnessid twig
 Or plant of Palestine the fragrant tears.³
 All these thou'dst fancy, in one garden grown
 God gathered here what Nature knew apart.
 And when soft zephyrs gently stirred the groves
 From all the blended scents one Nectar breathed!
 Hence new delight: for when the swaying boughs
 Set all their leaves a-tremble, the great Woods
 Sounded a Hymn to God, the breeze attuned

¹ Compare Milton:

Thus was this place,
 A happy rural seat of various view:
 Groves whose rich trees wept odorous gums and balm;
 Others whose fruit, burnished with golden rind,
 Hung amiable—Hesperian fables true,
 If true, here only—and of delicious taste.
 Flowers of all hue, and without thorn the rose, etc.

² Achaemenius, synonym of Persian (after its King Achaemenes). Mareotis, a lake near Alexandria in Egypt. Sabaea means Arabia felix, "Araby the Blest." Milton takes "Sabean odours," etc., and generously robs the gardens of Victor and Avitus.

³ Milton imitates this elegant digression, and apparently got his love for digressions in these writers, but makes them lengthy. Here his digression begins:

Not that fair field
 Of Enna, where Proserpin gathered flowers,
 Herself a fairer flower, by gloomy Dis
 Was gathered . . .
 . . . nor that Nyseian isle,
 Nor where Abassin kings . . .

The Songs of Praise, nor shook the air in vain—¹
 For 'tis not thinkable that He Who, binding
 Each thing to each by law, keeps all in one,
 Should aught have reckless or have useless made,—
 And of His works how fair this evidence
 Of thrilling forest tree and whispering woods !

Nor doubt that ere the Primal Parents' fall
 Here pitched their tents and here together dwelt
 Glory, Candour, Grace, Wisdom, and pure Love,
 Truth, Prudence, Peace, and Thought sublime, Ideals
 Of the Soul, with Virtue all resplendent !²

Whate'er on Earth's most beautiful is there.
 But why should I, with failing words, desire
 To number gifts so manifold and great ?
 Enough, that 'tis of faith—here from glad seed
 Sprang up the Tree of Life with fruit on high
 And there, diverse, harm-bearing fruit of Knowledge
 Hung down, dependent, from the Tree of Law.

Within the bosom of the sacred wood
 A Fountain flowed which nobly dower'd its young :³
 From it, four-cleft, four mighty rivers run.

¹ This splendid passage is thus reduced in Milton :

Airs, vernal airs,
 Breathing the smell of field and grove, attune
 The trembling leaves . . .

² Milton adopts this description of the Primal Parents :

For in their looks divine,
 The image of their glorious Maker shone,
 Truth, wisdom, sanctitude severe and pure.

Bk. iv. l. 291.

³ Milton's plan of dis severing his original makes his description very confusing. Taking the Tigris for model, he says it passed through the shaggy hill, underneath ingulfed, then, up-drawn through porous veins by thirst, arose a fresh fountain which "with many a rill watered the garden ; thence united fell and met the nether flood, which from his darksome passage now appears." Thence the poet is more faithful :

And now, divided into four main streams,
 Runs diverse, wandering many a famous realm
 And country whereof here needs no account ;
 But rather to tell how, if Art could tell
 How, from that sapphire fount the crispèd brooks,
 Rolling on orient pearl and sands of gold,

Richer than ocean, it pours down its floods
 Into the deep, which, unswoln, all receives :
 Yet less is that which, unswoln, takes the torrents
 Than that which gives, with undiminished force.

First of the rivers from the Fountain Blest
 Phison exulting hastes with Eden gifts
 For Gangic nations and dry Indian lands ;
 It, rolling seed and soil, makes labour fruitful
 And rude strands sparkle with bright gleams of gold ;
 Here glows the ruddy Ruby's lightning fire
 And here the Emerald's flash of lucid green.

Nor less is Geon, a more placid river
 That lifts Nile-waters, and the scorching plains
 Protects with pious flood, foiling the skies
 It tempers Aethiop with spreading lakes.

Third, Tigris hastes through rough rugged rapids,
 Euphrates' comrade—whose united mass
 Earth swallowed first, in hollow cavern hid,
 Till in Armenia and Median Tempe
 No more restraining, it casts forth the streams.
 Then Tigris spurning its deep dark Avernus
 Leaps, with mightier motion, through the air,
 Till caught in cave again, more strong by hindrance,
 It rages, and with waters multiplied
 It bursts more fiercely from its dungeon dark
 Cutting its course through the Assyrian plain.

Euphrates, gentler, wide, with fertile flood,
 Waters its subject Persia's dusty fields,
 With softly flowing streams, alike for all
 It serves, and lends to man whole-hearted help
 Until the drought—when, prodigal, it spends
 On land itself which to the sea was due.

Here, then, were Nature's Empires all, in germ,
 With all the Virtues, and Delights endowed,
 The first Possession of the First of Man.

With mazy error under pendent shades
 Ran nectar, visiting each plant, and fed
 Flowers worthy of Paradise.

Milton in excusing himself from telling their course through many famous realms betrays his knowledge of Victor's poem, and more obviously by substituting "orient pearl and sands of gold," for strands, sparkling with gold, rubies, and emeralds—an unhappy change, as "orient pearls" are not rolled on by rivers, and suggest molluscs.

BANISHED

The sorrow of the Primal Parents on their banishment from Paradise is told by Marius Victor with keenest sympathy and understanding and poignant pathos. Milton annexes much, but the ignominious expulsion is (or seems) his own. He shows the "hastening Angel," catching them by either hand, and hurrying them through the gate and down the cliff (like a constable). They looked back, and their last sight of Eden is of a Flaming Sword and

the gate

With dreadful faces thronged and fiery arms ;
Some natural tears they dropped, but wiped them soon.

Victor writes :

Till now the secrets of the World's creation,
As candid Faith reveals, I've truly traced,
Whilst yet the happy Earth lacked taint of Death ;
Now ways of Men and mortal things I tell—
Grant, God Omnipotent, thy poet power !
When, forced to leave their hallowed home and kingdom,¹

¹ Milton gives Adam's anticipatory farewell thus :

Departure from this happy place, our sweet
Recess, and only consolation left
Familiar to our eyes ; all places else
Inhospitable appear, and desolate,
Not knowing us, nor known.

Bk. xi. l. 303.

In Eve's farewell, Milton is still more influenced by Victor :

O unexpected stroke, worse than of Death !
Must I leave thee, Paradise ? thus leave
Thee, native soil ? these happy walks and shades,
Fit haunt of Gods, where I had hoped to spend,
Quiet, though sad, the respite of that day
That must be mortal to us both ? O flowers
That never will in other climate grow,
My early visitation, and my last
At even, which I bred up with tender hand
From the first opening bud, and gave ye names,
Who now shall rear ye to the Sun, or rank
Your tribes, and water from the ambrosial fount ?

Bk. xi. l. 268.

They reached the frontier of their Native Land
And place of Exile—with what stricken looks,
Appalled, they saw the barb'rous field of work !

There bloomed no verdant trees of varied fruit,
Nor fost'ring soil appeared, but a mixed mass
Of dense and heavy bulk, thrust forth, confused,
Rocks rugged rose, and gloomy forests frowned,
O'er grassless plains, bristling with horrid thorns.

Ah, what a scene for eyes, for hearts, to see
In which dwelt Paradise and all its beauty !

“ What sorrow neath the burthen of all woes !

This miserable wide waste—after thy
Delights, O Paradise ! thy pleasant gladness
Thy smiling glades, whose fleeting phantom Presence
Is ever here—whose Image wounds the soul !

Now thy woods shine with yet serener splendour
And all the wealth of thy lost blessèd groves !

Now sweeter still thy fruit as nectar seems !

Now Earth breathes fragrance from thy living flowers—

Alas, the sorrow of these odours fled ! ”

In this refined and most touching part, Victor reveals himself a psychologist of fine perception. His narrative is followed throughout by Milton, who, whilst imitating, amplifies, and in some cases coarsens. Victor makes Adam, unconquered in fair fight, resent Satan's foul deception of his wife, an unsuspecting woman. Milton annexes the project of death, and the noble repentance.

Victor proceeds :

“ O 'tis not thus Thou, Paradise ! repayest,
Whose joys make every scene more darkly drear !
Now perishes fair love of Life—now bleakness
Suggests 'twere sweet to die ; lest greater want
Wreak greater woe, for now Earth's very bowels
Are famished, forests yield but barren banquets
And we must wrench malignant roots for food.”

Whilst lacking all things, helpless and forlorn,
Despair taught them to hope their Father's help ;
Prostrate on the ground in tears and in mute
Grief, which banished words, then they solace sought,
And shame their accents querulous subdued ;
But when the gift of gentle speech returned
Arising both, thus Adam suppliant prayed :

ADAM'S PRAYER

" Omnipotent, Author of all, Creator
 Of this World ! fallen and by fault insensate,
 I, happy once, whilst life itself should last,
 Could follow the swift Spirits o'er the stars
 With vision clear and over all diffused.
 Those eyes, which then discerned thy mysteries,
 Why have I them no more,¹ or else so minished,
 So dimmed by darkness of this earthy prison,
 That now I naught of True discern, but flitting
 Mortal things, and a world still growing worse ?
 And therefore, Thou, Omnipotent, who art
 All everywhere, to Thee we fly—to Thee
 With trembling minds we pray, hear us, unhappy,
 Thou who see-est all, Thou who always hearest !
 When he, the world's most unrelenting foe,
 The Head of Ill, desired me with the damned
 To link, naught as himself he tried, nor captive
 Conquered, but warring on my spouse, a woman,
 He gave this wound, achieving our betrayal
 By fraud most foul and unforeseen deceit.
 Since I, for my offence, am justly doomed,
 Stricken with grief I do my fault acknowledge,
 I offer me, of me, a sacrifice.
 All tears, all murmurings, I put away,
 Embracing the sweet solace of my doom—
 Accepting this too, with all sacred gifts,
 In expiation of my sin, nor refusing
 What toil Thou mayest add, and if it please Thee,
 Best Judge ! hear no prayer against Thy sentence,
 Though we with tears and sobbing voices pray
 That Thy decision be in aught relaxed.

¹ This fine and great idea is annexed by Milton, but merely presented in this form ; where all the deep pathos is lost :

Michael from Adam's eyes the film removed
 Which that false fruit that promised clearer sight
 Had bred ; then purged with euphrasy and rue
 The visual nerve, for he had much to see,
 And from the well of life three drops instilled. (xi. 412.)

Euphrasia or Eye-bright and Rue were both medicinal for dim sight, the former especially. Rosemary was similarly used to strengthen the memory.

So shall Thy sentence in full force remain.

Thou'st ordered me seek food in fallow glebe,
 Grain in watered briars, in thistles fruit ;
 Hence it shall be done, nor for labour fail.
 Give but to know the grain, and how to harvest,
 What be the fruitful plants, what forms of labour—
 Father Compassionate, help. Teach us to work !
 Then, contented and certain of salvation
 Eve shall assist me, and taught by fate severe
 Shall bear a Race who, suffering by our fault,
 Shall, purified of stain, bequeath this Doom
 As an eternal Heirloom of the Dead."

The while they prayed by little signs was seen
 The shadowy serpent twining through the grass
 In sinuous supple folds and silent fear
 Crawling to hidden paths, accurst and vile,
 Who drew upon them wrath and direst grief.

Then Eve to Adam : " If thee the cause of all
 Our Ills can move, take stones, thou now hast power
 To give Death's author death ; expert and apt—
 By his own tortures and by cruel death
 Teach him 'tis sad to die, who me and thee
 Destroyed." She said. Their stony missiles flew
 Hurling the rocky ground, where hid the snake.
 It chanced that one fierce-thrown, from naked flint
 Rebounding, struck sparks, the dry withered grass
 Broke into flame, the rapid burning ran,
 And soon the forest shone a flashing fire !¹

Astounded, trembling, seeking where to hide,
 Amazement held them fast, and threw all prudence
 To the unusual flames, which to see
 They wished and turning watched some space apart,
 Wond'ring as from the soil black tresses fell
 And day was darkened by the forest fumes,
 But most to see the whole land now resplendent
 Shine radiant with new light beneath the sun !

Not unafraid they heard the crackling clangour
 Of gleaming groves, or saw the glowing globes
 Of swaying flame rise upward to the stars ;

¹ Milton adopts this where he makes Eve suggest they might get fire by reflecting sunbeams on dry matter or by collision of two bodies grind " the air attrite to fire, as lightning "

Kindles the gummy bark of fir or pine.

Bk. x.

Or yet the eating fire force down its roots
 Where, conquered by absorbing heat, the Earth
 Oped all its veins before the generous warmth,
 And, yielding all its fluids, now became
 Fluid itself, and soon in streamy metals
 Flowed : hence in high honour gleamed yellow gold,
 And white as milk the shining silver glittered,
 Hard brass dissolved and moved in masses molten.¹

What of the flaming forest yet remains
 Its ashes show'ring through the dark obscure.
 Thus arid Aetna, when with forge broke loose
 It pours forth strident sulphur blent with flame,
 And then the ground, with roasted glebe enriched
 Quickens with new growths, and by fertile rains
 Brings forth the swelling crops, and sees elate
 The happy harvests' undulating ears,
 Revealing many kinds as yet unknown
 That were not long before they welcome were.

No fate with courage fails. God gave us light
 To know all good things, in a lesser world.
 What greater is, to see by sacred reason
 That if man's given mind remained, unstirred,²
 Not apt to err, then neither his own kind
 Would it delight, nor varied forms of things,
 Nor numbering sands, nor mode of stars on high,
 Nor what the outspread space and depth of Earth
 Or measured mass, nor what melodious voice
 Shall mate the harmony of sevenfold spheres,
 Nor aught that we from usage learn, or that
 Assiduous studies teach, though use and art
 Alike from God, the Ever Giver, come !

¹ Milton tells of the early metal worker, who

at the forge

Labouring, two massy clods of iron and brass
 Had melted (whether found where casual fire
 Had wasted woods, on mountain or in vale,
 Down to the veins of earth, thence gliding hot
 To some cave's mouth, or whether washed by stream
 From underground); the liquid ore he drained. Bk. xi. l. 564.

² With Marius Victor's happy philosophy Samson's riddle is justified
 "out of the eater came forth meat." It must seem marvellous that the
 Dark Ages (called dark because of the speaker's mind) should have
 been more adventurous than later times.

SECTION II

PART III

Milton's Debt to Avitus

Alcimus Ecdicius Avitus, usually known as St. Avitus, became Bishop of Vienne, in the year 490—sixty years after the publication of the Epic of Sedulius, and died in 525. Eminent as a poet, with fine descriptive talent, he excels in analysis of character, and in dramatic power. In his great poem Milton found a diamond field. From Victor he obtained, chiefly, with the picture of Paradise, the better part of the character and action of Adam, his remorse, despair, desire for death, repentance, and noble resignation. From Avitus he took not merely the idyll of the first nuptials, in the Garden of Eden, but the tremendous figure of Satan, gazing on their lovely lives and happy home, with humiliation, envy, rage, and furious resolve to wreck the work of God—and hence, the subtle and dread drama of the Temptation of Eve and the Fall of Man.

Avitus finds that the wound in Adam's side, from which Eve was formed, symbolises that of Christ, from which originated the Church, His Spouse. God united Adam and Eve in marriage, and bade them live happy lives in harmony, increase and replenish the earth with children, and children's children, and kindred without end. Hence the marriage law, venerable throughout all time, to be kept by all unstained, hence children shall leave father and mother, and they shall be one flesh, and none shall put asunder those whom God has joined.

Avitus concludes :

This union by eternal vow was Hymen,
A Festival by Angels purely sung
In choral chant, and heav'nly harmony.
Their nuptial couch was Paradise—their dower
A World !—stars rejoicing gave them happy light !¹

¹ These are the noble words of Avitus :

Taliter aeterno coniungens foedere vota
Festivum dicebat hymen, castoque pudori

Milton, as usual, divides and disperses—dilating and diluting—his extracted subject. In one place, he writes :

And heavenly choirs the hymenaeon sung.

Bk. iv. l. 711.

Elsewhere :

All Heaven,

And happy constellations, on that hour

Shed their selectest influence . . .

the amorous bird of night

Sung spousal, and bid haste the Evening-star,

On his hill-top to light the bridal lamp.

Bk. viii. l. 511.

Just previous to this, as Avitus, Milton also says, “for this cause he shall forgo father and mother and to his wife adhere, and they shall be one flesh, one heart, one soul.”

Next comes an exquisite picture of Paradise by Avitus, which may compare with the lovely picture of the same Garden of Eden by Marius Victor. Both are beautiful with varied charm. From both Milton has borrowed, with liberal hand, all his scattered Paradisial scenery. Therefore there is no need to compare details which every reader can detect.

Here is the ideal of Avitus :

PARADISE

There is in eastern climes a place—thy secret
Nature !—whereon, from rise of sun, Aurora's
New-born beams flash back from neighbouring Ind.
Here shade protects against the torrid noon
Whose cloudless splendour dazzles all the air.
Hence comes pure Light, and from a nearer sky
Subserves dark bodies in their native night,
Which then with captured rays resplendent shine—
The sparkle makes their shrouded face more dread,
But all things chiefly for our use convene.

Here Nature lavishes the wealth of worlds
Whate'er to scent is sweet, to vision fair :

Concinit angelicum iuncto modulamine carmen.
Pro thalamo Paradisus erat, mundusque dabatur
In dotem, et laetis gaudebant sidera flammis.

Here branch of pitchy ebony combines
 With gleaming ivory from farther Ind,
 The beauteous tusk of monstrous elephant.

Now with the Indies overpast, the Head
 Of Earth begins, whose borders reach the sky.
 Rampired around, there stands a sacred grove
 To mortals inaccessible, and closed
 For aye—since th' Author of primeval Crime
 Departed guilty from that happy home,
 And there, instead, came heav'nly hosts to dwell.

Not here, in alternating seasons, come
 Winter, nor, after frosts, do Summer heats
 Return as the high circle of the year
 Revolves, nor chills that make the meadows hoar.
 Attentive Spring the clement sky obeys,
 No stormy South disturbs, and floating clouds
 Dispersing flee beneath the blue serene.

Nor need hath Nature here for frequent rain,
 Since all the happy buds with dew are kissed,
 The soil is ever green, the face of Earth
 Shines fair, plants do the hills adorn,
 And trees their tresses¹ are, with varied flowers
 They glow, and are with swift new sap supplied ;
 For what with us needs now a long year's growth
 Then bloomed and ripened in a fertile month.

Pellucid lilies light the land, unfading,
 No touch might violate the violets,²
 The rose's blush would still her face suffuse,
 Winter was not, nor torrid Summer heat,
 Spring crown'd the year with flow'rs, Autumn with fruit.

Here (what fame would falsely give Sabaea)
 Cinnamons grow, which the long-lived Phoenix
 Doth for its pyre collect—a Cradle-Grave !—
 When, from its blazing nest and death desired—
 Succeeding to itself—it springs new-born—
 Not willing with one birth to be content
 It doth the languor of its frame revive,
 And oft, its age out-burned, begins anew.

Here, too, the branches, dropping fragrant balm,
 Produce from the fat stem a constant flow.
 Then should perchance a light wind stir the air
 With gentle breath, a soft low whisper runs,

¹ Milton's translation is "hairy sides."

² Neither Sedulius nor Avitus disdained a gentle play on words.

The rich wood's leaves do tremble, and their flow'rs
Disperse delicious odours o'er the land.¹

There springs a Fount resplendent in the midst,
Naught with such grace in silver gleams, nor such
Cool liquid light in vases crystalline.
The margins glitter with green emeralds,
And a world's wonder of delightful gems
Lie pebbles here, that deck the happy fields
Around, with a natural Diadem !

From the Head Fountain waters are thence drawn
Four great divided rivers, these their names :
Euphrates, Tigris also, whose strong course
Forms the arrowy Parthians' long frontier,
Geon, the third, by Latins called the Nile,
Still nobler is, of birth unknown to man,
Whose placid stream throughout all Egypt flows,
Enriching, at fixed seasons, all the land.
For oft the swollen flood o'erleaps the banks
And inundates the fields with blackened sands,
Abundance follows, as the water's tax,
What skies refuse, the river-rain supplies.

Then Memphis hides within a spreading lake,
And husbandmen sail o'er their vanished farms,
No boundary binds—the Flood now levels all
With yearly Peace the elemental strife.

The happy Shepherd sees the grass submerged
And, where his flock fed on the verdant plain,
Flow waters strange, and fishes swimming gay.
Then, having fertilised the parchèd seeds
And largely quenched with drink the thirsty land,
The Nile retreats, and, gath'ring all its waters,
The lake shrinks to a stream, the furrowed bed
Encloses all, its banks its walls become,
Until at last, dividing and dispersed,
Its severed seven currents join the sea.

Yet why is so much said, and everywhere,
Of thy hid source, O Nile ? for who knows not
That from thy birth not sole, but fourth, thou art—
Shed from that height which overlooks all streams—
Its own, and Father Ocean—all surpassing
What mounts and plains, what clouds, and mists produce ?

¹ This is Milton's version :

Airs, vernal airs,
Breathing the smell of field and grove, attune
The trembling leaves.

THE EASTER SONG

Physon is fourth, which India calls the Ganges,
 That, oft unquiet, floods its odorous lands ;
 Its waters washing through the beauteous groves
 Bear to exile here deciduous wealth :
 For thence, from either shore, are wont to come
 Papyrus without knots, fine herbs and reeds.
 So with rich refuse that itself rejects
 Great Ganges doth in truth endow a World !

The Author of All gave the Primal Parents
 In this fair land of Paradise to dwell.
 As Ruler He pronounced the primal law—
 “ O Chief Work of the Maker—whom Our hand
 Alone created—Life I gave, what else ?
 Behold this land, most beautiful and rich
 With many gifts, shall serve you ; all is granted,
 For every need, repast, and lasting joy :
 Take this fair food, and these all-welcome fruits,
 In study of fine works abide in peace,
 Enjoy delights and live long happy lives.

“ There is, however, mid the grove one Tree
 Whose seed bears knowledge of the Right and Wrong
 Whereof it is forbidden you to touch,
 Lest that, perchance, rash eagerness to know
 May break the ban : ’twere better not to know
 That which harms when known. I Who made this Globe
 Attest that whoso this forbidden fruit
 Presume to taste shall be adjudged to Death.
 Not great the thing I ask, guard but the Right
 And happy Life, which such default would end.”

The Youths His words received and gladly followed
 Vowing throughout all time to keep the Law,
 So ignorant of ill, of fraud unconscious
 No fear alarms their unsuspecting minds.

Thus leaving them now taught, in sacred soil,
 The Father rose beyond the starry skies.

Avitus depicts Satan contemplating the novel beings, who, innocent and happy, were enjoying the peaceful delights of life in Paradise. Rage enters his heart, all the more furious on seeing others possessing what he had lost. He speaks the famous speech. Milton annexes the scene in full. The footnotes show his poly-plagiarism of the speech, whose beginning he simply translates, thus :

O Hell! What do mine eyes with grief behold?
 Into our room of bliss thus high advanced
 Creatures of other mould—Earth-born perhaps.

Bk. iv. l. 358.

Avitus thus gives

SATAN'S SPEECH ON SEEING MAN IN EDEN ¹

"O Grief!—this Creature to start up with Us! ²
 This Odious Race, to witness our destroyal!
 Lofty my state: behold me now, rejected,
 Cast out—and Clay usurp an Angel's honour! ³
 Earth now grasps Heaven—and of vile dust compacted ⁴
 Slime rules!—So perishes Our power, transferred,
 But not all has perished—great part remains—
 Our proper vigour—our all-wrecking courage! ⁵
 Delay delights not. Haste, sleek, subtle Strife!
 Whilst yet there's safety, and simple candour
 Unversed in guile is open to the dart.
 Better by fraud they should be snared, alone,
 Ere they shall plant a race eternal here,
 For naught immortal to the Earth belongs.
 Perish the source! the fallen head shall serve

¹ The happy seat
 Of some new race called Man.

Bk. ii. l. 347.

² A race of upstart creatures, to supply
 Perhaps our vacant room.

Bk. ii. l. 834.

³ (He) Determined to advance into our room
 A creature formed of earth, and him endow,
 Exalted from so base original,
 With Heavenly spoils, our spoils . . .
 Him Lord pronounced, and oh, indignity!
 Subjected to his service Angel-wings.

⁴ (He) Provokes my envy, this new favourite
 Of Heaven, this Man of Clay, son of despite,
 Whom, us the more to spite, his Maker raised
 From dust: spite then with spite is best repaid.

Bk. ix. ll. 150-178.

⁵ All is not lost—the unconquerable will
 And study of revenge, immortal hate,
 And courage never to submit or yield.

Bk. i. l. 106.

THE EASTER SONG

As lethal seed, Life's own origin shall
Engender Death, and all be smote in one !
No spreading branches from a cut root grow.¹

To me at least this solace doth remain,
If I no more may scale the closèd heavens
These too shall be shut out—misfortune doubled
Lessens, when others also meet like fate,
And come companions to partake the pain,
And share with us the fires which I forbode.

Nor should deception's way prove difficult ;
'Tis but to show the path I lately ran
To ruin—Ambition, that lost me Heaven,
Shall take the light of Paradise from Man."

He said, a groan his voice of anguish closed.

SATAN AS SERPENT

Than other animals, the supple serpent
Superior showed in ruse, and callous heart.
Him the Transgressor chose, and so endued
His aerial body with surrounding flesh.

Then he immediate changed, a Serpent stretched,—
Displayed the spotted splendours of his form
Spiring in folds voluminous, that showed
The shining armour of his scale-clad spine.

As when, in new-come Spring the Summer sends
Warm breezes forward after freezing cold
To change the season with soft quick'ning airs,
Displacing barrenness by radiant forms,
So passed the splendid snake ; quitting low haunts
He raised his terrible bright head, and awful
Beauty, with dire darting eyes,² which he taught

¹ And where their weakness : how attempted best,
By force or subtlety. Though Heaven be shut . . .
Seduce them to our party, that their God
May prove their foe. . . . For whence,
But from the author of all ill, could spring
So deep a malice, to confound the race
Of mankind in one root.

Bk. ii. l. 357-380.

² Milton makes the serpent move curiously, on a circular base of
towering fold on fold that floated redundant on the grass—

his head
Crested aloft, and carbuncle his eyes ;

Glad looks, when he approached the place desired,
With air caressing and soft singing sounds
By trifid tongue and tuneful throat produced.

When thus, in fraud maleficent, arrayed
And All-Deception now, he forth proceeds
To that fair grove, where, as it chanced, the youths
Were plucking berries from the verdant vine,—
Nor could a serpent with relentless spite
By venom sting their happy hearts to death.
He climbed, with spires enfolding, a tall tree
And drew himself to equal height above ;
Then thus assailed with gentle voice, well heard :

THE TEMPTATION OF EVE

THE SERPENT-SATAN'S ADDRESS

" Hail, Glory of Earth ! Maid most beautiful !
Resplendent, with rose modesty adorned,
Thou future Parent of the Race ; a World
Shall call thee Mother.¹ Man's first and firm joy,
His solace, without whom he could not live,
Even thy spouse is made subject to thy love
To whom thou renderest an offspring-race.
Paradise, a fitting seat, is giv'n you
Whom Earth's subject-substance trembling doth obey.
Whatever sky or land, or, from its deep,
Great ocean yields, are gather'd to your use ;
Nature naught denies, o'er all is given power.
I envy not, but wonder what restrains

With burnished neck of verdant gold, erect
Amidst his circling spires, that on the grass
Floated redundant.

Bk. ix. l. 499.

Milton asserts that his shape was " pleasing and lovely."

¹ Since the entire conception of this dramatic scene is due to Alcimus Avitus, it is unnecessary to point out details of disguised identity. I note but these :

Empress of this fair World, resplendent Eve !

M., Bk. ix. l. 568.

Eve rightly called, Mother of all Mankind.

M., Bk. xi. l. 159.

Sovran of creatures, universal Dame !

M., Bk. ix. l. 612.

O

THE EASTER SONG

Your choice from one sweet tree ; this cruel law
Who orders it ? Who envies you such gifts,
Imposing Fast mid such rich Festival ? ”

These flattering words in lisp'ing voice he spake.
A serpent speak, O woman what amaze !

What shame a beast to have this pow'r of words,
A brute presume thy tongue,¹ and still a shock
That thou should'st answer to his questioning !
When that the mortal venom filled the ear
Of ductile Eve, she then to ruin harks
And thus the Serpent with vain words addressed :

“ O mighty Snake of most delightful speech !
Not, though it seem, does God enjoin us fast
Nor hinder pasture for the body's care.
Lo, these fair banquets which the Earth spreads forth
The Father did, most readily, provide
For use, and freely loosed the reins of life.
This Tree alone, which thou, amid the wood,
Canst see, is interdict, to touch its fruit
Only is forbid, free is all the rest.
For if ill freedom should profane the law,
The Master's awful voice ordains we shall
Be doomed to expiate the guilt by Death !
What sayest thou of Death, most learned Snake ?
Tell all,—we ignorant do know it not.”

Then did the guileful Snake, the Minister
Of Death, thus teach, addressing captured ears :
“ O Woman ! thou fearest Terror's empty name.
No doom of death shall come upon you quick.
The Father did not grant you equal shares,
Nor let you know great things he hath reserved.
What use to see, to own the world adorned,
With blinded minds in darkened dungeon bound ?

“ Beasts too he made, with senses similar
And open eyes : one sun serves all alike—
The brute from man seems not set far apart !

“ Best take my counsel ! share the Mind supreme
And raise your senses up to Heaven erect.

“ This fruit forbidden which thou'st feared to touch
Makes known the secrets that the Father keeps :
For when thy lips its taste divine have felt,

¹ Not unamazed, she thus in answer spake :—

“ What may this mean ? Language of Man pronounced
By tongue of brute ! ” Milton.

Thy intellect illumed shall make thee God-like.
Then shalt thou Good from Evil know and Wrong
From Right, and then the False from True discern."

The whisp'ring promise of delusive gifts
The Woman heard with wonder and bow'd head,
And soon began to dally and incline
And ever more give doubting heed to death.

He felt her conquered in the coming strife
And, vaunting still the name and power of God,
He took an apple from the lethal Tree,
Diffused its fragrance and its form displaying
Offer'd its sweet to her assenting glance.

Nor spurned ill-trusting Eve the wretched gift
But caught the fatal apple, she raised it
To nostrils and to opening lips more near—
And ignorant she played with future Death !

Oh often she withdraws th' approaching fruit
Shaking,—her hand gives way beneath its weight,
And tremulous she flees th' accomplished crime,
Yet she would God-like be,—Ambition's ichor
Spreads, her mind by contrary forces torn.
Hence love, thence fear, now pride shall conquer law,
Now law itself gives help, so doubtful rage
The cruel wars of the distracted heart !

Nor does th' inciting Serpent cease his guile,
He lauds the apple, and deplores delay,
Hailing the guilt of her impending fall.

At last the stronger sentiment prevailed—
Eternal hunger by fair food provoked
Which she already from the snake had ta'en :
And, yielding to his wiles, she eager ate,
The sweet juice drank, and her Repast was Death !¹
His joy awhile the murky serpent hid,
Nor showed the savage triumph of his strife.

Unknown the deed to Adam, now returning
Joyful from mid the grasses of far fields
To seek a chaste kiss and his wife's embrace.
She ran to him, now first did boldness blow
Feminine fervour in the frenzied heart :

Thus she began to her mate miserable
Presenting in her hand the fatal fruit :

¹ Greedily she ingorged without restraint,
And knew not eating death.

Milton, Bk. ix. l. 791.

"Take this sweet food of living seed, my husband,¹
 That thou mayst like to the High God become
 And peer of all the gods. This gift I offer,
 Not ignorant, but knowing well : I first
 Have tasted it, and proudly broke the bond.
 Trust me, 'twas wrong for thy man's will to doubt
 What I a woman could, thou'st feared forestall ?
 Follow at least, and raise thy prostrate wits.
 Why lower thine eyes, why dally with desire ?
 Wouldst still filch time from this, thy coming glory ? "

She said and gave the dish of living death
 Which he with perishing soul, did crime-fed eat.

BANISHMENT, BABEL, AND EVOLUTION OF NATIONS

Whilst Marius Victor, with exquisite understanding, describes the pains of exile, Avitus states them in more serried form. Having related the judgment, he continues :

The Father clothed them with skins, and drove
 Them both from Paradise's sacred seat.
 Together fallen, they an empty World
 Entered, and with quick glance, examined all.
 Though varied growth it bore, and brodered grass,
 And verdant fields, fountains, and flowing rivers,
 To them its aspect horrible appeared.
 After thine, O Paradise, all was hateful.
 Man's wont :—what he must leave, he loves the more.
 Earth shrank on them, and they, unhappy, now
 In world of boundless space felt cramped, confined.
 Day dreary grew, and all light seemed to fade
 Beneath the sun, the stars mourned dull, remote,
 And scarce could any sense discern the sky.

Milton has it that Christ was the judge, and writes :

As father of his family, he clad
 Their nakedness, with skins of beasts, or slain.

Bk. x. l. 216.

Then later, when the Archangel Michael announces their expulsion, Adam is made to foresee and foretell that exile—

¹ Thou, therefore, also taste, etc.

M., Bk. ix. l. 881, *et seq.*

suffering, the poignant reality of which Victor and Avitus have so well described :

What besides
Of sorrow and dejection and despair
Our frailty can sustain, thy tidings bring—
Departure from this happy place, our sweet
Recess, and only consolation left
Familiar to our eyes, all places else
Inhospitable appear and desolate,
Not knowing us nor known.

In the *Aeneid*, Virgil relates how his hero is taken up to a lofty mountain that the future of his race might be revealed to him.

So Milton causes the Archangel Michael to take Adam up the highest hill in Paradise to reveal what should befall to him and his offspring. What was but an episode in Virgil occupies many pages in Milton. It is the history of the Hebrews. At first sight, I naturally consider it was compiled, or moulded, from the Biblical record, but it follows so closely on the descriptions of Victor and Avitus, with details given by them, and not in the Bible, that it became plain that Milton mined still in the works of these authors.

Here, in Book iii. of *Avitus* we find a description of the luxuries and licence in which man became degenerate, and on which Milton lays much and lengthy stress, and here again the horrors of fierce quarrelsome times, when Power was the only Protector, and Force the only Law.

Avitus makes a vivid, violent picture :

Mortals had then by cruel harshness shown
Their might of mind—what each one pleased he deemed
Permitted, and for each his Will was Law.
No Justice was, no diff'rence ever made
'Twixt Right and Wrong, no Ward of Virtue stood,
No Judge, no Witness, nor rose any Ruler—
Arbiter of action—to counsel honour,
Prince he felt who had the power to plunder,
Might not Merit won : the stronger the Man
The better the Man, Self the balance held.
So life of Man and brute became alike—
Add but a Mind to savage deeds inclined.

Milton renders it closely thus :

For in those days might only shall be admired,
And valour and heroic virtue called.
To overcome in battle, and subdue
Nations, and bring home spoils with infinite
Manslaughter, shall be held the highest pitch
Of human glory, and, for glory done,
Of triumph to be styled great conquerors,
Patrons of mankind, gods, and sons of gods—
Destroyers rightlier called, and plagues of men.
Thus fame shall be achieved, renown on earth,
And what most merits fame in silence hid.

Bk. xi. l. 689.

Then, after these, its causes, comes the Flood, to which, its causes and consequences, Avitus devotes a Book. It strikes one as significant that he begins this Book by a reference to Deucalion's fabled Flood and the regenerated race stone-born, and that Milton makes an identical reference on a similar occasion.

This is the vivid picture of the Iris—the Rainbow set in the heavens after the Flood, with its origin, and a thrilling statement of its symbolism, according to Avitus :

Three-fourths its course the setting Sun had gone,
When its ray touched, in eastern sky remote,
A cloud, and, thence, forth flashed a mist-born Sign,
That brilliant Bow, which poets call Thaumatis
In Greece, Iris in Rome, which hangs on air
Whilst e'er the vapour feels the slanting Sun.
Twofold the splendour of its mingled colours
Innumerate, with play of varied hues :
Glowing sapphire, white, and ocean-green,
Purple from the cloud, from the sky its sheen,
The Sun its radiance, and the Earth its shades ;
Dissevered and diverse as these appear,
The eye a harmony supreme beholds.

God set His Bow upon a cloud in sign
To trembling mortals that from cloud no more
Should fate disastrous fall from Heav'n on Earth.

Now, those who would true faith retain may look
Up to that Sign, and know what these betoken.
For Christ, Life-giver, sent these as harbingers,
Foreshowing the Redeemer's twofold substance—

Earth yields the Brightness of flesh Virginal,
 Heaven, the innate Splendour of its Glory;
 Midway on high the Mediator stands
 With gifts innumerate, in all refulgent,
 The Living Sign of God's celestial Pledge.

Milton makes strangely little of this. Adam, under the control of the Archangel, sees "the ancient sire," Noah, come out of the Ark, looking up he beholds over his head

A dewy cloud, and in the cloud a bow
 Conspicuous with three listed colours gay,
 Betokening peace from God, and covenant new.

Adam inquires :

But say what mean those coloured streaks in Heaven :
 Distended as the brow of God appeared ?
 Or serve they as a flowery verge to bind
 The fluid skirts of that same watery cloud,
 Lest it again dissolve and shower the earth ?

The Archangel explains the oft-mentioned covenant not again to drown the world,

but, when he brings

Over the Earth a cloud, will therein set
 His triple-coloured bow, whereon to look
 And call to mind his covenant.

More interesting than most other passages is that which concerns the building of the Tower of Babel. The subject is treated by Victor and by Avitus, and Milton follows the Bishop, as being the more brief. But that of Marius Victor displays so much originality, understanding, sympathy, and science that it is impossible not to give it the higher place.

This is the spirited story of Avitus :

BUILDING OF BABEL

This was the Giant-race of olden Terror,
 Whose acts the Greeks in fictive poems sang,
 Who still would dare the temerarious strife,
 Each man a Rebel, who, when battle bolts
 Had failed, raging, devised another war ;
 Not that as sung, they mounts on mountains piled,

THE EASTER SONG

But, my belief is, these were they who tried
 With well-burnt brick and bitumen close joined
 To build, if that could be, with their proud hands
 The Tower, and raise it to the stars sublime.

Thus men can madden, and with labour vain
 And vain cement push upwards still and pierce
 The clouds, and seek receding Heav'n to gain,
 Nor did desist, till Discord, giving tongues
 And language various, did all things confound.
 Hence was the common bond of reckless Pride
 By severance of speech asunder broke.

Then each his own, whom he by words might know,
 Assembled, and each speech a People made.
 So lacking labour, the great Mole ceased mounting
 And th' empty Tow'r stood idle in the air.

The burthened Earth, since came the whelming Flood,
 Grew oft such giant Forts, that still aspired
 To mingle with the indignant stars of Heaven,
 Which God swept off and silent we condemn.

As Milton has not only "conveyed" from Avitus, but also from Victor, it is proper to insert here a translation of the latter's poem. It is really a beautiful and tender psychologic study, with chivalric sympathies for the gallant daring of a defeated People. His theory of the Origin of Races shows scientific talent.

THE BUILDING OF BABEL ORIGIN OF NATIONS

When, after years, their numbers had increased
 And outgrown space, the Orient they left,
 Compelled to seek new homes, and camped at last
 Upon the spreading plain of Sennaar.

Now, when this also they were forced forsake
 And their sons made to sever and depart,
 These, grieving, raised most sorrowful complaint :

" Ah, how unstable is our Life's estate !
 How ignorant if what's prospering shall fail !
 How witless that our cherish'd Hope may prove
 Our Adversary—for, dare we say it ?
 Ev'n that for which our great Forefathers prayed,
 A numerous offspring, becomes our hurt !
 The crowding hosts must scatter wide and far
 Over Earth's surface, Exiles ! from this Land,
 Their Native Home, for ever banned !

And we
 Seared by chill poverty—unknown, unhonoured—
 Shall lie in lonely graves, nor build
 With seemly rites our Fathers' sepulchres.
 Nor aught of fair renown outlive our death !
 " Therefore, take action, youths, in numbers strong,
 Whilst what may hap, or end you, lies unknown,
 Bequeath to Future Time resplendent Fame !
 Let us a City build, whose rampired Tower
 We'll raise, till it shall reach the shining stars,
 The sky, and the supreme Olympian sphere.
 Then shall posterity, when we are gone,
 Believe we entered, Emigrants to Heaven ! "

Inspired, the youths contemning rocks and crash
 Of crumbling cliffs, rove out the conquered earth
 And forced by fire the fashioned brick ; resolved
 By their own hands to shape the mighty Mole.
 The jointed layers with bitumen they built,
 Which solid stood, and like a Rampart-rock.
 Soon rose the Tower, soon its high head transpierced
 The clouds and saw a nearer sky serene !

Then to the Senate of His Angels—all
 Astonished at such courage and mad pride—
 A Voice Celestial, the Father's, spake :
 " You see advance the daring Troop terrene—
 Imprudent they, and in adventure reckless—
 They deem it possible, by mortal means,
 The lofty sky to reach, and conquer aether,
 Whilst none with form terrene endued ascends
 To Heav'n, save who shall have from Heav'n descended.¹
 Yet since they are of common speech and kin,
 They do persist, nor will refrain to finish
 That Tower which they, by common concert, planned,
 So great the folly of the human mind !

" Therefore go forth, that they may understand
 What is forbidden is not possible.
 Let us descend, and that bold conjuration
 Of overweening pride in speech dissolve.
 So what of Concord criminal they sinned
 May perish of a Dissonance, more kind."

He said. Then first on their astonished minds
 Oblivion came, and unknown tongues were heard,

¹ *I.e.* no earth-born creature can ascend by its own volition, but may be taken by assumption, as was the prophet Elias.

THE EASTER SONG

The Captains clamoured to unheeding men ;
 They dallied, labour lagged, and all work stopped.
 None answered apt—did one attempt, vain sounds
 He muttered, or in panting broken phrase
 He stammered out : so the great Enterprise
 Frustrated hands forsook, none stood by none,
 None comrade joined, nor even father followed :
 If one another understood, they sought
 For others such, formed groups, and these increased.
 So came connexions in the parted People.
 Language made Nations. These in equal Hosts
 Fared forth and under many and strange Stars
 Found Foreign Homes afar.

So when the birds
 Whom pleasant plain and smiling day invite
 To wander and win food in mingled flocks
 See Night approach, they seek their leafy roofs,
 All following their flocks, with rapid flight,
 By Colour companied, or by Cry recalled.

Thus, into several, one People parted,
 That Tribes might Races form in lands diverse,
 And fill the Globe with Nations manifold.

With these descriptions of the building of Babel compare that of Milton, who adopts and embodies their ideas, but diverges, and as usual when he diverges he descends to a lower plane. Adam is told that after the Flood the chastened but increasing race should live peaceful and laborious lives, under paternal rule, in families and in tribes, until one arrogant Man, rejecting fraternal equality, should impose tyranny—a “mighty hunter before the Lord”—but a hunter of men. Then Milton’s Angel continues his forecast to Adam :

He, with a crew, whom like ambition joins
 With him or under him to tyrannise,
 Marching from Eden towards the west, shall find
 The plain, wherein a black bituminous gurge
 Boils out from under ground, the mouth of Hell.
 Of brick and of that stuff they cast to build
 A city and tower, whose top may reach to Heaven,
 And get themselves a name, lest, far dispersed
 In foreign lands, their memory be lost—
 Regardless whether good or evil fame.

But God, who oft descends to visit men
 Unseen, and through their habitations walks,
 To mark their doings, them beholding soon,
 Comes down to see their city, ere the tower
 Obstruct Heaven-towers, and in derision sets
 Upon their tongues a various spirit, to rase
 Quite out their native language, and, instead,
 To sow a jangling noise of words unknown.
 Forthwith a hideous gabble rises loud
 Among the builders ; each to other calls,
 Not understood—till, hoarse and all in rage,
 As mocked they storm. Great laughter was in Heaven,
 And looking down to see the hubbub strange
 And hear the din. Thus was the building left
 Ridiculous, and the work *Confusion* named.

It is manifest that for his higher and more noble flights Milton used the great eagle wings of Sedulius. Raised by these above the earth, he could catch a glimpse of the celestial beauty. Apparently, however, this was too ethereal for his taste, he felt impelled to "humanise" it. The consequence is that when, laying aside those wings, he diverges from Sedulius, he descends and pedestrianises in the dust.

Take three examples :—

1. When Sedulius describes the delight in Heaven and on Earth, when God forgives Man, and the Divine Son assumes human flesh as a free-will Atonement, he writes "Where Guilt gave Death now Love would Life bestow." Milton takes his text, writing "So Heavenly love shall outdo Hellish hate." But he elaborately explains that this came about because the Son shamed the Father to consent, because otherwise, Satan would win a triumph over Him, by ruining His created race and that nobody could defend Him ! How could a writer on such a subject adduce a motive so unspeakably mean ?

2. In the second instance, Sedulius brings us to the "Celestial City," seated on a hill, all brightness and all beauty and all welcoming, its banners fluttering on high, its clarion call an invitation, its Gate that opens to the knocking of Heart ! Milton also brings us to the gate of his Celestial City—or "Frontispiece"—it is "more rich" than that of a king's palace,

studded with gems, and could not be drawn by artist on earth—but it does not open! Souls, coming in fiery cars or boat on seas of pearl and jasper, must climb up ladders to get over the fortifications. And these ladders! They are not always there; they are let down and snatched up, now and again, to daunt, or taunt, and “aggravate” Satan, by seeming to invite and then excluding the miserable Satan! How could this be conceived of Heaven by a noble mind?

3. We see that Milton also follows Sedulius in his description of the Saviour’s Ascension into Heaven, which, in Sedulius, is the consummation of self-sacrificial Love in an atmosphere of celestial peace: but Milton, diverging, plagiarises from Homer, and describes the Redeemer as going to “surprise the Serpent, Prince of Air, and drag in chains through all his realm, and there confounded leave.” What chivalrous man could take the dastard deed of Achilles as an example, or what Christian mind could impute it to his Saviour?

So, also, with respect to the brilliant works of Marius Victor, and Alcimus Avitus, where Milton follows them we move amid the beautiful scenes of Paradise and witness noble if tragic action, where Milton diverges he descends into the mire. Take these examples:

1. There is nowhere given so sympathetic or so understanding an account of the cause and the consequences of the building of Babel tower, and its arrest, as that given by Victor. He feels, as what generous heart could fail to feel, with a people driven from their kindred, their homes, their native land—no more to build their fathers’ sepulchres—to lie themselves in far, scattered, lonely graves, leaving behind no fair name, no record of high renown. It were better for them, if disappear they must, to go as “emigrants to Heaven!” Both Victor and Avitus have displayed a certain admiration for their adventurous boldness and show that God intervenes out of loving compassion that they may not break themselves, in trying to achieve the impossible. He gives them various languages that so may different nations be evolved. This is fine and philosophical. But Milton, whilst following

minutely the statement, diverges and degenerates. His God is made to walk unseen among their homes, then "in derision" to set their tongues to a "jangling noise," a "hideous gabble," "till, hoarse and all in rage, as mocked they storm." Then, surely there was pity for them?—no, not in Milton's heaven!

Great laughter was in Heaven,
And looking down to see the hubbub strange
And hear the din. Thus was the building left
Ridiculous, and the work *Confusion* named.

In presence of this scene of sordid spite, so devised and so enjoyed by the author, one can only say that Milton's humour is appalling.

2. In another case, Milton, whilst annexing all the Temptation of Eve, and most of what follows in both writers, diverges and by diverging degrades Adam by setting him to scold Eve with base abuse. "Out of my sight, thou Serpent,"¹ he reviles her as hateful, a snare of hellish falsehood, longing to be seen if but by the Devil, Satan's ally, vain and deceitful, knavish, a mere crooked rib, thought to overreach Satan, Satan overreached her, and she overreached him (Adam)!

3. Lastly, the third instance is perhaps the most Miltonic. Sedulius and his three successors, more especially Victor and Avitus, have given most lovely, picturesque, and delightful descriptions of Paradise—the Garden of Eden—where the ever-fertile virgin soil ever produces flowers and fruit of the fairest, with delightful odours and soft music in the zephyr-loved woods. To all this, Milton must put his sign-manual, and by one characteristic touch make it Miltonic, and all his own. So, apparently recalling his London town-garden, or that little plot in front of his small house at Chalfont St. Giles—which I have visited—he sets Eve to tie up drooping flowers,² and Adam removes fallen blossoms and dropping gums. Victor and Avitus suggest higher Nature studies. Milton is more practical and—in this ever-fertile virgin soil—makes Adam concerned and anxious about *manuring the Garden of Eden*! "To-morrow, ere fresh morning

¹ Bk. x. l. 867.

² Bk. ix. l. 430.

streak the east" they must be risen to reform things "that mock our scant manuring."¹ That is startling, but Milton must have taken especial pride in this agricultural top-dressing of the Garden of Eden, for he absolutely introduces it into Heaven, as a plea in favour of Adam! In Book xi. the prayers of the penitents ascend to Heaven.

Them the glad Son

Presenting thus to intercede began :

" See, Father, what first-fruits on Earth are sprung
From thy implanted grace in Man—these sighs
And prayers, which in this golden censer, mixed
With incense, I, thy priest, before thee bring ;
Fruits of more pleasant savour, from thy seed
Sown with contrition in his heart, than those
Which, his own hand manuring, all the trees
Of Paradise could have produced, ere fallen
From innocence.

It has not been my purpose to indicate the sources in later times, from which Milton has borrowed more or less copiously. Some of these drew from the high head fountains here revealed. There have been many workers in these fields, and much success. If all our results were put together, it would appear that Milton's great Poem was a great Mosaic of other men's ideas. Then, one might consider the possibility of the *Iliad* being also a compilation or mosaic—if only Homer, like Milton, had greater predecessors ; " sed caret sacer vates." Milton stands unrivalled still, as a Prince of Poets and of Plagiarists.

SECTION III

PART I

Milton's Debt to Virgil

Virgil or Vergil is Fergil, a Celtic name, as Zeuss has shown and naturally takes place with his kindred victims.

If we consider the Last Epic of Christendom, as compared with the First, we shall find that Milton has fallen back upon the Pagan poetic precedents, from which Sedulius courage-

¹ Bk. iv. l. 628.

ously stood free. This is not a question of their relative powers nor of their genius. But if it can be said that Juvenecus did not succeed in doing more than clothing Christ in the costume of a greater Aeneas, can it be alleged that Milton in rolling through the skies the tumult of wars has essentially diverged from ancient examples, and not rather refurbished the old epic machinery which gave us Jove thundering against the Titans, and hurling his rebel-rivals to the depths of Tartarus? The names are different, the descriptions and discourses amplified and diverse, but under all the shining array and glorious guise of noble words the old machinery moves.

There are even entire passages where not only are the ideas the same, but where the verbal description might almost stand as a free translation or paraphrase of passages in the *Aeneid*. Thus, when visiting the realm of punishment, Aeneas asks the Cumæan Sibyl, his guide, who were the sufferers and what their crimes and tortures were? She tells, in Dryden's version, that beyond the dreadful portals lies the realm of unrelenting hate, and thus proceeds :

The gaping gulf low to the centre lies,
And twice as deep as earth is distant from the skies ;
The Rivals of the Gods, the Titan Race,
Here, singed with lightning, roll within th' unfathomed space ;
Here lie the Aloean twins (I saw them both),
Enormous bodies of gigantic growth,—
Who dared in fight the Thunderer to defy,
Affect his Heav'n, and force him from the Sky :
Salmoneus suffering cruel pains I found,
For emulating Jove with rattling sound
Of mimic thunder, and the glittering blaze
Of pointed lightnings and their forked rays.

But he, the King of Heav'n, obscure on high,
Bared his right arm, and, launching from the Sky
His withered bolt, not shaking empty smoke,
Down to the deep abyss the flaming Felon struck.
There Tityus was to see, who took his birth
From Heav'n, his nursing from the foodful earth ;
Here his gigantic limbs with large embrace
Infold nine acres of infernal space.

Milton, immediately after invoking the heavenly muse, asks an explanation of the Fall of our great Parents and who seduced them from their happy state. He is answered—That it was the infernal serpent

what time his pride

Had cast him out from Heaven, with all his host
Of rebel Angels, by whose aid, aspiring
To set himself in glory above his peers,
He trusted to have equalled the Most High,
If he opposed, and, with ambitious aim
Against the throne and monarchy of God,
Raised impious war in Heaven and battle proud,
With vain attempt. Him the Almighty Power
Hurled headlong flaming from the ethereal sky,
With hideous ruin and combustion, down
To bottomless perdition, there to dwell
In adamant chains and penal fire,
Who durst defy the Omnipotent to arms,
Nine times the space that measures day and night
To mortal men, he, with his horrid crew,
Lay vanquished, rolling in the fiery gulf.

Virgil's gulf is twice as deep as earth is from the skies, and Milton's is "as far removed from God and light of Heaven as from the centre thrice to the utmost pole." Then after an interchange of long discourse between Satan and Beelzebub, we come upon verses which close and complete the parallel. The Titan's gigantic limbs "with large embrace, infold nine acres of Infernal space."

Satan talks to his nearest mate, with head uplift above the wave :

his other parts besides

Prone on the flood, extended long and large,
Lay floating many a rood, in bulk as huge
As whom the fables name of monstrous size,
Titanian or Earth-born, that warred on Jove, . . .

Then he goes on to amplify by added comparisons with Briareos or Typhon, or Leviathan.

Not to multiply instances, it may suffice to quote the description of the Gate of the Infernal Region as given in Virgil :

The hero, looking on the left, espied
 A lofty Tow'r and strong on every side
 With treble walls, which Phlegethon surrounds,
 Whose fiery flood the burning empire bounds ;
 And press'd betwixt the rocks the bellowing noise rebounds.
 Wide is the fronting Gate and, raised on high,
 With adamantine Columns threatens the sky.
 Vain is the force of Man, and Heav'n's as vain,
 To crush the Pillars which the Pile sustain.
 Sublime on these a Tow'r of Steel is rear'd ;
 And dire Tisiphone there keeps ward,
 Girt in her sanguine gown, by night and day,
 Observant of the souls that pass the downward way.

Then, of itself, unfolds the eternal door ;
 With dreadful sound the brazen hinges roar.

Then Milton, elaborating the theme :

At last appear

Hell-bounds, high reaching to the horrid roof,
 And thrice threefold the gates ; three folds were brass,
 Three iron, three of adamantine rock,
 Impenetrable, impaled with circling fire,
 Yet unconsumed. Before the gates there sat
 On either side a formidable Shape.
 The one seem'd woman to the waist and fair,
 But ended foul in many a scaly fold, . . .

She had sprung, "a goddess armed," out of the head of Lucifer (after a most violent headache), whilst yet in Heaven (even as Minerva from the head of Jupiter). She was called Sin, and now, distorted portress of Hell, opened the gate for Satan's exit. Milton's hideous picture of pollution finds no parallel in the nobler imagination of the pagan poet of Mantua.

The terse lines of Virgil, descriptive of the opening gate are thus expanded :

On a sudden open fly,
 With impetuous recoil and jarring sound,
 The infernal doors, and on their hinges grate
 Harsh thunder, that the lowest bottom shook
 Of Erebus.

APPENDIX II

IRISH METRICAL CHARACTERISTICS IN SEDULIAN VERSE

WHEN a foreigner writes Latin, he naturally follows the classic models. Celts of Gaul, where Roman power predominated for centuries, obeyed its influence in literature, but as the Roman power diminished its literary absolutism was less considered, and the old native inherent tendency toward rime began to display itself in that new domain of Christian thought and feeling which found expression in hymns. These were things of another sphere, outside of classic experience and control, and hence the inherent racial qualities could show themselves more freely.

An Irish poet of the fifth century stood in a different position. His nation had not been subject to Roman power, but retained its independence. The knowledge and influence of the Latin language and literature did not bear on him with the practice and prestige of generations. He might write in subjection to classic models, it is true, but he was more free of mind and, if trained in his nation's metric, he was more apt to infuse some of its characteristics into his Latin verse. If therefore it can be shown that such signs are to be found in the verse of Sedulius, we shall have intrinsic evidence of an indisputable quality, that the author was an Irish poet.

These signs must be characteristic of Irish metric. It will not suffice, for instance, to show the occasional presence of rime, for sporadic rimes can be found, not only in Ennius, Ovid, Horace, Virgil, but also in Greek writers, such as

Sophocles and Homer, and even in the Hebrew. Such sporadic rimes were sometimes intended, but in many cases, I venture to say, they were accidental and probably passed quite unperceived by ears trained in time-metric. Thus to ears trained in tone-metric a classic verse may pass unnoted. How many persons have read the Scriptural text : " Why do the heathen rage, and the people imagine a vain thing ? " How few have identified it as a classic hexameter ?

No one can read Sedulius without noticing the occurrence of similar-end rimes, and the repetition of echoing syllables. Dr. J. Huemer¹ has counted twenty-four examples of rime in caesura semiquinaria, as :

pone supercilium si te cognoscis amicum

also twelve in caesura hephthemimeri, as :

humana pro gente pius occumberet agnus

three, in caesura trithemimeri, as :

sed modicae contentus adi solemnina mensae.

Then he enumerates fifteen or sixteen cases, where an end-syllable is repeated in a line, *e.g.* :

at Dominus, Verbum, Virtus sapientiae, Christus.

Lastly, he notices that lines often have like endings, as, " aevi " and " caeli," and he mentions that about fifteen lines end as " creando " and " castro " in one riming syllable as he imagines.

He fails altogether to see that such endings as " aevi " and " caeli," " creando " and " castro " are perfect Gaelic two-syllabic vowel-rimes. He has examined the Sedulian verse as a Roman Latinist might have examined it, seen the repetition of sounds similar to what had been noted in classic authors, counted them (their frequency might have given him cause for thought), but he had not the Cumaeian Golden Bough and could not enter, explore, and explain.

¹ *De Sedulii poetae vita*, etc., Dr. Johannes Huemer, Vindobonae, 1878.

The Golden Bough for us is the Gaelic metric. Without some knowledge of this, it is impossible to identify and understand the true character of Sedulian verse ; possessing this, it is impossible not to see and affirm that Sedulius was a poet trained in Irish methods.

SECTION I

DEMONSTRATION OF IRISH METRIC

If it be possible to show that rimed couplets, for instance, were employed systematically, it should be acknowledged that rime was used as an art-method or "Kunstmittel," and that it indicated an Irish source, since it was used systematically by Irish bards and by no Latin poet. This indication would be confirmed and the evidence made effective and convincing if the rime used was not only consonantal but assonantal, so specifically characteristic of Irish verse.

Now this is precisely what can be demonstrated most readily, though it never has been hitherto suspected.

The *Carmen Paschale* of Sedulius is composed of five Books, each Book containing 300 or more lines. Here is the remarkable characteristic—one not known to exist in any other Latin poem—each and every Book of the *Carmen Paschale* concludes with a couplet, rimed in the artistic Irish manner ! They are here given in due order as follows :

BOOK I

semina mittentes, mox Exultabimus Omnes,
Portantes nostros, Christo veniente, maniplos.

BOOK II

et bona libertas, euadere Torua Cruenti
ora lupi, vitæque frui, per Pascua Christi.

BOOK III

parua loquor, Si facta dei per Singula curram
et Speciale bonum, quum sit generale reuoluam.

BOOK IV

obvia Turba dedit? Domino nisi cum Patre Christo
qui regit aethereum Princeps in Principe regnum.

BOOK V

Facta redemptoris, nec Totus Cingere mundus
sufficeret densos per Tanta volumina libros.

The first fact manifest to ear and eye is that the final lines in the first and last Books terminate in the same rime (*os*), whilst those of the other Books end differently. This closing echo of the earliest rime shows a purposed plan.

Next we come to the Irish structure-characteristics of these verses. They are very definite:¹ each Latin line would be regarded as made of two semi-metres (so two lines represent the Gaelic quatrain). Now it is ordered that in certain Gaelic forms the last words of each semi-metre should rime, which is here distinctly done, in both lines, thus *es, es*, and *os, os* in Book I.

There is yet another and a more subtle, searching, and decisive characteristic. This is the question of "Concord" or alliteration—the harmonic relations of two initial letters—all vowels may alliterate (though they can rime only within their classes); consonants rime and alliterate only within their classes. There are two kinds of Concord, which may be

¹ It is necessary to remember that the Irish classified the vowels into two classes: the slender, *i* and *e*, and the broad, *a*, *o*, *u* (which must be pronounced as in Italian or Spanish). All vowels serve to alliterate: but the slender rime with the slender only, and the broad with the broad. This distinction is scientific, and the extension of rime to vowels of the same class is artistic, since it prevents the monotony, so dangerous and limiting in modern verse.

The consonants also were grouped in classes:

1. The letter *s* stood alone, the "queen of consonants," riming and alliterating only with another *s*.
2. Three soft or noble letters, *p*, *c*, *t* (*c* is always *k*), which can rime and alliterate with each other only.
3. Three lower or hard: *g*, *b*, *d*, riming and alliterating with each other only.
4. Five "strong," *ll*, *nn*, *rr*, *m*, *ng*, with similar powers.
5. Seven "light," *b*, *d*, *g*, *m*, *l*, *n*, *r*, with similar powers.

O'Molloy, *De Prosodiâ hibernicâ*. Rome, 1677.

called major and minor : in the first or proper Concord the alliteration must occur between the initials of the last two words of the line. Alliteration may, however, take place in an earlier and less emphatic part, and is then a minor Concord.

BOOK I.—Observe, now, that in these two Latin lines, which conclude Book I. there are: (1) Rimes between the semi-metres; (2) there is proper or major Concord between the initial vowels—E, O—of the last two words of the first line, and (3) there is minor Concord between the initials—P, C of the two earlier words of the second line—*Portantes nostros Christo*—(the intervening word does not count, it “neither makes nor mars” alliteration). Thus every condition demanded by Irish metric is found in this couplet: there are besides internal slender rimes, *semin* and *mitten*, and *ente*, and broad-slender interlaced rimes in *omnes* and *tantes*, with pure broad in *os*, *os*.

*semina mittentes, mox Exultabimus Omnes,
Portantes nostros, Christo veniente, maniplos.*

It must also be pointed out that it presents an example of linked or Interlaced Rime, where the rime (in *es*) noted in the first line is re-echoed in the second; this interlacing rime is a most notable characteristic. *Christo* and *maniplos* also rime.

I can conceive nothing more complete or convincing. The subsequent couplets can do no more than confirm this demonstration, but they do, one and all, emphatically confirm it.

BOOK II.—The last or rimed couplet of Book II. is different in structure. Here the lines present assonant or vowel rimes which are of two syllables (*enti*, *isti*) with slender letters—for though slender vowels could alliterate with broad (to prevent monotony) as in the first example, they can only rime within their own class as in this example.

Next there is major Concord in each line—T, C and P, C—and lastly there is a most remarkable instance of “union,” linked or interlaced-rime. Take this condition laid down for a certain Irish metric form: “It is demanded that there

should be a correspondence (or rime) between two other words in each couplet " (besides the finals), of which one is to be in the first line of the first couplet and a corresponding one in the second line, and of these the word in the first line should be the last but one, or nearly so, of that line, and should agree with its riming word in the next in number of syllables, in quantity, in vowels, whether slender and broad, and in the sound of the vowels.¹

Now, a glance at the Latin lines shows that the last word but one—*Torua*—rimes exactly as required with the last but one—*Pascua*—in the second line.

*et bona libertas, euadere Torua Cruenti
ora lupi, vitaeque frui, per Pascua Christi.*

Here, therefore, we have two instances of major Concord, assonant or vowel End-rimes, and a perfect specimen of "Union" linked or interlaced rimes! A lighter echo of the Irish metric is found in the riming words *bona* and *ora*—*lupi* and *frui*—with identical vowels.

BOOK III.—In Book III. the final couplet is of special interest because it has no real relevancy to what precedes, and is obviously added to finish the Book with an Irish rimed distich. It differs in structure and is rich in rime. The end-word in the first line is of two syllables, that of the second of three syllables—a curious characteristic of certain Irish metres. These rime by broad vowels in the two last syllables.

There is abundance of internal rime, as four words in the first line assonate perfectly—*parua, loquor, facta, curram*—and have their echo or linked rime (*bonum*) in the second line. In the latter also there is a four-syllable vowel internal rime, between *speciale* and *generale*.² The three letters S represent Concord. This is the couplet:

¹ O'Molloy, *De prosodiâ hibernicâ*, Rome, 1677. Translated by T. O'Flannghaile, Dublin. Gill & Son, 1907.

² A curiously similar polysyllabic internal rime is present (with alliteration) in Thomas Moore's "Song of Fionnuala":

While *murmuring mournfully* Lir's Lonely daughter

See Appendix III.

*parua loquor, Si facta dei per Singula curram,
et Speciale bonum, quum sit generale reuoluam.*

To produce so complex and complete a metrical feat explains why Sedulius had to select a distich somewhat apart from the context (which gave me a clue to its secret Celtic construction).

BOOK IV.—The two terminal lines of Book IV. present major Concord, or alliteration, in the first line, and minor Concord in the second. There are double internal and end-rimes—this time with a slender and a broad vowel in each line. Thus :

*obvia Turba dedit ? Domino nisi cum Patre Christo
qui regit aethereum Princeps in Principe regnum.*

There is Alliteration of the "noble" consonants, T, P, C; and manifest "linked" or interlaced rimes between the lines in *dedit, regit, princeps, princip.*

We now come to the last lines of the last Book.

BOOK V.—It is curious and of interest to note, that whilst the Second, Third, and Fourth Books finish by couplets having double vowel rimes, these appear to have been studiously varied : thus the Second Book rimes on two slender vowels, the Third on two broad vowels, and the Fourth on a slender and a broad vowel.

In the Fifth Book, whilst the last riming syllable is a distinct echo of that of the First Book, the structure of the couplet is varied. There is minor (and interlaced) Concord in the letters T, C, T, and two internal words *facta* and *totus* rime in the first line with the final word *mundus* : these find their echo, link or interlacing rime, in the word *tanta* of the next line. In this, the last line, an internal word rimes with the last word, both ending in *os*, like the final syllable of Book I., but here a nice variation is obtained by the introduction of dissyllabic or double-rimes—*densos* and *libros*—riming on slender and broad vowels :

*Facta redemptoris, nec Totus Cingere mundus
sufficeret densos per Tanta volumina libros.*

There is Alliteration, T, C, T.

It is manifest that accurate knowledge, great care, and studious skill must have co-operated to produce such exact complete and varied examples of the Irish metric in Latin verse. These were reserved for the finishing lines of each Book, as finials to an edifice, and are as irresistible evidences of Irish artistic authorship as would be an interlaced illuminated illustration from an ancient Irish manuscript.

SECTION II

DISSEMINATED TRACES

The care and curious workmanship devoted to the closing couplets of the five Books so as to mould them to the Irish metric could not be given, and should not be expected in the structure of the great Epic. At most we may expect occasional instances of alliteration, of internal assonance and of other rime. These, indeed, are found in unique abundance.

Take first the address To the Reader—Ad Lectorem—in elegiac verse. To the Latinist or casual observer the presence of leonine rimes of one syllable is apparent, and has been noted. But besides and beyond this, the expert in Gaelic metric will quickly perceive a remarkable and varied richness of assonance and double rimes, with alliteration often.

These are the first four lines in the Address :

Paschales Quicunque dapes Conuiua requiris
dignatus nostris accubitare Toris,
Pone Supercilium, Si te Cognoscis amicum
ne Quaeras Opus hic Codicis Artificis.

The Latinist notes in the first line, but two rimes, (*es*, *es*), the Gaelic metric recognises three, *es*, *es*, *is*, as the slender vowels rime together. Besides there are obviously two internal double rimes (*ales* and *dapes*). There is also concord or alliteration of the consonants P, Q, C.

In the second line, where there seemed to be only two thin

single rimes (*is, is*) the Gaelic metric detects three rich double rimes, *nostris, tare, toris*.

In the third line, Dr. J. Huemer noted but two single riming syllables (*um, um*), the Gaelic metric recognises five double rimes—*ium, icum*, also *pone, super, oscis*—and an alliteration, S, S.

In the fourth line, where only two single rimes *is, is*—are noticed, there are two double-rimes—*icis, icis*—and two vowel and two consonantal concords—O with A, and Q with C.

It is needless to proceed with further detail. Every line has been tested in a similar manner, with a somewhat similar result. Several instances of assonance and alliteration are to be found scattered throughout the Books.¹ As a rule, however, he duly adheres to the classic models, diverging systematically only at Book ends, or in passages of exceptional emotion. One may take the following passage where the Gaelic method shows through the Roman mould.

The poet describes how with comrade Hope and Faith, he ascends the Hill Sublime and beholds the Celestial City. He is deeply moved, and in moments of emotion native feeling and training prevail over the later learning, so that the Irish method appears :

nunc coeptam Iuuat Ire viam, montemque per *Altum*,
nitentes firmare *gradus*, properemus in urbem,
libertatis opem, radians ubi Regia fuluis
emicat aula tholis, ubi Dantur Digna Petenti,
quaerenti Spes Certa manet, Claustrisque remotis,
Peruia Pulsanti reserantur limina Cordi.²

Here the rimes would be overlooked by a Latinist, but in the first line there are four—*am, at, am, um*—with a vowel Concord—I, I, A. In the second there seem to be only two (*us, us*),

¹ For instance :

Turbaret geminas Cumulato Pisce Carinas.

Bk. iv. l. 121.

and

gaudia non *ferimus* Propensaue vota *Timemus*.

Bk. iv. l. 123.

² Liber i. v. 282, etc.

but the end-word of the first line obtains its link or interlaced rime here—in *gradus*, and the end-word *urbem*, of the second finds its internal rime in *are* and its interlaced rime—*opem*—in the third line. The terminal word—*fuluis*—of the third rimes with these and is re-echoed by the link or interlaced rime—*tholis*—in the fourth! Then also the three-syllabled end-word of the fourth line—*petenti*—is re-echoed, interlaced and rimed by the first word of the fifth line—*quaerenti*. The end word of the fifth line rimes by its last two syllables—*motis*—with *manet*, and its interlaced rime-syllables—*santi*—and directly with the terminal of the sixth line *cordi*.

There is also concord or alliteration obviously present, and yet a Latinist would not perceive a rime, in a passage interwoven with a musical network of interlaced assonances!

The next example is not the least important. Having described Christ as “*Pax Crucis*,” the “Peace of the Cross,” Sedulius proceeds to explain the symbolism of the Cross:

neue quis ignoret, speciem Crucis esse Colendam
 quae dominum Portauit ouans, ratione Potenti
 quatuor inde Plagas Quadrati Colligit orbis,
 splendidus Auctoris de vertice fulget Eous,
 occiduo Sacrae lambuntur Sidere plantae,
 arcton dextra tenet, medium laeua Erigit Axem
 Cunctaque de membris viuunt natura Creantis
 et Cruce Complexum Christus regit undique mundum.

This is rich in consonant correspondence, four lines having three, and the third line four. The end-word of the first verse, *colendam*, finds its interlaced rime in *Dominum*, a perfect three-syllable rime in the course of the next line, according to Gaelic custom. The same holds good for *Eous*, with *iduo*. The next three end-words (*antae*, *axem*, *antis*) rime with each other, in double (broad and slender) vowel rimes. The last line possesses three-consonant correspondence, and in structure seems purposely varied so that its last syllable rimes with two internal syllables—*dum*, *us*, *um*.

Sedulius regards the head of the Cross as representing the East, and the other limbs as symbolising the other quarters

of the world. This must seem strange to those accustomed to take the North as the chief point. But by a curious coincidence the orientation he gives fits in exactly with Irish terminology. Thus the Gaelic word *soir* means the "east" and also "before"; the word *siar* means the "west" and "behind," whilst *deas* is the "right" and the "south."

These terms prove that the East was for the Irish the chief point: they faced the sunrise mentally—so it was before them, the west behind them, their left hand towards the north and the right towards the south. This governs the orientation of churches. Granting that this orientation existed elsewhere it is still a suggestive fact that Sedulius's symbolism can be so exactly illustrated by terms of the Irish language.

SECTION III

EVIDENCE BY DEFECTS

Yet another identification mark may be found in the following passage, taken, like that just cited, from the fifth and last Book of the *Carmen*.

Sedulius describes, with deep emotion, the incidents of the Last Supper, and the most horrid treachery of Iscariot; then, in a passion of wrath and indignation, he thus apostrophises the felon Apostle:

Tunc Cruente ferox Audax Insane rebellis
Perfide crudelis fallax Venalis Inique
Traditor Immitis fere Proditor Impie latro
Praeuus horribiles Comitaris signifer enses?

Here we have the concurrence of the consonants, *p*, *c*, *t* forming concord, and vowel initials also making concord according to the strict rules of Irish metric. Then also there are the numerous assonants of one, two, and three syllables¹

¹ The collocation of the letters *x* and *s* suggests a hissing execration.

and interlaced rimes, such as *rebellis*, *crudelis*, *inique*, *signifer*.

These are sufficiently striking characteristics, but there is another and a most singular identification mark to be found in the texture of the verses—namely in the accumulation of epithets. This vehement proliferation of the epithets is also to be observed in the prose text :

Tune igitur audax cruenta ferox rebellis et perfide, . . . tune traditor, latro, fere proditor immitis et impie, praeuius ductor, ac signifer, hostis comitaris horribilis aciem, etc.

Now, with respect to both verse and prose, this multiplication of epithets may be regarded as an exclusively Irish peculiarity. It has been repeatedly regretted and denounced as a fault in some later Irish mediaeval writers or reciters. In ancient classic Gaelic work it occurs infrequently and may be an ornament not a blemish. It is noticeable in a few of the lines ascribed to Amergin, the pre-Christian bard, it is evident in the terse quatrains of the sixth-century poet Dallan Forgaill, in this line for example :

Sgiat breac buarta breon.

It appears also in an ancient poem in praise of Beann Eadair (called "Hoved" by the Norse, and thence "Howth") as follows :

Cnoc longmar lonnmar lionmar
Beann fionmar fonmar agmar.

It is more plentiful in the "Roman Vision," a historical poem of the middle of the seventeenth century. Just as Sedulius breaks from his epic reserve into a passion of invective at the mention of Judas, so does the later Irish bard break from his historical restraint into a passion of eulogy, when Eogan Rua O'Neill is named, thus :

Dreacac dualac duanac deirceac,
Feasac, fuadrac, fuadac, feastac,
Gaisgeadac gluasda, gruagac gleasda
Lannac, luatmar, luainneac, leimneac.

There are two other quatrains in this style. As for prose parallels these are too common to need more than a reference.

No evidence could be more conclusive and convincing than this concurrence of intrinsic and extrinsic characteristics, where not only the peculiar inwoven melodies of the metric but the very faults of style combine to demonstrate the Irish nationality of Sedulius.

SECTION IV

THE COUNTER TEST AND CONCLUSION

The lyrical "Hymn of Sedulius" seems to have won all hearts at once, and to have retained them through all times and climes. It is now, however, better known by its first line, "*A Solis ortus cardine*," because the world has forgotten the poet's name, whilst enjoying the poet's gift. This lyric consists of twenty-three strophes, each composed of four lines, like the ancient Irish quatrains, in each of which the sense should be complete. This Celtic custom had already been adopted by Hilary and Ambrose. After the Hebrew fashion, the poem began with the first letter of the alphabet, and each stanza that followed took another letter in due succession. This custom was a favourite not only with ancient Irish hymn-writers, but with minor bards of the last century. Another characteristic is alliteration, or what one might term letter-rime. Consonants are classified, and each finds concord within its class. Vowels are classified, and each rimes only in its class, but alliterates with all vowels. See above, p. 213, etc.

These are the opening quatrains of the Hymn of Sedulius and it will be at once seen that they conform to these ancient Irish rules :

*A solis Ortus cardine
Ad Usque terrae limitem,*

Christum Canamus Principem
natum Maria Virgine.¹

Two vowels alliterate in each of the first two lines, and two consonants in the third. Another most interesting fact is the existence of internal link-rime, as one may call it, which is an exclusively Irish characteristic, and so passes unperceived by those not versed in ancient Irish poetry. Thus, *cardine* rimes with *usque te*, and *canamus* with *natum Mar*—indeed *tu cardine* rime, by vowels, with *ad usque te*—whilst *canamus prin* also assonate exactly with *natum Mari*. These rimes are found precisely where one may find similar rimes in ancient Irish verse. Finally we have here the great Celtic character of vowel end-rime, in this case dissyllabic, on the letters *i*, *e*—*ine*, *item*, *ipem*, *ine*. Sometimes the consonants also rime.

It was exceedingly difficult to cast the Latin into such a Celtic mould, and one must not expect that subsequent quatrains should show the same exactness. The second quatrain reads :

beatus auctor seculi
seruile corpus induit,
ut carne carnem liberans
ne perderet quos condidit.

The final *s* of the first word, as it precedes a vowel, served to alliterate with the initial of *seculi*; the difficulty is overcome in the same way in the second line. In the third and fourth lines two consonants, *c*, *c*, and *q*, *c*, alliterate. As regards link-rime, *seculi* rimes with *seruile*, and *nem liberans* with *perderet quos*. There are trisyllabic *e*, *u*, *i*, and *i*, *u*, *i*—*seculi* and *induit*—end-rimes closing the first two lines; the poet ends the first, second, and last lines by a monosyllabic echo in *i*.

¹ Which may be thus imitated :

All from the Orient dawning day
Until the Earth's remotest ray,
Sing Christ our King, in harmony,
The Virgin Mary's progeny.

Two other quatrains may be quoted, as examples :

hostis Herodes impie,
Christum venire quid times ?
non eripit mortalia,
qui regna dat caelestia.

There are two letter-rimes in the first line, *h, h* ; two in the second, *c, q*, and two in the fourth, *q, c*. In the third *n* and *m* belong to the same class. Link-rime is found between *impie* and *venire*, and between *pit morta* and *regna dat* ; whilst there is trisyllabic end-rime in the first couplet on *i, i, e*, and dissyllabic in the second on *i, a*.

The next quatrain gives the triple vowel end-rimes : *viderant, praeuiam ; lumine, munere*—and the next : *personat, pignora ; milia, victimam*. In the following quatrain, besides internal link-rime, there is trisyllabic end-rime in the first couplet, and dissyllabic in the last. Both the final vowels and consonants rime in the last couplet :

lauacra puri gurgitis
caelestis agnus attigit,
peccata, quae non detulit,
nos abluendo sustulit.

This tway-letter¹ rime, vowel-and-consonant, now commonly identified as "rime," occurs four or five times in the hymn. It is found likewise from time to time in ancient Irish verse ; but the Celts who used it knew how to employ the more varied assonant, which less fatigues, whilst gratifying, the ear. They also were the first to employ blank verse.²

Having thus tested these quatrains of Sedulius by the rules of ancient Irish metric, and found them ring right, the conclusion is obvious. But though this examination is sufficient in itself, there is fortunately a counter-test possible, which should set the question of the nationality of Sedulius at rest for ever. It might, for instance, be fancied (without foundation) that his method of verse-structure was common

¹ "Tway-letter" is used when one letter is a vowel and the other a consonant.

² See *Bards of the Gael and Gall*, London, 1897.

to the Latins and other peoples. To this I answer that every modification which others made in his Hymn, with a view to amend it, proves their ignorance of his art, because it strikes out some Irish characteristic. Every change was an offence to the Irish ear and method.

Thus Bede and the Mozarabic Breviary read *et usque* instead of *ad usque*; this alters the full alliteration between two broad vowels to one less satisfactory (though permissible) between a slender and a broad vowel.

Again Sedulius wrote :

paruoque lacte pastus est
per quem nec ales esurit.

The distinguished Latinists who revised the Roman Breviary in the time of Urban VIII. objected to the adjective, and "amended" the first line thus :

et lacte modico pastus est.

This alteration expunged the alliteration of the consonants *p, p* ! Worse happened when the Parisian Latinists in their Breviary wrote :

et indiget lactis cibo.

Not only was the alliteration lost, but the dissyllabic vowel end-rimes were destroyed !

Let us look at another quatrain where the Latinist revisers came into collision with the Irish poet. In the quatrain which should, in alphabetical order, begin with the letter *h*, Sedulius wrote :

hostis Herodes impie
Christum venire quid times ?

Judged by the Latin ear this seemed erroneous. Instead of *hostis* forming, as it should, an iambic foot, or at least a spondee, which would be permissible in this metre, it was held to make a trochaic foot. Arevalus fairly pleads that the aspirated initial of *Herodes* was equivalent to a consonant, and left *hostis* a spondee. Sedulius had clearly the Irish habit of sounding the *h* fully, from which the Romans fell

away. However, the revisers thought to set things right by altering a few words, and this is what they made of it :

crudelis Herodes, Deum
Regem venire quid times ?

How rapidly the Irish characteristics have vanished ! Not only is the alphabetical order infringed by the omission of *hostis*, but the careful alliteration (*h, h, c, q*) is destroyed. Then the end-rime is spoiled, for the broad *u* does not rime with the slender *e*, in the final syllables, and this is done gratuitously, not coerced by any exigency of sense or language to which even the poet should bow.

The Latin ear was gratified by the extinction of a suspected quantity, but the change would have jarred cruelly upon the attuned ear of the Irish poet. Nothing could better demonstrate that the characteristics which have been pointed out were of Irish introduction than the fact that the Latinists were not conscious of the subtle inlaid rimes which they so rapidly annihilated.

THE *ELEGIA* OF SEDULIUS

This poem, which begins with the words " *Cantemus Domino,*" is written in elegiac verse, with this peculiarity, that the first part of the hexameter is repeated as the second part of the pentameter, with the meaning modified. Composed for singing, it is a song, and as it is also in praise of God, it is a hymn, according to the definition of Saint Augustine. It has the exceptional character of being a hymn in classic elegiac metre.

This hymn obtained great celebrity, especially in England, because of St. Dunstan's Vision, which, according to Eadmer, he beheld in St. Mary's Chapel of St. Augustine's Church. In this vision of great beauty he saw the Blessed Virgin, surrounded by a multitude of fair young maidens who were chanting this hymn. The Virgin herself began by singing the first two lines to a most celestial melody, which was con-

tinued by the fair choristers singing the subsequent lines, as they moved around her in choral procession.

These are the opening lines :

Cantemus socii Domino cantemus honorem,
 dulcis amor Christi personet ore pio,
 primus ad ima ruit magna de luce superbus,
 sic homo, quum tumuit, primus ad ima ruit.
 vnus ob meritum cuncti periere minores,
 saluantur cuncti vnus ob meritum.
 sola fuit mulier, patuit qua ianua letho :
 et qua vita redit, sola fuit mulier.

These lines (there are 109 in all) may be represented by the following imitative version :

Come let us sing to the Lord ! come all, let us sing to his honour !
 Let our voices arise, chanting the sweet love of Christ !
 First Pride fell to the deeps, down far from the splendour of heaven
 Thus man grown arrogant down to the deeps also fell.
 Then thro' the merits of one henceforth his descendants should perish
 But men all were redeemed through the high merits of One.
 Woman alone oped the gate, giving death to disconsolate mortals,
 That which gave again life oped was by woman alone.

This metric mode was not peculiar to Sedulius, but had been rarely used : the Greeks called it "epanalepsis" (repeating) ; it has also been named peracteric, reciprocal, ophite, or serpentine—doubtless from the old symbol of the serpent with its tail in its mouth (imaging eternity). But this *Elegia* of Sedulius gained for this rare and obsolete mode a new popularity among poets, and it was imitated by Fortunatus, his admirer, by Sidonius and others, and curiously enough by Irishmen.

Dr. Shahan acutely observes : "Is it not remarkable that the peculiar Irish rhyme of the Sedulian distich-hymn Cantemus should have been imitated in the early Middle Ages by Irishmen only ? The proof of it is in some letters of the Irish Colony at Liège published by Dümmler, in two of which we have the perfect Irish refrain. Sedulius Scotus also frequently used this rhyme" (? metric). These are the citations :

sumite Scottigenam devota mente benigni
o vos Francigene, sumite Scottigenam.

omnia Christus habet, per Christum cuncta reguntur,
mentior haud vobis, omnis Christus habet.

It should confirm the statement, that this metrical mode was popular among Irish writers, to learn that an example is extant in the Gaelic, and I think no other non-classic language possesses a similar example.

Dr. W. K. Sullivan, in his monumental Introduction to Professor O'Curry's great pioneer lectures, says that "possibly the chanting of psalms, antiphonies, etc., that St. Aldelm speaks of . . . in Glastonbury was introduced by the Irish monks." Sir Samuel Ferguson, in his erudite Essay on the Origin of the Harp, quotes the undoubted authority of Gerbert to the following effect: "To this period we may refer the Antiphonary of the Monastery of Bangor" (Ireland) "whence St. Columbanus coming forth, with St. Abbo his companion, not only imbued our Germany with the light of the Christian faith, but also with the principles of ascetic living. . . . Doubtless, the first rule for arranging ecclesiastical services amongst us, as made up of psalms, canticles, hymns, collects, and antiphonies, was hence derived."

We shall next consider how and by whom such hymns were produced.

APPENDIX III

CELTIC INFLUENCE ON THE EVOLUTION OF RIMED HYMNS

IN the time of Sedulius, the Church, emerging from the gloom of the Catacombs when the storms of persecution ceased, began—like a bird when sunshine falls on its wings after a tempestuous night—to uplift its voice in joyful songs of praise.

This was a new sound in the Latin world, and it is significant to note that it began not in the capital but in Celtic Gaul and appeared next in Cisalpine Gaul. It is equally significant that the first two hymn-writers, St. Hilary and St. Ambrose, were Gauls by birth. Hence as regards the Western Church we see that hymns passed into its service from its Celtic frontier.

Nor should it be counted as strange, for, by the reports of Caesar, Pliny, and Strabo, the bards or poets had long occupied a position of great dignity, power, and influence amongst this Celtic nation. They could precipitate wars, and arrest armies in their march; they were indispensable to kings, chiefs, and assemblies. In almost every respect they resembled the bards of Erin; and when we find that, in the Celtic Isle, the first Christian hymns imitated certain of the peculiarities of Celtic verse, it is reasonable to infer that a similar course was followed on the Celtic mainland. The civilisation of the Celts influenced even the warriors who had defeated them, and that influence must have been felt by the students of the flourishing schools of Gaul, many of whom became dis-

tinguished as poets, rhetors, orators, teachers, and office-bearers in Rome and the Provinces. In the fifth century, when hymns began to be heard in the Western Church, Gaul could count twenty-four of her sons as Latin poets.

We all know that the Eastern Church had a different history as regards hymns. The great spiritual enthusiasm of the Hebrew nation was a fount of lyric poetry, from the triumph-song of Moses to the Magnificat. By St. Paul's Epistle we find that the Colossian Christians made use of psalms, hymns, odes, and spiritual songs. The service of Song, therefore, passed directly into the Eastern Churches. Pliny found the Bithynian Christians chanting with antiphons, before day-dawn, to Christ the Lord. The Church of Antioch adopted it, at the suggestion of St. Ignatius, in the first century. These examples were multiplied in the East, and religious songs, in Syriac and in Greek, were sung and published. The Greeks used several of the classic metres, and, in the fourth century, St. John Chrysostom had processional hymn-singing, with lights, in the night hours.

If, as some have conjectured, the Service of Song came to the Latins from the East, then it should surely have passed over during early centuries of intimate communion. If, during three hundred years, there was no such transfusion, then the presumption bears against the Eastern source.

On the other hand, we have the admitted fact that the first Christian hymn in Latin was composed by St. Hilary of Poitiers, known as "Hilarius Gallus"—Hilary the Gaul—a Celt by race. Now there are distinct traces of the Celtic metric (or rime-system) in this hymn, as shall be demonstrated—but first, let us see if such a rime-system in hymns can be traced to any other source.

I. NO HEBREW SOURCE

The Hebraic psalm metres did not leave a legacy of rime. In 1898 the University of Vienna awarded the Lackenbacher prize to R. Nivard Schloeg O.C. for his work. "De re

metrica veterum Hebraeorum," which states and criticises the views held as regards Hebrew metric. The ancient writers, including St. Jerome, considered it similar to Greek metres, and recognised (with some peculiarities) iambic, alcaic, sapphic, hexameter, and pentameter verse. Cardinal Pitra and many others differ, recognising a resemblance, but noting a structural difference; so that there are four views with respect to Hebrew metric. One bases it on quantity, a second on number, a third on accent; and a fourth on quantity and accent. Schloeg, following Zenner, holds it proved that the Hebrew psalms were composed of strophes and antistrophes sung by two choirs.

II. NO GREEK SOURCE

The oldest extant liturgical manuscripts known went back no further than the close of the fifth century, until the discovery, by Prof. G. Bickell of Innsbruck, of a papyrus of an earlier date. This document he found among the papyri of the Archduke Rainer in 1887. It was alleged to be two centuries earlier than any one previously known, but Wessely, who notes it as "popular" Greek, regards the writing as of the fourth century. It is very simple in structure and without rime:—

ὁ γεννηθεὶς ἐν Βηθλέμ
καὶ ἀνατραφεὶς ἐν Ναζαρέτ
κατοικήσας ἐν τῇ Γαλιλαίᾳ
εἶδομεν σημεῖον ἐξ οὐρανοῦ·
(τῷ) ἀστέρᾳ φανέντας
ποιμένες ἀγραυλοῦντες
(οὖ) γονυπεσόντες ἔλεγον
δόξα τῷ Πατρί, ἀλληλουῖα
δόξα τῷ Υἱῷ καὶ τῷ ἁγίῳ Πνεύματι,
ἀλληλουῖα, ἀλληλουῖα, ἀλληλουῖα.

Some ten years later Cardinal Pitra discovered, in St. Petersburg and in Moscow, Greek manuscripts of a much more recent period, containing hymns, not of classic structure,

but depending on syllabic number, accent, and apparently rime.

These, however, may have been written after the revival of Greek in Europe by St. Columbanus, and perhaps by some of his disciples.

III. NO SYRIAN, NO AFRICAN, NO ROMAN SOURCE

Suppose we go further afield and, searching the confines of the Roman Empire, take in writers born in Syria and in Africa.

Strange to say it is here that something may be found resembling rime—as a child's caricature resembles a human face. Commodianus Afer was born in Gaza, and wrote in the middle of the third century. The persecution of the Christians, whose faith he adopted, may partially account for the imperfection of quantity in his rhythmic hexameters, but even the best spiritual intentions can hardly excuse the composition of a poem of twenty-six lines, when every line ends with the same letter *o*!

This may by some be called rime—the Chinese have a similar system which pleases them, or their poets—but properly speaking it is no more rime than the reiterated tapping of one note on the piano is tune. It results in a monotonous noise painful to any cultured ear, but intensely odious to a Celtic accustomed to the subtle interwoven melodies of the Celtic art. Here is a specimen of the verse of Commodianus :

incolae Caelorum futuri cum Deo Christo,
tenente principium, vidente cuncta de caelo.
simplicitas, bonitas, habitet in corpore vestro—
irasci nolite sine causa fratri devoto.
recipistis enim quidquid feceritis ab illo.

And so he proceeds, with excellent precepts, to the close of over two dozen miserable monotones.

Aurelius Augustinus, better known as St. Augustine (354-430), has sometimes been mentioned as a writer of rimed

verse. This refers to his poem against the Donatists. In reality it is nothing better than a repetition of the system of Commodianus, though here the terminal vowel is not *o* but *e*. These lines may serve as an example :

abundantia peccatorum solet fratrum conturbare,
propter hoc dominus noster voluit nos praemonere.

Verecundus is the only subsequent author who follows this method of riming long on one syllable. St. Augustine indeed speaks apologetically of his verses, written that they might be remembered and sung by the "poor and ignorant," not as a literary effort. They do not present the genius of St. Augustine, but his charity.

A contemporary, Victorinus, an African, who was a distinguished teacher of rhetoric at Rome, composed some hymns, when he became a Christian, about the year 372 ; but they do not rime, though they display more promising germs of sound-echoes than the verses of Commodian. To show how remote they are from the methods introduced into Latin by Hilary, I may quote some examples of Victorinus. One hymn begins :

Adesto lumen verum, pater omnipotens Deus,
adesto lumen luminis, mysterium et virtus Dei.

Another begins :

Miserere, Domine, miserere Christe, miserere Domine,
quia credidi in te, miserere, Domine, quia misericordia tua cognovi te.

Each strophe opens with similar words, but the strophes are very irregular as regards length. He seems to have imitated the psalms. In a third, where a similar irregularity is seen, each line closes with the words, "o beata Trinitas," and is therefore an early example of a refrain or burthen-line, but there is no proper systematic rime, though there is repetition of the end-syllables of some lines :

Deus Dominus, Sanctus Spiritus : o beata Trinitas,
Pater Filius, Paracletus : o beata Trinitas.
praestator, minister, divisor : o beata Trinitas.
Spiritus operationum, Spiritus ministeriorum,
Spiritus gratiarum : o beata Trinitas.

This may have been intended as a litany, and been used as such, but could in no manner have served as a model or precedent for the rimed Latin hymns, which soon came to be heard throughout the Christian world. The Hebraic, Grecian, Roman, Syrian, and African sources having been found empty, we now turn to the abundant Celtic fountain.

IV. THE CELTIC SOURCE

Fortunately the verse-examples of Commodian, Augustine, and Verecundus fell sterile and dead. It would be a nice question to decide how great an obstacle to the spread of Christianity, through musical nations, would have been the adoption of such methods. Perhaps it would have been the more welcome in Africa and China, but its divine ceremonies would have been mute, without service of song, among many western peoples, had such repellent systems been attempted, and for sake of these monotonous methods the world would have lost a treasure of beautiful and noble hymns.

In the face of such a danger, in presence of such a fact, it seems as strange as it is amazing that the Celtic peoples, who introduced the system of musical metric, and who initiated and developed the new hymnology, should have obtained not merely no gratitude but absolutely no recognition. Yet without them Commodian might have conquered, and a great light have never gladdened the Christian world.

The first writer of a hymn in Latin was a Celt, known as Hilarius Gallus, or Hilary (now St. Hilary) the Gaul. He was born at Poitiers, became a bishop, and through Arian influence was banished, in 356, to Asia Minor; where he took refuge in Phrygia. The sorrows of exile, which refine and exalt noble souls, made him a poet, and he sent, a year or so later, to his daughter Abra, a copy of his new and beautiful hymn, "*Lucis largitor Optime.*"

Although this hymn is composed in classic metre, it bears, in my opinion, distinct traces of the bardic system of verse-structure. I refer not merely to end-rime, which is usually

alone considered, but also to internal and vowel rime. These resemblances have not hitherto been noticed because hymnologists generally were ignorant of Celtic, but I venture to suggest that St. Jerome (who knew something of Celtic, for he recognised it when spoken in Galatia) had some of these characteristics in his mind when he described Hilarius as wearing the Gallic buskin (cothurnus).¹

Be it noted that the hymn is framed in quatrains, which was an Irish-Celtic system, and that there are instances of alliteration (or letter-rime) as well as of syllable-rime. Of two versions of the first quatrain I take that which more completely shows the Celtic characteristics :

Lucis Largitor *optime*,
cuius sereno *Lumine*
Post Lapsae noctis *Tempora*
dies *refulsus* Panditur.

MAJOR CONCORD.—Here we find alliteration in the first two lines, with perfect vowel end-rimes in the last three syllables.

In the second couplet we have internal interlaced rime between "tempora" and "refulsus"; there being one "slender" vowel and two "broad" vowels² in each word. The concluding word of the quatrain rimes in its last syllable with the last syllable of the third line, both possessing broad vowels *ra*, *ur*. There is alliteration: *l*, *l*, *l*, *l*, and *p*, *t*, *p* in the quatrain.

The second quatrain supplies similar signs, with alliteration of three: *l*, *l*, *l*.

tu verus mundi *Lucifer*,
non is qui parui *sideris*
venturae Lucis nuntius
augusto fulget *Lumine*.

¹ The cothurnus was the buskin on the classic stage which was suited to the personage. St. Jerome's phrase solves the mystery of "the Irish brogue." Foot-wear seemed irrelevant to speech; yet "bróg" is simply a buskin; hence the phrase, "he uses the Irish brogue" (bróg) has a classic origin, as already noted, p. 26.

² The slender vowels *i* and *e* rime; the broad vowels *a*, *o*, *u* rime in Irish metric; but they must be pronounced as in Italy or Spain.

The final two-syllables of the first, second, and fourth lines assonate perfectly, and the end-word of the third line obtains exact internal or interlaced rimes in the fourth line, *fulget lu*. There is even five-syllable rime in the last distich. With internal rime the quatrain is remarkably rich, for *mundi*, *parui*, *lucis*, *fulget* all rime in both syllables.

The fourth quatrain is equally noticeable :

*adesto rerum conditor,
paternae lucis gloria,
cuius admota gratia
nostra patescunt corpora.*

The rime is carried even further here, as there is trisyllabic rime with five-syllable internal or interlaced riming, for *mota gratia* assonate perfectly with *nostra patescunt*. All the last syllables rime by their vowels. There is also alliteration : *c, p, p, c*.

The rime-system, which this hymn reveals, is too elaborate and methodical to be the result of chance, especially as it closely follows certain principles of verse-structure preserved in ancient Irish metric.

Another hymn has been questionably assigned to St. Hilary ; but, though it rimes more obviously, it lacks the finer finish of the first. We have alliteration (or concord) between initial consonants and between initial vowels, with sectional rime :

*ad Caeli Clara non sum dignus sidera
leuare meos Infelices Oculos,
grauī depressos Peccatorum Pondere ;
PARCE REDEMPŦIS.
bonum neglexi facere quod debui,
probrosa gessi sine fine crimina,
scelus patraui nullo clausum termino ;
SUBUENI CHRISTE.*

In addition to internal and end-rimes, it will be observed that the fourth line assonates completely (syllabically) with the eighth. Thus in these two lines one broad vowel *a* rimes with one broad vowel *u*, while there are four slender rimes in *e* and *i*.

The rime-system shown in these specimens is more subtle and refined, and elaborate—as in Irish metric—than anything that can be cited from Latin poets, such as the obvious end-rimes in some verse attributed to Ennius, and the sporadic leonine rimes noticeable in Ovid and others. The case is still stronger against the Christian poets, Commodianus, Augustine, and Verecundus.

After St. Hilary, St. Ambrose comes next, in point of time, as a hymn-writer; greater than his predecessor, no doubt, but that does not lessen Hilary's glory as a pioneer. Their verses shine the brighter by contrast with the attempts which have been mentioned, and both these poets were Gauls by birth. Ambrose was born, about the year 370, at Treves, where his father ruled as "Praefectus Praetorio Galliarum." His youth was passed in a Celtic atmosphere. He is supposed to have written his treatise, *De moribus Brachmanorum*, for Palladius, a Greek, who was afterwards sent by Pope Celestine to Erinn as bishop to "the Scots believing in Christ."

When, at the age of thirty-four, Ambrose was chosen Bishop of Milan, he was still in a Celtic atmosphere, that of Cisalpine Gaul. Soon after Augustine came to Milan there came Justina's order for the banishment of Ambrose; this caused the faithful to watch, night and day, in the Church, so that they might protect or die with their beloved Bishop. Then, it is stated, psalms and hymns were first sung in the Church to alleviate the anxiety of the people. The practice so begun, in the year 386, happily continued. But, although this was the first time that hymns were sung in a Church in Italy, it does not follow that hymns had not been previously sung in Churches in song-loving Gaul. Doubtless hymns of St. Hilary were sung from earlier days.

St. Ambrose is known to be the author of four hymns, and others are ascribed to him with more or less certainty. Archbishop Trench,¹ comparing the former with the mediaeval

¹ *Sacred Latin Poetry*. London and Cambridge, 1864.

hymns of Bernard and Adam of St. Victor, notices their coldness and proceeds :

The absence, too, of rhyme, . . . adds to this feeling of disappointment. The ear and the heart seem alike to be without their due satisfaction.

Had this distinguished prelate been as intimately acquainted with the Irish language as with others, his ear would have quickly detected traces of Celtic rime in these verses which seem rimeless to readers in general. Let us take, for example, the hymn which he quotes from St. Ambrose, and note how it is enriched by the elusive Celtic vowel rimes and consonant correspondence :

veni, Redemptor *gentium*,
ostende partum Virginis ;
miretur omne saeculum :
talis decet partus Deum.

Taken as a Celtic quatrain, we find that, in the first line, the vowels, *o, e, i, u*, rime exactly with the first vowels of the second line, *o, e, e, a*. In the last two lines there is also interlaced rime between *omne* and *talis*. There are also three terminal tway-letter rimes in *um*. The second quatrain reads :

non ex *virili semine*,
sed mystico spiramine,
verbum Dei factum est *caro*
fructusque ventris floruit.

Here there is triple vowel rime in the first line, *virili* and *semine*, in the first distich, two double end-rimes ; in the second distich, major and interlaced concord, and the quatrain has three slender end-rimes.

Again observe :

procedit e thalamo suo,
pudoris aula regia,
geminæ gigas *substantiæ*
alacris ut currat *viam*.

There are here terminal and internal rimes, now, however,

the end-rimes are on the vowels, *i*, *a*. Is it possible not to perceive the intentional rime, in the entrance-words of the following quatrain? The first two lines rime in every syllable throughout, and the second two in five syllables :

*egressus eius a patre,
regressus eius ad patrem,
excursus usque ad inferos,
recursus ad sedem Dei.*

The rime-method is changed, but this not seldom occurred as an art-method in ancient Irish Celtic poems ;¹ however, we look here only for traces of Celtic influence, not for all its characteristics.

In other hymns of Ambrose rimes are much more irregular, accidental, or absent. In the following lines rime is obtained by repeating syllabic and letter sounds, but also be it noted, the last syllables of the first, third and fourth lines (*or*, *ra*, *um*) are perfect vowel rimes in the first quatrain and in the second, the method is exactly alike (*at*, *us*, *ans*). This shows system. There are sufficient internal rimes, and alliteration :

*aeterne rerum conditor
noctem diemque qui regis,
et temporum das tempora,
ut alleues fastidium,
praeco diei iam sonat
noctis profundae peruigil,
nocturna lux vianibus,
a nocte noctem segregans.*

Other Ambrosian verses, printed in the Pisaurensis Collection, 1764, supply examples with consonant as well as vowel rime, and are thus more obvious to moderns, but the internal and alliterative rimes are liable to be lost. In this morning hymn however they are present :

*somno refectis artubus,
spreto cubili surgimus ;
nobis, Pater, canentibus
adesse te deposcimus.*

¹ *Bards of the Gael and Gall.* London, Fisher Unwin, 1897.

THE EASTER SONG

Te lingua primum *concinat*,
 Te mentis *ardor ambiat*,
 ut *actuum sequentium*
 Tu, Sancte, fis *exordium*.

Pope St. Damasus, who was born a year before St. Hilary died, appears to have been distinctly influenced by that Celtic poet in one of his many short poems. For that to St. Agatha clearly possesses end-rimes, and others :

martyris ecce dies Agathae
 virginis emicat *eximiae* ;
 Christus eam sibi que *sociat*
 et diadema duplex *decorat*.

stirpe docens, elegans *specie*
 sed magis actibus atque *fide*,
 terrea prospera nil *reputans*,
 iussa Dei sibi corde *ligans*.

It was at the very Morning-time of Song—whilst Milan Cathedral was still surprised with new melody—that the poems of Sedulius made their appearance. That they were welcomed, with honour, is plain from the fact that not only was his Hymn adopted, but also other verses composed in metres not usually associated with singing.

This was the case as we infer from Eadmer's *Latin Life of St. Dunstan*, which mentions the *Elegia*, beginning " Cantemus Domino " in alternate hexameters and pentameters. Though the Greeks employed the heroic metre in Church Service the Latins seem to have avoided it, as a general rule, to which there is at least this exception. Another indication of the great favour shown to the verse of Sedulius is found in the fact that his Epic, the *Carmen Paschale*, supplied the " Introit " on several Festivals. Considering that the Introits are usually passages from Holy Writ, this exception stands out as an honour shared, so far as I know, by no other poet.

Two other beautiful and celebrated hymns have the name of Sedulius associated with their authorship. One is the hymn for Passion Sunday, " Vexilla Regis." Rocca says that some ascribe this hymn to Ambrose and some to Theo-

dulphus, some to Fortunatus,¹ and some also to Sedulius. This is the first quatrain :

Vexilla Regis prodeunt,
fulget crucis mysterium :
qua vita mortem pertulit,
et morte vitam protulit.

What strikes one immediately is that the turn of thought, the form of phrase, and the system of rime are identical with those found in the undoubted work of Sedulius. The first couplet recalls the line in the *Carmen Paschale* :

en signo sacrata crucis vexilla coruscant,

Bk. i. l. 337.

and the mystic symbolism of the Fifth Book by which he shows the Redeemer—"Pax Crucis," the Peace of the Cross, embracing the world, and making what had been the Sign of Death to be the Sign of Life. If the hymn be not of Sedulius, it must have been written by a close student of his work.

Antonius Lacharias, an eminent authority, assigns the noble hymn, "Pange Lingua," to Sedulius, with praise ; another writer would ascribe it to Fortunatus.² It begins in the following manner :

Pange lingua gloriosi
proelium certaminis,
et super crucis trophaeo
dic triumphum nobilem.

qualiter Redemptor orbis
immolatus vicerit,
de parentis protoplasti
fraude factor condolens, etc.

In the first couplet there is alliteration between two consonants, *p, p* ; in the second also, *t, t* ; in the third between

¹ Fortunatus was born a century after Sedulius ; Theodulphus lived much later, in the days of Charlemagne.

² And to Claudianus Mamertus in *Hist. littér. de la France* : Bénédictins de St. Maur.

two vowels, *o*, *i*. In the last couplet quoted there is alliteration in each line. Inlaid and end-riming are traceable likewise.

This hymn passed through the hands of the Latinist revisers, who substituted "lauream" for "proelium," whereby they possibly improved the sense, but certainly destroyed the alliteration, *p* with *c*, and so testify to its Celtic origin. It is rather against the claims for writers later than Sedulius that the Council of Tours (A.D. 567) desired that the names of authors of hymns should be stated, whereas this hymn is anonymous.

St. Patrick was born five years after St. Hilary's death, and was a contemporary of Ambrose and Damasus; he spent much time in Gaul as well as in Ireland. In the Cotton MSS. a hymn is ascribed to him, which displays triple end-rimes. But I do not think it belongs to that time. It begins thus :

Constet quantus honos humanae conditionis
scire volens, huius serie videat rationis
non hominem verbo solo deus effigiavit,
quem facturus erat sic quomodo cuncta creavit.

He was, however, more distinguished, as a poet, in the Irish than in the Latin language and has the glory of being the first to write a hymn in a non-classic tongue, and one too of exceptional vitality, originality, and power.

From a former work ¹ I quote what follows : "The fifth century, which gave St. Sedulius and St. Patrick to letters, gave also St. Secundinus, a nephew and contemporary of the latter. His verses in praise of St. Patrick betray the influence of the bardic schools. Zeuss drew attention to some (end) rimes sprinkled through the verses (as "*omnes amantes*") but I would point to other and yet more remarkable signs, such as alliteration and internal rime, these are so characteristically Gaelic that they readily escape general notice. Take the opening lines [of which the first has

¹ From *Bards of the Gall and Gael*, Introduction. London : Fisher Unwin.

three initial vowel rimes, and not only two but three end-rimes, whilst there are three double internal rimes, *Audi, omnes, mantes*]:

Audite omnes amantes
Deum sancta merita
uiri in Christi beati
Patricii episcopi,

quomodo bonum ob actum
simulatur angelis
perfectamque propter uitam
aequatur apostolis.

In the first couplet, *amant* and *sancta* rime; in the second, *ati* and *atri*. In the third couplet *actum* and *atur* have the same vowels, and in the fourth *vitam* and *aequa* have similar vowels. Some consonants, too, reappear. The last two syllables of the first, third, and fourth lines in the first quatrain rime. In the second quatrain there is alternate monosyllabic end-rime. The Bards varied the metre, occasionally, in Irish.

"Sancti, Venite" the celebrated post-communion hymn, is attributed to the same bard. Angels are said to have sung it in his church at Bangor. It is constructed on a Gaelic model. Here, however, five-syllabled lines alternate with those of seven syllables. To the ordinary eye or ear, there must seem little or most imperfect rime in the following stanza. Once, however, it is tested by the standard of Irish verse-structure, the perfection of the riming is made clear:

Sancti Venite,
Christi corpus SUMITE:
sanctum bibentes
quo redempti SANGUINEM.¹

¹ The internal and interlaced rimes being always overlooked, I would invite attention to their completeness here. Thus, we have "nite" with "Christi," "corpus" with "sanctum," and "bibentes," with "redempti." Then there is alliteration and double vowel end-rimes in all four lines, and triple vowel end-rimes in every alternate pair—a melodious marvel.

There is linked rime in the first couplet, between the two "slender" vowel-sounds (*ie* and *iū*); and in the second between the three similar sounds (*iee* and *eei*). The last words of the second and fourth lines rime with equal completeness—each having one "broad" and two "slender" vowels (*uie* and *aie*). Here is another stanza where, at first glance, there appears to be no rime, except in the letter *m* of the second and last lines. It unfolds its perfection to the Gaelic test :

lucis indultor
et saluator OMNIUM,
praeclaram sanctis
largitus est GRATIAM.

It is only necessary to point out that in the last words of the second and fourth lines there is perfect vowel-rime, according to the Gaelic rule, between *oiu* and *aia*. The bard was not always so successful, sometimes he ekes out his rime, and sometimes forgoes it; but it is so elaborate that its presence proves purpose.

In the sixth century St. Columbcille, a bilingual bard, contributed Gaelic and Latin verse. His "Altus," a famous hymn of old, was composed in trochaic tetrameter as Bede notes. A writer, in the ancient "Lebor Breac," distinguishing between "artificialis" rhythm, with feet of equal times, equal divisions, and equal weight, "arsis" and "thesis," and "vulgaris" rhythm, where there is correspondence of syllables in quatrains and half-quatrains, says the hymn is composed in this popular rhythm. It is noteworthy that these characters are those of the Gaelic stanza. St. Columbcille uses trisyllabic rime, well known to the Gael, and occasionally obtains internal chimes :

altus prositor uetustus
dierum et ingenitus
erat absque origine
primordii et crepidine.

In another octosyllabic hymn he also employs four-syllable rime, where consonants sometimes chime :

noli pater indulgere¹
tonitrua cum fulgure
ac frangamur *formidine*
huius atque *uridine*.

Twenty years later St. Columbanus flourished, a fine classic scholar, to whose efforts and example the revival of classical literature, and especially of Greek, on the Continent was largely due. Though Columbanus composed in classic metres, he did not fail to introduce Irish alliteration, internal, and final rimes, *e.g.* :

dilexerunt *Tenebras Tetras* magis quam *lucem*,
imitari Contemnunt vitæ Domini *Ducem*.

Even his charming poem to Fedolius, so praised for its pure latinity (quoted in an Appendix to the *Bards of the Gael and Gall*), I have shown to possess systematic vowel rime throughout.

St. Columbanus was educated at the famous Monastery of Bangor (*rectè* Benchur) in Ulster. Now the Antiphonary of Benchur, one of the most ancient Manuscripts of the Universal Church, is still extant in the Ambrosian Library of Milan,² to which it was brought from Bobio, where St. Columbanus had preserved it. Its date is fixed with certainty in the period between 580 and 591.

This Antiphonary or Service-Book contains many pieces of an earlier date, such as St. Hilary's Hymn, and amongst them is a delightful and most interesting pious Song called "Versiculi Familiae Benchuir," or "Versicles of the Benchur Family" (or Community).

¹ *G* and *c* are pronounced hard in Irish.

² *The Antiphonary of Bangor : An Early Irish Manuscript in the Ambrosian Library at Milan.* Henry Bradshaw Society, London, 1893. In his Introduction the Editor states he considered it a privilege and an honour, to be accepted "as the Editor of this priceless monument of ecclesiastical antiquity." "It is one of the oldest Service Books of Western or indeed of Universal Christendom. Neither England nor Scotland possesses any liturgical MS. nearly so old as this relic of the Ancient Celtic Church of Ireland."

It has the distinction of being the first of all College Songs—too few in number—of which “Gaudeamus” and “Dulce Domum” are types.

It is also, I think, a Parent-Poem, which has had offspring characterized by less complexity of structure, greater freedom and rimes more easy for general recognition and adoption—a model for modern rime. Not that it lacks the correct and typical characteristics, for it does possess them. Take for example the first quatrain :

Benchuir Bona *regula*
recta atque diuina
 Stricta *sancta sedula*
Summa iusta ac mira.

The alternate triple and double syllable end-rimes are obvious. Not so obvious, but perfectly distinct are the concord or alliteration of the consonants, *bb*, *rr*, *sss*—the internal interlaced rimes, *regula* and *recta at*—the concord in the second couplet of the initial *s, s* carried on to the last line, and the crowning internal correspondence of *sancta*, *summa*, and *iusta*, interwoven rimes.

These finer qualities, including others such as the correspondence in classed consonants, were gradually lost among strangers, whilst the more obvious end-rimes remained, a permanent though impoverished possession.

VERSICULI FAMILIAE BENCHUIR¹

Benchuir bona *regula*
recta atque diuina
 stricta *sancta sedula*
summa iusta ac mira.

Munther benchuir *beata*
fide fundata certa
spe salutis ornata
caritate perfecta :

¹ “Benchur,” a Gaelic name (now Bangor, near Belfast), becomes Benchuir in the genitive. In the second quatrain we have “Munther Benchuir” (the “Family of Benchur”), where the first word is written phonetically to suit Latin singers.

navis nunquam turbata
 quamuis fluctibus tonsa
 nuptis quoque parata
 regi domino sponsa.

domus dilicis plena
 super petram constructa
 necnon uinea uera
 ex aegypto transducta.

certe ciuitas firma
 fortis atque munita
 gloriosa ac digna
 supra montem possita :

Christo regina apta
 solis luce amicta
 simplex simulque docta
 undecumque inuicta

uere regalis aula
 uaris gemmis ornata
 gregisque christi caula
 patre summa seruata.

virgo ualde fecunda
 haec et mater, intacta
 leta ac tremebunda
 uerbo dei subacta :

cui uita beata
 cum perfectis futura
 deo patre parata
 sine fine mansura.

Benchuir bona regula :

I quote once more from the Introduction to the *Bards of the Gael and Gall*.

In the seventh century flourished the poet-saints Ultan, Cummain, and Colman.

The structure of the hymn of St. Ultan, in honour of St.

¹ This quatrain, partly illegible, begins :

Area hirubin tecta

Brigit, is exceedingly curious and interesting. The riming has escaped attention because of its very profusion. The editor of the *Liber Hymnorum* saw only "assonances" in the middle and end of each line, with possible alliteration.¹ Take the first two lines :

Christus in nostra insola quae vocatur hibernia
ostensus est hominibus maximis mirabilibus.

This gives but a meagre monosyllabic rime. Rime, though concealed, is amazingly abundant. In the first line, for instance, there are three trisyllabic internal rimes, as here shown :

in-nostra insola quae-voca.

In the second line there are also three :

ostensus ² homini maximis.

In the first line the rimes run on one " slender " and two " broad " vowels : in the second this is ingeniously reversed, and the rimes are formed of one " broad " and two " slender " vowels. In addition, I would point out that the lines terminate in trisyllabic vowel rime, for *bernia* and *bilibus* correspond in sound. Curiously enough, they supply a third combination, having two " slender " vowels first and one " broad " vowel. And there is an extra four-syllabled rime, for *hominibus* is in full assonance with *abilibus*. The third line reads thus :

que perfecit per felicem celestis uite uirginem.

The trisyllabic rimes are five ; but here all are yielded by the slender vowels :

perfecit per-feli cem-cele tis-uite uirginem.

St. Ultan's hymn may be the source of the popularity of the verses known as " Tripudiantes."

¹ His omission is doubtless due to the fact that, following Zeuss, his attention was only given to the observation of end-rimes. A new edition of the *Liber Hymnorum* has since appeared, in which the editors deal with the matter more minutely.

² The last syllable preceding a vowel is short, and the vowel is regarded apparently as sufficiently slender.

St. Cummain Fota's hymn is noticeable by its alliteration and trisyllabic rimes :

celebra iuda festa Christi gaudia
apostulorum exultans memoria.

In the eighth century St. Cocuimne (who died A.D. 742) employed both vowel and consonant rime, with alliteration, in a manner most dear to the Gaelic bards of Munster a thousand years later. It is not necessary to italicise the rimes in such verses as these :

bis per chorum hinc et inde collaudemus Mariam
ut uox pulset omnem aurem per laudem uicariam,
Maria de tribu iudae summi mater domini
oportunam dedit curam egrotanti homini.

These are even more remarkable :

Maria mater miranda patrem suum ededit
per quem aqua late lotus totus mundus credidit.
tonicam per totum textam Christi mater fecerat
quae peracta Christi morte sorte statim steterat.

If we arrange two lines in the form of the Irish quatrain, it will be seen how completely they conform to its rules :

Maria miranda mater
patrem suum edidit,
per quem aqua late lotus
totus mundus credidit.

His contemporary St. Cengus, son of Tipraite, makes use of woven rime with like liberality in his hymn to St. Martin. As written the lines are :

Martinus mirus more ore laudavit deum,
puro corde cantavit atque amavit eum.

Here we see the rimes, but not the system, until we arrange the lines as a Gaelic quatrain :

Martinus mirus more
ore laudavit deum,
puro corde cantavit
atque amavit eum.

These examples suffice to show to what extent, and with what ingenious skill, Celtic characters were impressed upon the new art of Christian hymn-writing and also how diversified were the forms of metric adopted. In the course of time and in less erudite hands the more subtle and refined Celtic characters of Concord and Correspondence, restricted alliteration and hidden harmonies became effaced, as the lighter lines of an engraving wear out, and nothing remained but the deeper and more manifest profiles—terminal or end-rimes. These were occasionally of one syllable but were often of two or more riming syllables, sometimes riming by the vowels only (assonantal) sometimes by the consonants also.

This mode of reduplicated rime still remains a distinctive character of the verse (even in English) of Irish writers, as compared with English verse, in general. Thomas Moore employs it, and has borne reproach for it. He has even been called un-Celtic in form! As his words were cast in the music mould of Irish metric and emerged bearing its imprint, the rebuke is amusing.¹ Readers whose ears have not been attuned to classic Gaelic verse might imagine its melody would be marred by its rules, but the contrary is the case. Fortunately this can be shown in English. By an amazing and admirable happening, Thomas Moore, apparently influenced and guided by the ancient Irish melody to which he wrote words, un-

¹ In his Introduction to ancient Irish poetry, Prof. K. Meyer made the curious statement that "the original type from which the great variety of Irish metres has sprung is the catalectic trochaic tetrameter of Latin poetry, as in the well-known popular song of Caesar's soldiers :

Caesar Gallias subegit, Nicodemus Caesarem :
ecce Caesar nunc triumphat qui subegit Gallias."

Now Caesar found the Gallic Druids well versed and long-trained in poetry on his arrival, and the Irish bards were not less so ; it is incredible, therefore, that the native verse of either should have only then sprung from a type in a foreign tongue, sung by enemies—and the more incredible because it was disreputable and popular with conquering foes. This statement abides with a preceding assertion that : "By the fifth century the Gaulish language was everywhere extinct"—which is inexact.

wittingly produced a quatrain.¹ This is the first in the "Song of Fionnuala" whose exquisite melodiousness every vocalist knows :

Silent, O Moyle, be the roar of thy water,
Break not, ye Breezes, your chain of Repose,
While, murmuring mournfully, Lir's Lonely daughter
Tells to the night-wind her Tale of woes.

Vocalists know and appreciate its music, but the cause of that music is that it is cast in a pure Gaelic mould. This has never been analysed, until now, when noticed. The first line contains four internal rimes, on broad vowels, and the effect of this is relieved and intensified by the slender vowels of the first word. The second line, has obvious alliteration (*b, b, r*.) and internal rime. The third line is very rich ; four consonants *m, m*, in the first half, and two more, *l, l*, in last, all alliterate, while there is perfect three-syllable-internal rime in "murmuring mournfully." In the final line, there is alliteration of consonants, *t, t*, and internal rime of vowels in "night-wind." But mark in addition, there is not only varied tway-letter (consonant-vowel) end-rime, but there is alternate assonantal entrance-rime, for "Sile-" rimes with "while" and "Break" with "Tells." No example so complete as this have I found, but there are remarkable echoes as in :

*The Harp that once through Tara's Hall
The Soul of music Shed
Now Hangs as mute on Tara's Wall
As if that Soul were fled.*

Here clearly are alliterative, internal and interlaced rimes. It has been alleged that Moore's double rimes were unsuitable for great subjects. Such objections only prove that the critic has been trained in different methods and has acquired alien ears, by nature or by education.

This very Irish character of dissyllabic riming has, strangely enough, been most markedly impressed upon the

¹ Moore's father was a native of Kerry, where Irish was generally spoken and sung

Latin hymns. It seems the very exquisite expression of joy and delight in the Christmas Hymn "Adeste, Fideles," and in the exultant Easter hymn :

O filii, et filiae !
rex caelestis, rex gloriae,
e morte surrexit hodie !
Alleluia !

But then, what more stately than this Irish mode, what more solemn than its sound in the "Dies irae" with its alliteration and double end-rimes ;

Dies irae, Dies illa
Solvat Seclum in favilla
teste David cum Sibylla.

Or what more expressive of sorrow or more replete with poignant pathos than the Stabat Mater :

stabat Mater dolorosa
iuxta crucem lacrymosa
dum pendebat Filius.

APPENDIX IV

A PHYSIOLOGICAL STUDY

ON CERTAIN SPECIAL SENSES AND DOMINANT QUALITIES OF NATIONS : TIME-METRIC AND RIME-METRIC

PART I

SPECIAL SENSE CHARACTERS OF MEN AND NATIONS—SIGHT—
COLOUR SENSE : PARTIAL AND COMPLETE COLOUR-BLIND-
NESS — FORM-SENSE — POWER-SENSE — SPEECH : PARTIAL
MUTISMS : LETTER-DUMBNESS—HEARING : PARTIAL DEAF-
NESSES—TIME-SENSE—TUNE-SENSE—TIME-DEAFNESS—TONE-
DEAFNESS.

It is clear that the various races of mankind have not advanced always along the same lines of progress, nor with equal rapidity. Some go forward more in one direction, some in another, and when they lose ground, as seems ordained, this does not happen in a uniform manner. The evolution of the characteristic qualities of races has consequently, by differentiation, resulted in their acquisition severally of distinctive and varied gifts. The environment favours those which most develop : if it change, some may diminish or even be entirely lost—hence advance in what is called civilisation does not necessarily result in perfecting every gift or all qualities. The Indian, for instance, may have a much superior sense of sight and of smell to those possessed by citizens of great towns.

In each group, on account of special causes and heredity, there will be variations. This we should expect, to a greater extent, when two or more races come together and a larger group is constituted, which we name a nation. Its qualities become more complex. However, from the influence of common conditions of life, from intermixture, from greater numbers of one race, and from the prepotency of more energising qualities, certain distinctive dominant characters will attach to the entire nation, though originally composed of different races.

This granted, we may admit that certain functions of the human organism develop diversely in different races and nations, as we know they obviously do in different individuals. Where, in a given group, certain of these develop more generally and more prominently than in others, they become a distinguishing dominant character of that group, race, or nation. Taking the nation as an entity, this character might stand to it in the same relation as one of his special senses to the individual. Thus, the Athenians possessed, in their appreciation of perfection of form and expression, what we may call a Beauty-sense; whilst the Romans, though not devoid of this, had a predominant Power-sense; their special aptitude, as a people, was to organize and govern. Each of these groups was of course gifted with other national senses, more or less subordinate, undeveloped, or retrograding.

Adopting and elaborating the theory of a German writer, Mr. Gladstone once endeavoured to support the view that mankind, in the early ages, could not distinguish colours. He grounded his case largely upon adjectives of ancient writers, such as are seen in Homer and others, where the hues of flowers, for example, are not described as we would depict them.

This argument, however, was fallacious, for there is not one but two faculties involved: perception and expression. For it is quite possible to perceive differences and yet fail in expressing them. Even the lower animals may perceive differences of colour, and there is no reason to suppose that

man, however undeveloped, was not so endowed, especially when the knowledge of different colours in berries, for instance, meant pleasure or pain, and sometimes life or death to him.

On the other hand, if Mr. Gladstone had said, as I suggest, that different races or nations were diversely gifted as regards a colour sense, then surely our common experience would assert the accuracy of the proposition. Just as some individuals fail in colour-perception, so there are nations which have a very imperfect sense of colour as compared with others. Certain individuals do not discern some colour or colours : they are colour-blind so far ; but this has not been recorded as yet of any race or nation.

In the matters of speech and of hearing, we are less at a loss for exact knowledge. Every one is familiar with the fact that some individuals cannot pronounce certain letters, such as "th" or "r." Nations also have different articulation-powers. Thus, the Chinese cannot utter the letter *d* nor the letter *r*—they are therefore "letter-dumb" as respects these two letters. Sanskrit, like the Finnish, has no *f*, several Polynesian languages have no *s*, and the Hurons no labials. They are, therefore, "labial-mutes."

Here then are distinctive characters marking out a race, and even a nation.

The French cannot pronounce *th*, and substituted *z*. The *th* sound has distinguished the English speech amongst those of most nations, but it seems beginning to disappear locally ; in the London dialect it is replaced by *v* (*e.g.* "muvver" for "mother"), and the letter *r* is partially lost, as the guttural *gh* has been long lost, for the English are a composite nation of Celts, Norsemen, Angles, Saxons, and Normans. The *th* sound was gradually acquired by races which did not originally possess it, in accordance with the principle laid down of pre-potent characters, which may affect a language as well as a people.

Russian and Polish have sounds not found in other European languages. The Hottentot klick is characteristic.

Thus we have it that some nations possess the power of uttering articulate sounds not in use by others: some are letter-dumb for certain letters, others for others.

Similar differences are observable as regards perception of sounds. The range varies very greatly: some lose the higher notes more quickly and others the bass. There are some who cannot distinguish the factors of musical tone, intensity, pitch, and timbre or quality. There are in fact many persons—far more than is generally supposed—who cannot distinguish musical tone from noise.

That means that their hearing-organs cannot discriminate between periodic vibrations and non-periodic vibrations. They have no musical ear; they may indeed be taught to play the piano mechanically as an automaton could be made to play it, but they cannot reproduce the notes vocally nor pick up a tune by ear.

There are many who cannot distinguish one note from another; not a few who cannot tell one tune from another, yet some of these may perceive errors of time. These have the time-sense, but not the tone-sense.

There are even poets who write excellent verse, quite perfect in structure, rhythm, metre, and rime, who are devoid of this perception of tone. It may sometimes happen that their failure to appreciate the works of another poet, who enjoyed this faculty, is due to the defect of tone-sense in themselves.¹

Now all such persons are what I would call *tone-deaf*.

They are numerous, and it seems probable that not only individuals, but a race or even races may be similarly defective. Certainly, the sounds, not to say noises, which some races rejoice to hear, do not give pleasure to more musical peoples.

Now, let us consider some of the physiological bases of

¹ Thus I have heard Thomas Moore—who is essentially and admirably a tone-poet—depreciated and scoffed by some who were absolutely tone-deaf and could not distinguish one tune from another! One must determine a critic's qualifications. What weight would attach to the criticism of a picture by a colour-blind critic?

versification. It is within familiar experience that all persons are not equally qualified in this art.

There are even some, though they do not boast of it, to whom it is as alien as music is to others. Not only are they unfitted by defective organisation to take active part in it, but they are incapable of appreciating the gratification it yields to others better endowed by nature. More indeed are but partially defective. All persons, especially editors, experienced in the efforts of young versifiers, know how apt these are to fail in correctness as regards rhythm, time, and even rime. With untiring zeal critics, with faculties on the alert, weekly watch for lapses and rarely fail to find or to point them out. But successive generations of men and maids, beginning poetry, repeat such errors, not consciously but inevitably.

Their special verse-senses are imperfect, perhaps from undevelopment, perhaps from other causes. If we inquire farther we shall find that just as some can keep time who cannot keep tune, so some in verse can keep perfect measure who fail in making perfect rimes, while others who rime well may find it difficult to make proper measure.

There are, I hold, behind these facts certain special senses, whose inertness, perfection, greater or less development, are accountable for the phenomena mentioned.

That is to say, there is a Time-sense, a Rhythm-sense, and a Rime-sense.

If any be absent or defective, then we shall have more or less complete Time-deafness, Rhythm-deafness, or Rime-deafness.

Now my position is that as these Special Senses are differently distributed amongst individuals, so also are they differently distributed amongst nations. This opens a great question, and to show the differences properly would require vast research and a large volume; however, enough can be given to establish our foundations.

Take the Chinese, for example: Masham¹ says they

¹ Masham, *Chinese Grammar*, 1814, Serampore.

have tones and semi-tones, perhaps stress, but rime a long time on one syllable. In our terminology, they show they possess the Time-sense, and Rhythm-sense, but not the Rime-sense. For I would at once point out that the repetition of a syllable is no more rime proper than the reiteration of the same note on the piano or the tapping of a tam-tam is tune. The repetition of the same sound would become odious to any ear but one which was Rime-deaf or Tune-deaf.

In Sanskrit, Colebrooke¹ notes, there are two kinds of metre, one governed by the number of syllables, usually uniform but often arbitrary in passages of the Vedas, the other by feet, but only one sort is admitted as so regulated. This is Arya, and is frequently used, *e.g.* in Nalodaya. There is rime here, for at the end of each hemistich the four last syllables are the same in sound though differing in meaning. In Damayanti's Lament on the desertion of Nala, there is an example of this :

Tatra, padé vyálinám
at'ha vibhrántam vané cha dévyá, 'linam
tánu vündé vyálinám
Tatin dad 'háné, tayá 'spadé vyálinám.

The next verse rimes upon another word (sit'áyá) and the next upon another. We have here vowel and consonant rime, but no diversity, so that the effect on the ear grows monotonous, though the wits are kept awake, by the play upon the words. This mode of versification shows the possession of comparatively well-developed Time, Rhythm, and Rime-senses. It is, however, difficult to fix dates, for Sanskrit works, which were generally supposed to be of great antiquity, are now held by Continental scholars to date from after the Christian era.

The Persian verse shows the possession of similar qualities as in this Ghazel of Hafez : ²

¹ Colebrooke, *Asiatic Researches*, vol. x.

² Sir W. Jones, *Asiatic Researches*, vol. i.

Rūnēki ahdī shēbābēsī degner bostanra
Miresed muzshdehi gul bulbuli khush elhanra.

Ei seba guer ba juvanani chemen baz resi
Khedmeti ma veresan seru gul ou uhanra.

In this ghazel every *beit* (or *distich*) ends with a word terminating in "anra." The versification displays the possession of the senses of time and rhythm, but the riming produces a similar monotonous effect to the Sanskrit from the reiteration of like dissyllables, which here are repeated ten times as there are ten *beits*. Mohammed Shemseddin, commonly known as Hafez (man of memory), lived and died so late as the last half of the fourteenth century.

Muratori quotes a few Hebrew lines, where the terminal syllables coincide in sound.

When we pass from Asia to Europe, we at once confront two markedly distinct schools of versification: one that of the Greeks (and after them the Romans) is characterised by its quality of time or measure.

The construction of verse, based on this principle, became a fine art, in which the subtlest skill was used to produce the desired results, whilst combining variety with continuity. What variety, for instance, in hexameters which linked together by certain characters are so capable of changing effects! But, doubtless, moderns cannot obtain or even conceive the extreme pleasure which the ancient Greeks and Latins with their faculties so specially developed then enjoyed.

Their Time-sense must have been equivalent to the Tune-sense of musical artists, and their verses to us, moderns, are like flowers whose beauty we admire, but whose fragrance we barely feel.

The other School of Verse method was that of the Celts. The Gauls, said a keen observer, most industriously pursue two things: military matters and polished speaking. Their Druids, who were also Bards, held the highest place in the state, they cultivated poetry with extreme assiduity, learning great quantities by heart; by their songs they incited armies to battle, and could stop them in mid-career. They studied

in colleges for a score of years. It was thought their institution had come from Britain, and to Britain they at times resorted for further studies.

Caesar found a similar people in the South of Britain, when he landed, and the character, appearance, manners, and the extant remnants of Gaulish language prove them to have been a people identical in race with some of the ancient Irish. The position and training of their Bards or Druids were essentially the same as those of the Irish. Hence we may legitimately infer that their verse-methods were practically identical with those of our ancient Bards which by happy fortune escaped, as theirs did not, obliteration by Roman domination.

Now the Celtic School of Verse, as shown by the ancient examples of this island, was pre-eminently a School of Tune-methods. It knew of Time and Rhythm but these were not the dominants. The term Rime to modern or foreign ears, most faintly, most inadequately, indicates the marvellously refined and intricate methods of interwoven sounds which they created, not the mere repetition of a sound, but the reiteration of portions of a sound and semi-similar, semi-dissimilar sound, so that in a verse, you shall hear in rime fundamental tones and over-tones, full notes and faint, shadowy, suggestive, and elusive echoes which nothing resembles, which can be likened to nothing, if not to the sounds which the hidden bugle calls from the mountains around Killarney when on a still evening the echoes roll, recede, swell, faint, and die away in exquisite aerial melody.

CURIOUS SCIENTIFIC DISCOVERY

The ancient Celtic poets had a most highly developed Rime-sense, adapted for the most refined sensations and exquisite results in rime-picturing. As regards its higher and more delicate powers, that Rime-sense has been largely lost. It was, we may assume, developed to its wonderful perfection by the long training which the bards underwent, but the

capacity for subtle analysis and distinction must have been there, and correctly there, for it must astonish one to discover that these ancient bards made a classification of letters of the alphabet which, differing from that of grammarians, corresponds with the results of most recent scientific research.

Thus grammarians group the vowels together, the bards divide them into two classes, the broad *a*, *o*, *u*, and the slender *i* and *e*. Between members of each class they recognised a certain similarity—a correspondence—which does not exist between members of the different classes.

This may seem artificial and groundless to those to whom a vowel is a vowel. But observe how it harmonizes with modern science. Von Helmholtz has pointed out that if you sing the vowels one after another, determining the over-tones by the aid of resonators, one over-tone is specially characteristic for *a*, for *o*, and for *u*, whilst *e* and *i* have each two special characteristic over-tones! Thus we find that the broad vowels *a*, *o*, *u* are musically related, and that *e* and *i* differ from the others and are musically related. This confirms and justifies the law that *i* and *e* can rime together but not with *a*, *o*, *u*, which rime together.

As regards the classification of consonants which corresponded they exhibited equal acuteness; thus *p*, *b*, *f*, and *v* form one group, and Brucke classifying by articulation-positions, places the first two as explosive labials, and the second as aspirate labials; both belong to the first position.

The bards had another group *t* and *d*, and Brucke classes these two letters as explosives of the second position.

Another Irish group includes *k*, *g*, *ch*, *gh*, and Brucke for the third articulation-position gives *k* and *g* as "explosives" and *ch* as "aspirate."

Surely these parallelisms between the results of recent research and the analytic methods of the bards are marvellous and indicate an amazing degree of auditory and mental keenness.

PART II

TWO GREAT SCHOOLS OF VERSE: THE TIME-METRIC AND
THE RIME-METRIC—DOMINANT PRINCIPLES

Two great Schools of Versification, therefore, were contemporaneous in Europe, one the Greco-Roman, characterised by its dominant principle of Time-measure, another the Celtic, characterised by its dominant principle of sound-echo or rime. The nations had their special senses of Time and of Rime developed severally, to a predominant degree.

There may have been exceptional instances, but generally speaking the Greco-Romans were or became rime-deaf, and the Celts more or less Time-dull—not completely deaf for some exact idea of measure or Rhythm was needed—but comparatively when the highly developed classic system is in view.

It is no evidence to the contrary that some sound-echoes are discernible in Greek and Latin verse. Their purposive character must be proved. Though there are sporadic instances here and there, it is manifest that rime is never used as a "Kunstmittel" and essential element of verse-technique. As to the fact that occasionally words re-echo it would be practically impossible to prevent it; in the theory of probabilities, where nouns, adjectives, or verbs are used which have at times similar endings, two of them must sometimes coincide. But it does not follow that rime was intended, nor does it follow that the writer was conscious of any chiming. This suffices for the rare instances to be noted in the works of Homer and Propertius and Horace.

In illustration, let us take a line from the prose version of the second Psalm.

"Why do the heathen rage, and the people imagine a vain thing?" Now here is a perfect hexameter, as has been noted—and I would point out that, as it is certain the translator did not intend it, the metre passed unperceived by him. He

would have detected it at once had it been rime (to which his ear was attuned), but his time-sense was not so acute. So, conversely, Greeks and Latins may have accidentally and unconsciously happened on rimes and passed them unperceived. When detected by a critic such as Quintilian (*e.g.* "invisae visae," "fortunatam natam") they were condemned; orators and authors, he said, should avoid the negligence of allowing similar syllables to end one word and begin the next.

In Greek tragedians such repetitions very rarely occur, but something may be said for verses in Sophocles cited by Sir Alexander Croke, which run as follows:

ἐπιβαίνοντες, τὸ μὲν εἶπωμεν
τὸ δ' ἀκούσωμεν
καὶ μὴ χρεῖα πολεμῶμεν. *Oedip. Col.* 189.

αἶρετ', ὀπαδοί,
μεγάλην μὲν ἔμοι
τούτων θέμενοι
ξυγγνωμοσύνην
μεγάλην δὲ θεοῖς ἀγνωμοσύνην. *Trachiniae*, 1266.

Similar in some respects, and probably imitative were the rimed lines of the archaic Latin poet Ennius (b. 239, d. 169 B.C.). Born in Calabria, he was half Greek half Oscan, but more Greek than Latin in culture. For he followed immediately on Livius Andronicus, a Greek of Tarentum, who, taken captive at its siege, is regarded as the founder of Roman poetry, drama, and literary language. He translated the *Odyssey* of Homer, and his tragedies and comedies were taken from the Greek. So also Quintus Ennius borrowed from Euripides, and the rimed passages which follow may well have been imitated from those of Sophocles. His poetry was admired by Cato, under whom he made the Sardinian campaign, by Scipio also, and it was praised by Cicero in his *Tusculan epistles*.

Probably his achievement in transplanting Greek metres

into Latin moved Cicero to give his adaptation of a Celtic quatrain. Both Virgil and Horace recognised his merit. He was a pioneer in Latin poetry. Putting away the rude irregular Saturnian verse (though still occasionally retaining alliterations) he introduced the hexameter and the Greek metric and methods generally.

These are the lines which Cicero quotes (*Tusc. lib. i. sect. 28*) :

caelum nitescere, arbores frondescere,
vites laetiferi pampinis pubescere,
rami baccarum ubertate incurvescere.

He quotes also the last three lines of the following passage. To be in proper perspective it must be seen in its place, as part of his tragedy of *Andromacha Aechmalotes*. In his usual (unrimed) verse the widow of Hector deplores her fate : helpless, hopeless, homeless. The temples of the gods in flames, her country ravaged, nothing remains but blackened ruins. Then suddenly comes her most pitiful apostrophe to her slaughtered Father, her Country, the once glorious Home of Priam, whose blood now stained Jove's Altar, which she beheld, and saw the City in flames, and that horrible agony—her dead Hector dragged behind a chariot, and Hector's Son—her Son—a child flung down from the ramparts.

In the last lines, the verse changing is rimed—like a rimed Irish dirge. This is the apostrophe :

o pater, O patria, O Priami domus,
saepum altisono cardine templum !
vidi ego te astante ope barbarica
tectis caelatis lacuatis
auro ebore instructam regifice.
haec omnia videi inflammare ;
Priamo vi vitam ovitarei,
Iovis aram sanguine turparei.
vidi, videre quod sum passa aegerrume,
Hectorem curru quadriiugo raptarier,
Hectoris natum de muro iactarier.

It seemed to me at first sight, that there was a hope that these rimes were a reminiscence of old native Italic methods, but nothing justifies it. They are an imitative wail. Naevius,

a contemporary, the first really Roman poet, a man of noble mind, shows no trace of native method. No doubt Niebuhr did great pioneering work in calling attention to the pre-existence of native mind-work, and is not entirely shaken by Taine and Paul Albert, but the remnants discovered—the songs of the Salians and of the Arvales—bear no trace of rime, and little of literature.

In any case the rime-experiment of Ennius (if it were such) failed of acceptance, and the metric of conquered Greece conquered the victor Roman and attuned the Latin ear. Of his successors, it must be remembered that Catullus and Virgil¹ belonged to the Cisalpine Gauls (as did Livy and Pliny the younger). Horace and Ovid, it is true, were southerners; but Ovid was long in exile amongst the Scythians, and learned the language of the Getae and Sarmatians. Virgil, in his more passionate passages, appears to recall ancestral impulses in vowel and consonant correspondences. But, all considered, there was nothing like systematised rime, nothing but a chance chime. Where, as in Propertius, there seems a purposed (and strained) echo, it is evidently artificial, an affectation, or a curious *préciosité*. The genius of the time-metric dominated all Latin verse in its great age.

Now, admitting the existence of two great Schools of Verse-making, of the Time-school and the Rime-school, the question next arising is—Was there any means of contact between them or any possibility of the Celtic influencing the Latin verse?

Every one would of course assume readily the possibility of the Latin influencing the Celtic. For we are all in our youth made vassals to Athens and Rome. Each generation of us goes through their streets to school, and looks with dismay to the frontiers, where hangs a dark cloud of “barbarian” foes—our own Forefathers! We are even worse than the Greeks and Romans, for they recognised the valour, virtue, and intelligence of their occasional adversaries. They

¹ Zeuss has pointed out that the name Virgil is Celtic, properly Fergil; its later form is Feargal (pr. Farral), meaning a brilliant man.

studied their character, customs, costumes, and rites, borrowed from them not rarely, whilst we generally imagine there was no more intercommunion than between day and night.

Remember that, six centuries before the Christian era, the Greek founded a colony at Marseilles, with Celts as their friends, a century later Herodotus describes their territory, yet another century and Aristotle describes their manners and customs, while Pytheas of Marseilles voyages north to Britain.

Remember, that, about 590 B.C., a century and a half after the foundation of Rome, a swarm of Celts crossed the Alps and founded Cisalpine Gaul. Two centuries later began that series of Celtic invasions which so imperilled the city. A portion of the Cisalpine Gauls swept down in 390 upon Clusium and Rome, which they entered, and the Capital itself would have fallen had it not been for the alarm given by its classic Geese—always hostile to the Gael.

The besieged offered a great ransom in gold—it was then that Brennus (their Brenn or Brehon) threw his sword into the scale, crying (with due alliteration): “*Vae victis.*”

In 367 the Gauls or Celts invaded Alba; in 362 came another invasion, when the *tumultus Gallicus* was proclaimed, and every man had to take arms.

Then Manlius (an earlier Malachi, or Maelseaclan of Tara) got the title of Torquatus, because in single fight he won a “collar of gold from the proud invader.” This was the Celtic Torque.

The fourth invasion followed in 359, and the fifth in 350.

An unresting race, more adventurous than avid, the Gauls, sweeping eastwards, sent an Embassy from the Adriatic to Alexander; they mortified his pride, for on being asked what they feared most, they did not reply politely that they feared him most, but with frank irony, that they “feared nothing but that the sky might fall on them.”¹

¹ Remembering that the lark was the Gallic symbol one might ask if the derisive saying, “When the sky falls you shall catch larks,” be traceable to this speech?

In the third century B.C. they marched into Greece and menaced Delphi, crossed the Hellespont and made a settlement in Phrygia, called first Gallo-grecia and afterwards Galatia, where the Celtic Torque was known and worn, and where their descendants still spoke Celtic in the days of St. Jerome.

Then came the Roman outflow. Again, the *tumultus Gallicus* was proclaimed, every man was called to arms, and Cisalpine Gaul was subjugated, but the Celts remained.

A century later, the legions go into Transalpine Gaul, and some fifty years before our era, Caesar had Celtic nobles in the Roman Senate, and the Gallic Lark flying aloft beside the Eagles, symbols of pacified peoples. Their merchants could visit the Celtic lands and Isles, their Geographers map out our ports, towns and rivers, imperial Caesar, and Cicero his friend, study the institutions of the Celts and the functions of their Druids. When wave on wave of these nations had flowed alternately into each other's territory, it is impossible not to infer intimate communications between them. Their learned men were manifestly not ignorant of each other.

If we turn from wars to letters, we shall see that this inference is more than confirmed by a profusion of instances. Take the century and a quarter which preceded the Christian era; it was a Celt, Lucius Plotius, who was the first, the earliest teacher of rhetoric at Rome, and Cicero regretted that he had been too young to hear him. But he (after the forum) and young Caesar studied under the Celt Gniphio, a grammarian and rhetor, and they heard the great Celtic actor Roscius. They both knew and esteemed Divitiacus¹—who became a Roman Senator—chief Druid-bard of the Aedui (people of Autun), and with him they studied the knowledge of the Gauls, their divine mysteries and divination. From him, as I have shown elsewhere, Cicero may have learned something of the Celtic art of verse; for we find that certain of his verses, which seem ridiculous to the Latin, fall into regular Gaelic moulds.

¹ This is a latinised form of the Celtic name Dubhtac, pronounced Duvtac.

C. Valerius Priscillus was a Celtic ambassador of Caesar's. There were also Celtic poets writing in Latin, as Caius Cornelius Gallus (who was appointed first Roman Governor of Egypt), Publius Terentius Varro, Voltienus Montanus, three distinguished orators and historians, mathematicians, philosophers, and rhetors. Germanicus and Claudius were both born at Lyons, the Roman Capital of Gaul—and the latter made a memorable discourse in favour of Gallic Senators.

The first century of the Christian era was equally crowded with distinguished names. Many Celtic nobles went to Rome to hear Livy, and their own great Schools of Autun and Marseilles and Lyons became famous. Amongst the poets are the names of Montanus (who won the displeasure of Tiberius), of Petronius, of Antoninus Primus, who kept up a correspondence with Martial, and acted as his Maecenas. There are fifteen other names known of men distinguished as orators, rhetors, jurisconsults, physicians, or philosophers.

The second century yields about the same number, of whom one, St. Augurinus, a poet, was raised to the Consulate, Paulinus became Senator, and Favorinus shone at Athens, a famous Sophist.

In the third century the state of literature declined, but about the same number of notable names appear, many of Christian saints, martyrs and bishops; amongst them St. Irenaeus, a Doctor of the Church. The Celt Julianus Tatianus teaches literature to Maximin, son of the Emperor Severus, and eloquence at the Schools of Lyons and Besançon. Treves now became the usual seat of the Emperors and Prefects of the Gauls (which included Britain and Spain).

In the fourth century, the Celtic poets became profuse panegyrists of the Emperors, as some of our own later territorial bards became eulogists of their chiefs.

There is a multitude of names, some of men illustrious by their works. Of these the most remarkable were St. Hilary, who was born at Poitiers, in 305. He was exiled to Phrygia in 356, and the year following sent home hymns to his daughter. He was allowed to return in 360.

He is regarded as the first hymn-writer of the western Church.

Ausonius, another poet, was born in 309, four years later ; his mother was of the Aedui (of Autun), like Divitiacus, and his father a physician from near Bordeaux. There he began to teach in 330, and in 345 he held the chair of eloquence, and so great was his renown that he was called to take charge of the education of Gratian, by whom he was ultimately appointed First Consul.

Another and a more eminent contemporary, St. Ambrose, was a Gaul by birth, having been born in 340 at Treves, where his father resided as Prefect. In 374, St. Ambrose became bishop of Milan (the old Capital of Cisalpine Gaul) ; on two subsequent occasions, at least, he visited Gaul, once in 383 on a friendly mission to Maximus, whom he stays from proceeding to Italy, and with whom he makes peace in the name of the young emperor ; next he came, four years later, to ask him for the body of Gratian, which was refused him. Icarius, to whom St. Augustine dedicated his book, may have been born in Spain, but his father was a Gaul. It is worthy of note, in conclusion, that St. Athanasius lived for three years in banishment at Treves.

It is, assuredly, most remarkable that the two poets whose names are associated with the first Christian Latin hymns were Gauls by birth, Hilary and Ambrose, and both lived amid a population of Celtic origin.

THE END



